

Hist 210 Modern European History

Numbered Transcript

HIST 210 • Dr. Robert Tombs

Contents

Lecture 1. Roots of Reason

Lecture 2. Conflict in the Age of Reason

Lecture 3. Industry and Innovation

Lecture 4. Imperial Impact

Lecture 5. World War I Era

Lecture 6. World War II Era

Lecture 7. After the Wars: Europe Divided

Lecture 8. Efforts Toward Unity

Lecture 1: Roots of Reason

At a glance — Tombs on the roots of reason — the Enlightenment.

- 1.1 Well, good morning, ladies and gentlemen. I'm here to talk about, and you're here to listen to, a series of lectures on Europe, which I've subtitled Rise and Fall. There are changes in how we think about European history, which have been going on for some years now. When I was a student, I studied an option called The Expansion of Europe, and that seemed a perfectly natural thing to call it. We wouldn't talk about that nowadays. We wouldn't at least call it that. But it seemed at that time that the history of the world, at least the history of the modern world, was about how Europe had expanded to occupy and to influence, to control, a large part of the world and had permanently changed its history.
- 1.2 A famous Cambridge historian said, "Africa has no history until the Europeans arrive there." That was the assumption, which we now know was wrong. But it looked as though the history of Europe had become the history of the West, and in a sense, had become the history of the planet in modern times. Hence, at the end of the Cold War, and I'll come to this in a later lecture, a famous essay was written by Francis Fukuyama called The End of History. It looked as though European culture, European values, European ideas, had triumphed once and for all. And that meant, effectively, that there was going to be no more change. That was the end of history.
- 1.3 But for several years now, we've been much less confident, less arrogant. And now people talk very much about decolonization, the removal of European influence in the world, about the provincialization of Europe, making Europe seem far less important than it used to be. People demand reparations for damage done in the past. Apologies. The return of artifacts from European museums, which once claimed to be, still in theory claimed to be, world museums, that these things should be returned from Europe to their places of origin as a reparation for what is usually called theft or looting. And in Europe itself, plenty of signs of economic, political, and cultural decline.
- 1.4 So we could think of this story as a Greek tragedy in which the hero, Europe, is finally brought down by his own failings. But were there only failings? Or should we still respect Europe's record? Should we still see in it things to value and, if necessary, to defend? And that, I think, is what much public debate is about at the moment. Or, of course, we could take a different view and say, well, look, we're not talking about ethics or politics or ideology. We're talking about history, and history is about what happened and why things happened. Not about morality. We're not talking about who the good guys and the bad guys were.
- 1.5 And after all, no other continent faces this critical scrutiny. We don't ask about whether Asian culture should be deconstructed because of bad things that have happened in Asia. We don't say, well, should Africans renounce their culture and their history

because of their willingness to sell Africans into slavery over the centuries? We don't ask questions like that of other continents, only about Europe.

- 1.6** We could say, well, we shouldn't talk about this kind of thing. We should talk about just history. Let's stick to the facts, things as they really happened. I certainly will, I hope, be talking about that sort of thing, what happened, why it happened. But I think it's impossible to avoid the fact that this has become a very controversial topic. Although I shan't be preaching a message, or at least I hope not much of a message, I shall come back to this whole question in my final lecture on what we should think about Europe's history.
- 1.7** Now, I suppose the obvious place to start is by saying, well, what is or was Europe? Seems a very simple question, but it's not quite so simple. If you look at the map of the world, which shows European ancestry today, it looks pretty well as though most of the world is either inhabited by the descendants of Europeans or was governed by them at some time or another. But what is this Europe? This is not what we mean by it. We don't mean Europe is all parts of the world in which the descendants of Europeans live. We don't think of Patagonia or New Zealand as being part of Europe. So what do we mean by Europe?
- 1.8** The original meaning of the word was that part of the world that is to the northwestern side of the Mediterranean. The idea of Europe as an entity, as a civilization, based on the Greco-Roman tradition and the Judeo-Christian tradition, really emerges from the 15th to the 18th centuries, when Europeans become aware of other cultures which are not their culture. So the idea of Europe as distinct becomes accepted.
- 1.9** And then in the 19th century, the idea of Europe as the controlling force in world history, and as the representative of some common civilization, becomes very common. This is what I shall be calling in my lectures Europe's Century. So then people can talk about the concert of Europe, meaning the agreement between European states. And people like Mr. Gladstone, the British liberal, could talk about the conscience of Europe being outraged, as if there was such a thing as a collective conscience for a whole continent.
- 1.10** In the 19th century, the idea of a controlling civilization. In the 20th century, well, certainly a decline from that position to one of disaster and decline. And yet, and this will be one of the topics of my final lecture. Today, the European Union and its supporters still talk of embodying European values and even talk of Europe being, I quote from a recent EU document, "a community of destiny." So Europe is still becoming, in their view, and that's something that I'll be looking at, too. There are lots of ideas about what Europe actually is. And I have only 8 lectures, and I'm going to pick out what seemed to me to be the key themes and not to summarize the whole story, which you can, after all, get from any textbook. So I'll be picking out the things that seem to me important and interesting.

- 1.11** The lectures I'll be giving, which I'll just run through very quickly, the first two, under the general heading of Europe and the Origins of Modernity, 1688 to 1815—first of all, From Religious Wars to Enlightenment, which is this lecture, and then, second lecture, A Century of War and Revolution. Then the second two lectures, the general heading is Europe's Century. The first lecture called Cities, Factories, and Nations, and the second lecture, Empires and Globalization. Then the second half of the course, The Decline of Europe. The first lecture, The Seminal Disaster, 1914 to '36. Then the Near Death of Europe, 1936 to '45. Then post-war, the Cold War and the End of Empires, and finally, A United Europe: Destiny or Illusion? And then some general reflections on what it all means.
- 1.12** But I'm beginning now at a point at which I think probably few historians would begin, perhaps none apart from me, which is around 1688. Why then? Well, four reasons, I think. First of all, it marks the end of the last religious war in Europe. Europe for the previous 150 years had been racked by religious conflict, as you will know, and the English Civil War, the British Civil Wars, were the last of all those civil wars or those religious wars. And this was finally brought to an end in 1688 by the largest invasion until D-Day, the largest sea-born invasion until D-Day, by William of Orange, the ruler of the Netherlands, who, with an army, invaded England, with the consent of most people in England, and got rid of the last of the Stewarts, and ended religious conflict of a very extreme kind.
- 1.13** That was of importance for Europe, as I shall say in a minute, but there are other reasons, too. Oh, I shouldn't—let me quote Voltaire, the great 18th-century French philosopher who said, and they realized that something was going on. "The civil wars of ancient Rome brought slavery, but the troubles in England have brought liberty." There are two other reasons for choosing around 1688. One is that in 1687, I think, coincidentally, Isaac Newton published his great work, Principia Mathematica, which showed, or people understood it as showing, that the universe was a logical place, that it could be understood. It worked according to mathematical rules. Why was this important, I'll say in a moment.
- 1.14** And second, in 1689, and this was not a coincidence, because in 1689, after the Glorious Revolution, so-called, of 1688, Locke was able to publish another great work of the 18th century, well, which would influence the 18th century, called An Essay Concerning Human Understanding. And what this argued is that human beings are born with no preconceived ideas, that our minds are a blank sheet, and that everything that we know, everything that any of us can know, are things that we have to learn by experiencing the world, by observing and understanding what we observe. Now, that may seem either wrong or obvious, but it was then a revolutionary idea because it meant that even the idea of God was not something that was there from the beginning. It was something you had to learn.

- 1.15** Another reason, or my final reason, for choosing 1688 as a starting point, is that it began a new era in politics. First of all in England, but this was seen, as I said, as important for the whole of Europe. A period of religious toleration, as opposed to religious persecution; a Bill of Rights; the end of press censorship, though this was more by accident than by design, because they forgot to renew the law, but having forgotten it, they didn't then do it again; and because Parliament became crucial to government. Parliament had occasionally met when the King called it in the past. From 1689 onwards, it has met every year.
- 1.16** And this, as I say, people realized, was something new and something important. Voltaire wrote about it, I quoted him a moment ago, as did one of the greatest political writers of the 18th century, Montesquieu, in his great work, *The Spirit of the Laws*. Both of them visited England and wrote after they got back about why what was happening in England was of huge importance to Europe. A little more about that later.
- 1.17** But I want to give you a few key ideas about what these people were saying and why these ideas seem to me to be a key to what we call Enlightenment. In French, "les lumières," the lights. In Germany, "Aufklärung," which I suppose is pretty well, literally, enlightenment. Though the word Enlightenment, which we now use constantly of 18th-century culture, was not used in England for quite a long time. They didn't know what to call it. I think it wasn't until the 20th century that we started talking about the Enlightenment. So it wasn't always obvious what was going on, but something was going on.
- 1.18** So here are a few key ideas, it seems to me. One predates this a little, by Francis Bacon, who wrote in 1597, "Knowledge itself is power." Knowledge is power. John Locke, from the work that I mentioned earlier, and this is hugely important, and he couldn't have written this before. If he had, he'd have been probably locked up. "Faith," he says, "faith can have no authority against the plain and clear dictates of reason." So religion does not dictate what we must believe. Reason dictates what we can believe. Also, Locke: "Men are naturally free." The governments of the world were made by the consent of the people. Now, we know that this idea runs all the way through 18th-century political thinking, and of course, it's embodied in the American Constitution.
- 1.19** Lord Shaftesbury, who I'll shortly be mentioning again, but he was a considerable figure who wrote influential works on politeness. I'll come to politeness in a moment. So Shaftesbury said, "There is a mighty light which spreads itself over the whole world, especially in those free nations of England and Holland, on whom the affairs of Europe now turn." He wrote that in 1706. Finally, from a later generation, the German philosopher Immanuel Kant, who was asked what Enlightenment meant, what did the Aufklärung mean, and he said it means "sapere aude," dare to know. Those, I think, are key ideas of the Enlightenment.
- 1.20** What's the context? Now, why are people talking and thinking like this now? The context is a desire to replace religious conflict and persecution with toleration and

Shaftesbury's idea of politeness. There'd been more than 150 years of terrible religious conflict, as I said. Here is a picture of the siege of Magdeburg in 1631, in which apparently 20,000 people were killed in one town. This gives you an example of what Europe was like in the 17th century.

- 1.21 Both internal violence and violence between states, which led to many thousands of people being tortured and killed for their beliefs, burned for heresy, of course, and actually even worse things than being burnt alive. You may think, well, what's worse? Well, there were things that were worse, I assure you. I went to Münster, visiting friends last year, and on the church spire at Münster, you can still see iron cages hanging in which the bodies of the Anabaptist heretics were exposed. Millions were killed in wars.
- 1.22 If I can talk about Europe in this way, Europe had learned that it didn't want any more of this. It had to go beyond this towards toleration of difference and towards politeness, as opposed to persecution. I'm going to try and sum up what seem to me to be key ideas of Enlightenment, in shorthand terms. First of all, reason. Reason is part of being human. It's what makes us what we are. Toleration. We have to leave behind this time of fanaticism and persecution. Freedom. If people are to think for themselves, as Locke says they have to, then, of course, they must be free to think.
- 1.23 Optimism. The world is not a sinful, doomed place. Happiness. We all know that the American Constitution talks about life, liberty, and the pursuit of happiness. It's not just an accident. Happiness, the idea that humanity does not deserve to suffer and be punished, that people deserve actually to be happy. This is one of their rights. Improvement. If people use their reason, then we can do things better. Progress. As Enlightenment advances, the world will progress. Nature. Nature is good and rational and a source of inspiration for us. Finally, benevolence. Emotions and feelings of empathy are good.
- 1.24 What holds these ideas together? Well, I may have said it already, to leave behind fanaticism. That's a word that they constantly used, and to use your reason to understand and improve things. Newton had shown that you could work out how the whole universe worked. Locke wanted freedom to think things out, and changes in religious belief encouraged the view that the world was not coming to an end as many people had believed. It was not racked by witchcraft and the devil. It was not stained by sin. One theologian had said, well, the world is a dirty little planet, and most people were not doomed to hell, and that happiness and pleasure were part of being human. This was a huge change in thinking.
- 1.25 Thomas Hobbes, in his great work, *Leviathan*, in 1651, on politics, had spent the first chapter telling people they didn't actually have to believe in fairies. The belief in witchcraft, as you know, had been very common only a generation before. People had believed that, OK, to give a crude example, everything that happened in the world was due either to the immediate will of God or to the devil. If your cow had a calf, then God

was blessing you. If your cow died, well, then it was because someone had made it happen. That old woman down the road who must be a witch had cursed you and made your cow die.

- 1.26** And millions of, well, not millions, thousands of people had died for this sort of belief. And now people are saying, well, no, it doesn't work. That's not how things happen. So Hobbes said, don't believe in fairies. The last prosecution for witchcraft in England happened in 1714, but the Queen, Queen Anne, simply annulled the verdict because, by that time, intelligent people were not believing in witches anymore. Key individuals played a huge role, and I've mentioned some names and will mention some more, but this is more than just a story of great men and some great women. A lot of people were involved.
- 1.27** Why? Because peace and greater prosperity increases the market for culture. It became fashionable to take an interest in ideas and literature and science. Lots of societies were founded in which people could pursue these interests. There were more books and newspapers. There were international bestsellers. I suppose, apart from the Bible, this is the first time this had happened. Daniel Defoe's novel, *Robinson Crusoe*, was probably the first, the first proper novel in English, probably the first, certainly the first international bestselling novel. Why *Robinson Crusoe*? Because it's the story of an individual faced with nature, alone in nature, and using his reason to survive and to create a kind of miniature civilization for himself. I'll mention *Robinson Crusoe* again later. You'll see why.
- 1.28** And during this period, 300,000 books were published in England. And in London, by the middle of the century, there were 20 newspapers, more than there are today. So a market for culture, more books and newspapers—new arenas, too, which we now commonly call the public sphere, not just church and court, which were the dominating influences in culture, but things like coffee houses, salons in people's houses where people got together to talk, societies, including the Freemasons, also places where you met to talk about things, pleasure gardens, and of course, pubs. Samuel Johnson, the English literary scholar, used to meet with his friends, a brilliant selection of intellectual friends, in pubs in London. All this meant that cultural life was less controlled than it had been in the past.
- 1.29** And I'd like to give you an example of Mozart and Haydn. The two great Viennese composers of the late classical period had begun their careers as the servants of great households. Mozart worked for the Bishop of Salzburg, and Haydn worked for a great aristocratic family in Bohemia. So they were, in fact, household servants. Their job was to produce music when it was needed for somebody's birthday or whatever. And then they realized that they could make a lot more money and also become more famous and have a better life by actually going out into the public and putting on public concerts, putting on operas for a public audience of people who pay and turn up and listen.

- 1.30** And this, of course, is an entire change in their lives, their status, and so on. Haydn never entirely broke with the family he worked for, but they did allow him to come to London and Paris to give concerts and to make some extra cash. But there's a move from artists being the servants of their patrons to artists being, in a sense, the servants of the public. Samuel Johnson says, "The public will always allow you to say what you want to say."
- 1.31** Finally, there emerges an international cultural life, which is often called a Republic of Letters. It can be at an elite level. So you have important writers, philosophers, artists, who meet, who write to each other, who visit each other across national boundaries, but it also can include ordinary people, too. Let me give you just one example, a man named Thomas Turner, who had a grocery shop in Sussex in the south of England. He owned more than 70 books and periodicals, including works by Locke, which I mentioned, by the essayist Addison, the novelist Lawrence Sterne, the nature poet Edward Young, the works of Shakespeare and Milton. He was reading several new books a year. He read sermons to his friends, and he read Locke's great work in his shop between customers. So ordinary people, too, were taking part in this new cultural life.
- 1.32** Now, there's a mission statement of Enlightenment, which comes in its greatest work, I think its greatest single work, which is the French Encyclopedia, the *Encyclopédie*, which was published in 35 volumes between 1751 and 1772. Around 20,000 people contributed to this enterprise, which shows the scale of this phenomenon. I think only in France could this have been done at the time, though it was still quite dangerous to do.
- 1.33** And the editor wrote—and this, I think, is very important—he wrote that the aim of the *Encyclopédie*, and I'm quoting now, was "to collect all the knowledge scattered over the face of the Earth so that our children, by becoming more educated, may at the same time become more virtuous and happier. All things must be examined, debated, investigated without exception and without regard to anyone's feelings. We have long needed a reasoning age when men would no longer seek the rules in classical authors, but in nature."
- 1.34** I don't think you could sum it up better than that. But beware that we're not talking about free societies, even in England and Holland. There wasn't censorship before publication in England anymore, but you could be prosecuted after publication. I'll give the example of John Wilkes in the 1760s, a well-known radical provocateur who published a number of works and caused a lot of annoyance to those in power. When they found he'd written, as a young man, a slightly obscene or somewhat obscene poem called *An Essay on Women*, he was prosecuted for blasphemous libel because he criticized bishops. That was blasphemy. Seditious libel because he criticized the Crown. For obscene libel because it was a naughty poem. The government was paying a hitman to go and challenge him to a duel, and he had to go into exile.

- 1.35** So there were limits to freedom, quite considerable limits to freedom, even in England. In France, much worse. Almost at the same time, 1766, a young man called the Chevalier de la Barre was also accused of blasphemy on very slight grounds, and he came off less well than Wilkes, who ended up as Lord Mayor of London. So there was a happy ending for Wilkes, but the Chevalier de la Barre was sentenced to death for blasphemy. He was tortured, first of all, to make him reveal his accomplices; he didn't. Had his tongue torn out, and then he was burnt, and a copy of the works of Voltaire thrown onto the pyre with his body.
- 1.36** So there were limits to freedom, and you were always like Diderot, risking the Bastille. The fortress in Paris is where writers could be locked up. That was the usual place for locking up writers. And you didn't need a trial. You just have a signature on a document from the king or from a minister who would lock you up. So it was still a dangerous world. But even in this dangerous world, there were works of huge importance. I want to give you a list of some key names and books, as it were, for the record. These are still very interesting to dip into.
- 1.37** Daniel Defoe, *The Life and Adventures of Robinson Crusoe*, as I mentioned, was published in 1719. Voltaire, *Lettres sur les Anglais*, English letters, which he writes about how England is discovering new things. Then his novel, 1759, *Candide*. Samuel Richardson, *Pamela, or Virtue Rewarded*, 1740, a hugely influential and widely read sentimental novel. It invents the sentimental genre. It's about a servant girl who defends her virtue against her lecherous master and is rewarded because he, in the end, marries her. It's a sort of reward. Montesquieu, I mentioned, *The Spirit of the Laws*, 1748. Émilie du Châtelet, a female translator of Newton in 1756, *Principe Mathématique*, which is said to be still the best translation into French of Newton.
- 1.38** Jean-Jacques Rousseau, 1762. *Julie, ou La Nouvelle Héloïse*, a novel. I'll come back to Rousseau, and his *Du Contrat Social*, *Social Contract*, 1762. He was very busy in 1761-1762. Then finally, *Émile, ou L'Éducation*, a novel, also in 1762. Cesare de Beccaria, *On Crimes and Punishments*, classic work on reforming the law, 1764. Adam Smith, *The Theory of Moral Sentiments*, 1759, *The Wealth of Nations*, 1776. *The Theory of Moral Sentiments*, about how people naturally wish to cooperate together. *The Wealth of Nations*, the most famous ever work on economics, I suppose, about how the economy works or ought to work or ought not to work. Then finally, Immanuel Kant, *Critique of Pure Reason*, 1781 to '87. That covers most of the century. These are great works that are appearing constantly, as you see.
- 1.39** I want to look a little more at two key theorists of society, Charles Louis de Secondat, the Baron de Montesquieu, a great French aristocrat and philosopher, and Adam Smith, Scottish academic and philosopher, too. Now, these are, in some ways, the inventors of social science. Their aim is to discover the rules, as it were, as Newton had done for the universe, or so it seemed. They would discover the rules by which societies operate. Montesquieu tries to understand and classify different types of political system and

those which give more or less freedom. And he develops, he formulates the idea of the separation of powers. That's his most famous idea, by which liberty is on the basis of the separation of the legislative, the judicial, and the executive power, which, of course, was embodied in the American Constitution and many others.

- 1.40 Smith, like Montesquieu, believed that modern society was based on commerce. I suppose we'd say on economics. That's what society is mainly about, and that this would make it freer, more peaceful, more tolerant, and even more equal. People would have an equal chance. His ideas about how the economy functions, or should function, are hugely influential still. But crucial in the 18th century is the idea that society can function on its own. It doesn't need to be run constantly by monarchs or even churches, that people will spontaneously organize society because it's in their interest to do so. And he says, as if by a hidden hand this will operate.
- 1.41 So he was an optimist, and I've said that optimism was a characteristic of the Enlightenment. Society was getting better, and people were getting happier. Well, all that I've said so far makes it sound wonderful, and in many ways it was. But even at the time, critics emerged, and many of the leading figures themselves began eventually to think that they'd failed. And today, many critics blame Enlightenment for many of the evils. Some of them seem to blame it for all of the evils of the modern world. But I'll come back to that later.
- 1.42 But I want to talk about one of the great critics of the Enlightenment from within. Jean-Jacques Rousseau, who was really the Enlightenment superstar, and he attacked Enlightenment philosophy. Now, was he the most radical of revolutionaries, or was he the most reactionary of conservatives? In a way, it doesn't matter. He split from the mainstream and he wrote that civilization itself was bad and corrupt. One could hardly be more radical, whether of the right or of the left, though those terms didn't yet exist. Civilization itself was bad and corrupt, and it corrupted people.
- 1.43 He said that Enlightenment civilization was causing people to turn away from simplicity in belief, away from patriotism, away from true nature, his great ideal, and his works became international bestsellers, and he an international celebrity. In his romantic novel, *Julie*, which I mentioned, 1761, it ends with the heroine Julie and her friends setting up their own little society far away from city corruption. In his other bestselling novel, *Emile*, the following year, young Emile is brought up by his guardian in complete rural isolation, never allowed to go to a town, not allowed to meet other people. And he's only allowed to read one book, which you may guess is *Robinson Crusoe*, Rousseau's favorite book. And that's how you bring up a young man, in the country, away from everything, with only *Robinson Crusoe*.
- 1.44 Rousseau's idea of social corruption is hugely influential, and I would say revolutionary. Whenever nowadays we blame society for people doing bad things, we're echoing Rousseau. Whenever someone wants to destroy the system and start afresh, they're following Rousseau. There's an example of a difference within Enlightenment society,

which I think is quite amusing. I hope you will, too. This is a contrast between Rousseau and an English aristocrat called Philip Dormer Stanhope, the fourth Earl of Chesterfield, who is himself an Enlightenment figure, a statesman, a diplomat, but also a patron of the arts and a man who is interested in ideas.

- 1.45 They have very different ideas about behavior. I think they're almost as if they were talking to each other, though they're not. I'm just going to quote a few things about the difference. Rousseau in *Emile*, and he writes very well, "Everything is good as it leaves the hands of the creator; everything degenerates in the hands of man. He wants nothing as nature has made it, not even man; he has to be trained like a circus horse, twisted like a tree in his garden."
- 1.46 Chesterfield, who writes lots of letters to his son, which were later published at about the same time, telling his son how to behave. He says, "Apply yourself to Marcel's lectures." Marcel was a famous dancing master. More about dancing masters in a minute. "Apply yourself now to Marcel's lectures. Desire him to teach you every genteel attitude that the human body can be put into. Take particular care, take particular care, that the motions of your hands and arms be easy and graceful." So this is precisely what Rousseau condemns, training someone like a circus horse. Chesterfield says to his son, "Yes, you must train yourself. You've got to train yourself on how to behave."
- 1.47 Now, Rousseau says, "If I were a dancing master, I would not do all Marcel's monkey tricks. I would take my student to the foot of a rock to tread the steep paths lightly. I would make him copy a mountain goat rather than a ballet dancer." Chesterfield says to his son, "Your dancing master is at this time the man all Europe of the greatest importance to you. You must dance well, in order to sit, stand, and walk well; and you must do all these well in order to please."
- 1.48 I think we'd have to imagine 18th-century society a bit like a kind of ballet without music, in which all ladies and gentlemen had learnt all the movements, how to speak, how to stand, how to sit, how to bow. And they learned this from their dancing masters. And then finally, Rousseau says, "The man of the world consists wholly of his mask. What he is means nothing to him; what he appears to be means everything." Chesterfield thinks that the hallmark of success is that people might think you are French. And he says to his son, "The ideal is to make the French say, *qu'on diroit que c'est un François*." The French say, "You'd think he was French." So exactly, Chesterfield doesn't care what you really are. He cares about what you look like.
- 1.49 Here we have this deep divergence within this 18th-century culture. Rousseau was encouraging and spreading admiration for nature. But Enlightenment ideas of nature were often aimed at improving it, rather like Chesterfield improving his son's movements. There's a huge vogue for English-style gardens all over Europe. But the thing about a garden, of course, English-style gardens, were meant to look natural, but

of course, they were not natural. They were pretending to be natural, rather like Chesterfield's son.

- 1.50** The 18th century is also very interested in science, but science is often about investigating nature and improving it. This is the time of innovation in agriculture, of new crops, of improved breeding techniques. As Rousseau said, "He wants nothing as nature has made it, not even man." Familiar examples of this, and I mention these two because they happened in the same place at the same time. Marie-Antoinette, the Queen of France, built herself a little toy village in which she could play at being a shepherdess. She could play at being in nature. And on the same year this was completed, came the first balloon flight at Versailles, also a great scientific triumph of the age.
- 1.51** Is this a contradiction? Nature or science, or nature and science? And I'm giving you another example, a fairly light-hearted one. Was the world, after all, a place of happiness, or was it corrupt and immoral, as Rousseau thought? Fragonard's famous painting, *The Swing*, from 1767, shows a young girl, a young woman, in a garden, innocently playing on a swing. But it's clear that there's a bit of upskirting going on, and there's a bit of voyeurism going on. Is this really nature? Is it a pretense at nature? Is it a corruption through this pretense of nature?
- 1.52** The other painting is by Elisabeth Vigée Le Brun, leading female portraitist, of Marie-Antoinette dressed up as a kind of country girl, a very expensive country girl outfit, in a straw hat and a muslin dress. This painting was thought to be shocking because a queen of France should not appear like that. But if you look at it, you see that she's not like any real country girl. She's just pretending.
- 1.53** There's another far more sinister contradiction. Here we're getting, in a sense, to the crux of modern controversies between discovering nature around the globe, including by voyages of discovery. Explorers like Cook and Bougainville became international celebrities. But what they were doing, of course, was discovering the world. They were also describing it, drawing it, painting it, collecting and classifying bits of it, but also taking possession of it and exploiting it, exploiting nature and exploiting other human beings through slavery and decolonization.
- 1.54** There's certainly ambivalence here. The famous painting of Omai, Polynesian visitor to Britain, by Sir Joshua Reynolds in 1776, shows on one hand, I think, a genuine admiration for Omai and the idea of other civilizations, but it also dresses Omai up in a way that he would never actually have dressed, and what we would now call exoticizing, which is also, it can be seen as a way of demeaning and controlling. Another example is Olaudah Equiano, an African who was himself a slave, though he later became an anti-slavery campaigner who lived and died in Cambridge in his later life.
- 1.55** So, admiration for foreign cultures, exoticizing foreign cultures, enslaving people, and yet in some cases working for the abolition of enslavement. All these are contradictory

aspects of Enlightenment thought. But some say this wasn't a contradiction at all, that Enlightenment ideas and Enlightenment society aimed precisely at controlling and exploiting nature and creating a hierarchy of race and of civilization, and that Enlightenment universalism and Eurocentricity provided precisely the ideology that justified slavery and conquest.

- 1.56** So these I'm summarizing the present-day critiques of Enlightenment, that its universalism makes the white, male, educated European the norm and Europe the progressive civilization, compared with which all others are backward or barbarous. It assumes that everyone is essentially the same. It tries to universalize, order, classify, and hence control. Its rationalism is an illusion. There's no single truth and perhaps no objective truth, whatever. This is the postmodern view. Finally, it provides the tools of racism, colonialism, misogyny.
- 1.57** If you think I'm exaggerating, let me quote from a notice you will read if you go to the famous Pitt Rivers Ethnographic Museum in Oxford. "The past is still present," says the Pitt Rivers, "and the invisible structures of colonialism still persist today. These invisible structures, known as coloniality, shape our ideas about race, class, culture, gender, and sexuality. Coloniality divides the world into the West and the rest, and assigns racial, intellectual, and cultural superiority to the West. Coloniality creates and shapes these ideas through three overall processes—by establishing hierarchies, by controlling knowledge, and by imposing white culture and place names."
- 1.58** I'll come back to this in later lectures, but let me conclude this lecture by saying this about the Enlightenment. We have to beware of caricaturing 18th-century culture, which was a time, after all, of great debate and ferment. There was not a single set of ideas, and many of the criticisms made by present-day commentators were made by leading thinkers at the time. Some thought that their ideal of creating a peaceful and free world of commerce had failed. Many criticized slavery and colonial conquest as immoral. This was hugely important because nobody else in history had criticized it.
- 1.59** The French Revolution seemed to many to be the result of Enlightenment rationalism. I'll come to that in the next lecture. And in a sense, to prove its dangers, a monster that had emerged from the Enlightenment. So it's right to see the complexities of the Enlightenment, including its dark sides, its failures and its illusions. But it would be a caricature to see only the dark sides. And undeniably, much of what we see as gains of the modern world, including freedom of thought, of speech, of writing, rational investigation, including in science, technology, medicine, the belief that human life can be improved and we are not stuck in unchanging ancestral ways. All these things, too, owe a huge debt to Enlightenment thought.
- 1.60** I'll end by repeating Immanuel Kant's motto of the Enlightenment, "sapere aude," dare to know, which I think should be our motto today, too. Thank you very much.

- 1.61 Thank you very much for the lecture. I just wondered if you could tell me if Rousseau had a prescriptive vision for the rebuilding or if he just criticized what was around him at the time.
- 1.62 Well, he did, but I don't think it could be said to be a very realistic one, and I'm not sure that he felt it was real. I mean, his idea of society is that it must be close to nature. Well, it's a nice idea, but in practice, the way he developed it was a fairly inhuman one. If Emile had been a real person, you would think, gosh, this poor boy is being put through the most appalling ordeal in his childhood and is bound to turn out badly. But in his social contract, it's one of many contractual theories of government in which you assume that there is, there has been a pre-state age, as it were.
- 1.63 Hobbes called it the state of nature when life was, I can't remember quite the phrase, nasty, brutish, and short. Then people somehow get together and they agree to set up a government. OK, this is fiction, but the idea that government comes from people agreeing together to set up a government and obeying that government is, I suppose, in many ways, the foundation of what we assume about modern democracies. But Rousseau's idea was based on his experience in Geneva, and he did say he thought this was only possible in small communities, because in a large state like France, 20 million people, you couldn't have the citizens all coming together to agree on their laws.
- 1.64 There is always a problem, and has always been a problem since, in what do you mean, how do you represent people in a state? Even if you want to be democratic, how can you actually do it? I don't think Rousseau really had an idea. His solution was to talk about the general will, which is a somewhat mysterious idea, which doesn't just mean the majority view. It means that somehow there is, in the community, a vision or a view of things which is the one that must prevail, and that anyone who doesn't agree with it becomes an outlaw.
- 1.65 Well, in the French Revolution, and indeed, in later totalitarian regimes, some of which have been blamed on Rousseau, this idea can obviously be put to very dangerous uses. If you claim that I represent the general will, you, because you disagree with me, are a traitor and therefore deserve to die, as Rousseau said. It's not what we would think of as a pluralistic, liberal way of conducting democratic affairs. It's a kind of—someone called it a totalitarian democracy. I don't think Rousseau ever did really have a solution, and what he suggested was very dangerous, or at least it was put to very dangerous uses.
- 1.66 With the colonies in the New World, what are your thoughts of the American native Indian ideals coming over to Europe and influencing the Enlightenment?
- 1.67 Well, an important idea in Enlightenment thought, it's linked to this idea of nature, is what was sometimes called, I'm not sure if this was Rousseau's phrase, the "noble savage." The idea that there were non-European societies which were closer to nature and which had virtues that the civilized European had lost. This was a fairly common

view. But the reality of indigenous cultures, I think, was pretty well outside the realm of what people knew. I think it's true to say they projected onto other civilizations what they wanted to find, what they expected to find. North America would be one example.

- 1.68** There were attempts to integrate a sort of Anglo or British Indian society at times. There were visitors, Omai being the most famous, there were visitors from North American nations to Britain—I expect to other European countries, too—and from the Pacific islands, too, and indeed, close relations with India, if you think of India in the sense, at least, of a non-European culture, though a very different one. But I think it was the extent to which you think that this was genuine sympathy or genuine insight depends in many ways on how you read the whole history of European contacts with indigenous peoples. I think one would have to say it's a very checkered history.
- 1.69** Even when it was very well meaning, it often ended in tears. The experience of Captain Cook, I think, could be taken as emblematic. Cook was sent off and was given instructions that he should treat the indigenous people he met with great courtesy and respect because they were the true owners of the land. I think his instructions from the Royal Society said something like, "and in the eyes of God, perhaps they're more deserving than we, Europeans." I think Cook tried to follow that. But in the end, as you know, he ended up being killed in a clash with Polynesians.
- 1.70** What he did not know is that he and his presence were offending certain religious taboos, that merely his presence was interfering in power structures in those societies, as well as introducing diseases into those societies. So even if the intention was very high-minded, the reality was almost inevitably, well, I was going to say, disastrous, in some cases, disastrous; at least, in many cases, it had unintended consequences. That was something that I think no one really understood or predicted. But the idea of the noble savage was certainly an important one within this whole ideology of nature.
- 1.71** Thank you very much for the lecture. You mentioned that there was the conflict between religion and the beginning of science, and that people started to have new ideas and criticize that religious ideology. How do you see today the trust that people place in science? Perhaps there might be a return into this beliefs because, today, the scientific world or the big science, the papers, the scholars, their voices are more prominent and dictate in the academia what people should think and the waves that the academic science bring.
- 1.72** Well, I think, if I gave the impression that the Enlightenment was an anti-religious movement, that's wrong. I mean, the Enlightenment consisted of all sorts of things. People like Newton himself was highly religious. And as you may know, he believed that the force of gravity, which he, in a sense, discovered or at least explained, was the result of the will of God. I mean, he didn't—and he also believed that the world was coming to an end. I can't remember whether he thought the year 2000 was the likely date. But many Enlightenment philosophers were definitely working within a religious framework.

- 1.73 And although there were some, of whom Voltaire is the most famous or notorious, who were extremely opposed to the Catholic Church, it was particularly in France that Enlightenment took on an anti-Catholic and eventually anti-religious element, largely because of the structure of power within that society. But in Britain and in Germany and in Italy, there was not such a conflict between science and religion. And indeed, many clergy were prominent as Enlightenment thinkers and writers.
- 1.74 But the difference was between what is often called a Calvinist understanding in which, as I said, it was assumed that everything that happened was a result of divine will and intervention, or indeed of diabolical intervention. That is, which then many 18th-century thinkers regard or start to call superstition. They want religion to be purified of superstition and fanaticism, and to become, as they see it, a truer, and indeed, Rousseau calls it, a more natural form of religion. So there is a God, there is a creator, and that creator ought to be worshiped, honored. But the creator is not someone who is constantly interfering in human society to punish some and to reward toward others.
- 1.75 And indeed, a famous analogy was to talk about the creator as rather like a clockmaker who creates this complex universe and then allows it to operate on its own. So there comes to be an idea of the divine and of religion that is much closer to what they would have thought of as philosophy. And therefore, for Locke, as I said, reason cannot be disproved by religion, but then that's because he thinks that the works of God are rational. So there's no conflict between reason and religion. Science and philosophy are the way of helping to discover the true nature of creation and the true nature of religion.

Lecture 2: Conflict in the Age of Reason

At a glance — Conflict in the age of reason.

- 2.1** I ended my previous lecture on the criticisms and contradictions of Enlightenment culture, including the belief of some leading thinkers that their great project of tolerance, peace, and improvement had failed. And the biggest failure of all is that the century of light was also a century of wars. Indeed, six of the 12 biggest wars in human history were fought during this period. Some of them we've forgotten about. That doesn't mean to say that they were not, in fact, extremely big, expensive, and bloody.
- 2.2** And they are the Nine Years' War, from 1688 to '97, the War of the Spanish Succession, the War of the Austrian Succession, the Seven Years' War, the American War of Independence, which I expect we all have heard about, from 1775 to '83, and then the revolutionary and Napoleonic wars, which end this cycle of violence. About 5.5 million battlefield deaths, countless civilian deaths all around the globe because some of these were global wars. The Seven Years' War has often been called the true First World War, and the century ended in violent revolution, which also cost several hundred thousand lives.
- 2.3** So was it all failure and hypocrisy? The century of Enlightenment is also the century of blood. Many people at the time feared that this was the case. I mentioned Voltaire earlier, and I mentioned his bitterly satirical novel, *Candide*, again, which I recommend, in which the characters suffer and witness all sorts of terrible horrors and eventually give up in despair and decide that the only thing they can do is to retire into private life, and as Voltaire famously puts it, cultivate our garden.
- 2.4** David Hume, great Scottish philosopher, came to question whether giving liberty to the people was not too dangerous, perhaps enlightened rulers with the hope of the future. Of course, we hear that today. Adam Smith feared that business interests were not, as he hoped, creating harmony and peace, but were in fact pushing towards war and conquest. As I said in my first lecture, many people today agree, and we need at least to bear this in mind, and we'll come back to it again later. But I want to begin with the basics.
- 2.5** The most powerful states in the world in about 1710 were the Chinese Empire, the Qing Empire, 210 million people already; the Mughal Empire in India, about 150 million; France, the European superpower, 20 million. By the way, if the French population had increased at the same rate as the English population since then, France would now have about 180 million people. But it didn't. But that's another subject. Germany, or at least the Holy Roman Empire, very loose German entity, 20 million. Britain, 9 million. Russia, 25 million. The Ottoman Empire, 25 million.
- 2.6** So Britain is the smallest, France the biggest of the European states, but they're vastly outweighed by the non-European states. That's going to change as far as power is

concerned. But those are the basics. The European states are not the most powerful, but they are the most mobile, and France is the superpower. The wars of the 18th century are partly explained by France, at least by the wish to resist French hegemony in Europe, which had been enforced during the rather aggressive reign of Louis XIV, in which one of his ministers had said, "Not a dog can bark in Europe without the consent of my master."

- 2.7 So the other European states wanted to stop that. And the 1688 invasion of England, the Glorious Revolution, was largely motivated by the wish to create an alliance against France. And what's been called, I think, quite rightly, the second Hundred Years' War, is a constant attempt largely to limit and eventually to destroy French power over the next hundred years, and which finally only ends in 1815 with the defeat of Napoleon at Waterloo.
- 2.8 OK, so those are the basics. What a great change which would upset Europe's always somewhat unstable equilibrium is sea power and commerce. I was reading French foreign ministry archives from the 18th century and was very impressed by how perceptive many of them were. One of the reports says, "Once, land forces made the destiny of states. But since a century ago, Neptune's trident has become the scepter of the world." That was written in 1779. It's because power and wealth now come from sea, the sea, from control of the sea, from global commerce. Means that the second Hundred Years' War, the core of it, will be a conflict between the great land power, France, and the rising sea power of Britain.
- 2.9 All this comes down to, well, minor simplification. All this comes down to the ability to raise money. Wars are fought by money. The founder of the Bank of England said, "Today's wars are fought not with iron, but with gold." If you have global commerce, you can raise taxation and you can raise credit. And if we want to know in a sentence why Britain, as a small country, was able to defeat France, a large country, the answer, I would say, is the combination of the city of London and Parliament.
- 2.10 The city of London that could borrow money, Parliament that would guarantee that your money would be paid back one day, which you couldn't assume if you were dealing with the king of France. The king of France might pay you what he owed you or he might not. And if he didn't want to, he might put you in the Bastille and accuse you of fraud. If you had money to invest, savings to put somewhere safe, you would lend them to Britain. You wouldn't lend them to France. That, in a nutshell, is why Britain won and France lost. But perhaps someone might say a slight simplification, but I think basically true.
- 2.11 I talked about the Enlightenment in the last lecture. But part of the Enlightenment, as you recall, is a desire for improvement and rationality. But that also meant the improvement of rationality of states and to make them more efficient and more powerful and more able to fight wars. And that is why you had the phenomenon that's usually called Enlightened despotism. Who were the rulers who are most interested in

the Enlightenment? Frederick II of Prussia, Catherine the Great of Russia, Joseph II of Austria. Why are they interested in these things? Because it will make their states more efficient. Find out what the rational way of governing is. So for Joseph II, all these convents and monasteries, they don't serve any rational purpose. Let's close them down and let's take over their wealth.

- 2.12** I wonder if anyone knows which was the first European state to abolish, or at least the first major European state to abolish the death penalty, which seems like a great Enlightenment reform. Anyone guess? Well, it was Russia. Why Russia? Not because the Russians were humane, but because, after all, why waste a human resource? If you've got a criminal, why hang him or break him on the wheel as they probably would have done, when you can put him into the army or use him as a slave laborer? Much more rational, much more to the profit of the state.
- 2.13** OK. Neptune's trident commands colonial trade in sugar, tobacco, spices, dye products, tea, coffee, and that was increasingly important and profitable. And so, of course, was slavery. Britain became the biggest shipper of slaves across the Atlantic; France and Brazil were the biggest buyers. This began to be questioned on ethical grounds in several countries in the later decades of the century, though slavery lasted well into the 19th century in the Americas, and later still in Muslim countries. Indeed, I met a lady recently who mentioned that her parents had been brought up by slave girls.
- 2.14** In Britain, there was a big popular campaign against slavery in which many women were involved. They boycotted slave-grown products. They petitioned Parliament. This is something of a summary of this campaign. The famous diagram of the slave ship Brooks, in 1781, which you've probably all seen somewhere, which is a diagram of a slave ship showing how slaves were packed in to every deck, like commodities, which they were. And on the other hand, a famous badge created by the Wedgwood factory, the Wedgwood's great Enlightenment industrialists, which shows a slave who is saying, "Am I not a man and a brother?", from 1797. And this was part of the campaign to abolish slavery.
- 2.15** William Wilberforce began a parliamentary campaign to abolish the slave trade in 1789. A couple of years before that, a society called the Society for Effecting the Abolition of the Slave Trade began its campaign in England. There were other similar movements in some other countries. And several important Enlightenment figures were involved in the abolition movement, including the painter Sir Joshua Reynolds, the writer James Boswell, several politicians, including the Prime Minister William Pitt the Younger; and they urged Wilberforce, who was a member of Parliament, to lead the campaign.
- 2.16** But the campaign was damaged by fears of revolution and by the outbreak of war with France. Slavery was, the slave trade was, it seemed, too important to end at a time of war, though eventually it was outlawed in 1807 in the British Empire, and slavery itself abolished in 1833, a month after Wilberforce's death. So this, if you like, is part of the

Enlightenment, which is campaigning for what it had, in theory, always stood for, which was the equality of human beings.

- 2.17** A different aspect of this century of war is the rise of an ideology of patriotism. It's not yet called nationalism. That comes really in the next century, and I'll be talking about that later. And patriotism is partly an internal political ideology. It's the people who say, we represent the true interests of the country, as well as, externally, we wish to defeat the nation's enemies. I have a couple of paintings here, one by J. S. Copley called *The Death of the Earl of Chatham*. Pitt the Elder was one of the great models of patriotic statesmen, a radical in many ways who is using patriotism to attack the government accused of not being patriotic. He's shown here supposedly dying in the House of Lords after making a great patriotic speech. It didn't quite happen like that. But it's shown as him sacrificing his life for the country.
- 2.18** And a different painting, though the style is not dissimilar, by the great French classicist Jacques-Louis David, called *The Oath of the Horatii*, which is a classical analogy, of course, in which it shows the brothers, the Horatii, who are taking swords from their father and swearing to die if necessary in defense of Rome. On the right-hand side of the picture, it shows their sister, a mother, I think, with a sister certainly weeping, suggesting that patriotism is really a male virtue. Remember that because I'll come back to that. The Horatii swear to die in the service of Rome.
- 2.19** Patriotism is a clear threat, in fact, to traditional ideas of dynastic loyalty and monarchy, which is why Samuel Johnson, whom I've mentioned earlier, called it the last refuge of the scoundrel. It was dangerous because it created a new focus of loyalty. You were supposed to be loyal to your king. What defined the nation was its monarch. France was the kingdom of France. It could add a bit here, it could lose a bit there. People didn't have to speak the same language. They didn't even have to have the same religion. But what united them was simply their loyalty to the king.
- 2.20** But now people are saying, well, no, actually, that's not what it is essentially about. It's about loyalty to the state or the nation. The endpoint of that in France will be revolution. Now, let me read you a couple of, I think, quite interesting passages. Again, one from the French foreign ministry archives, who are talking about William Pitt the Elder, who was the enemy of France and who was leading Britain. By this time, he'd reached the position of high office. He was leading the war effort against France in the Seven Years' War.
- 2.21** What the French say about him is this. His ambition is not wealth, for he despises it and is incorruptible, but power. In France, Mr. Pitt would end his days in prison. In Russia, would have made a revolution or had his tongue torn out. In England, he obtained high office. So they know that patriot politicians are dangerous. But they also think that this is the secret of Britain's victory in the Seven Years' War over France. It's because they had a man like Pitt who could galvanize the nation in a way that the French are finding it very difficult to do.

- 2.22 And the position of the King is therefore being devalued, and he's blamed for defeat. This is the comment of a French aristocrat. "Today, hardly anyone dares to say in Parisian society, I serve the King. You'd be taken for one of the chief valets. I serve the state, is the expression used." Some people caught on to this. Frederick the Great of Prussia famously said, "The Prince is only the first servant of the state." So the justification for Frederick being king is he is the servant. If you can bring that off, if you can call yourself a patriot king, as George III in England did, or Frederick II of Prussia, then maybe you can ride out this patriotic wave. You can put yourself at the head of the patriotic movement.
- 2.23 But if you fail to do that, then you'll find yourself in great political difficulties in which the king himself, as in the case of France, is seen as not serving the nation, not serving the state, serving himself or his courtiers, but not the true interests of the nation. And that's, in a sense, why, to cut a long story short, revolution takes place in France in July '89.
- 2.24 Now, the revolution didn't happen because France was badly governed or France was particularly tyrannical or particularly divided. In fact, the French paid much lower taxes than the English. In my view, if I could say it humbly, that's where I think most historians get it wrong. They assume that the French Revolution must have internal causes. It seems to me that obviously its main cause was external. Louis XVI's monarchy collapsed because it bankrupted itself fighting wars against Britain, the second Hundred Years' War that I mentioned before, all these great wars throughout the century.
- 2.25 The problem of France was that very few states in history, maybe Rome, certainly the United States since the 1940s, have been able to be true superpowers. That's to say that they can be both dominant on land and on the sea. France tried to do this and it couldn't afford it. Britain didn't have to worry about being a land power. It was just a sea power. Prussia wasn't a sea power, it was just a land power. An alliance of Britain and Prussia, as in the Seven Years' War, could defeat France because France could not be both a land power and a sea power. And trying to do so, it bankrupted itself.
- 2.26 And the final straw was when the French helped the Americans to break away from the British Empire—the American War of Independence, which we could as easily call the French War of Revenge. It was a war of revenge and a successful one, but in revenging themselves against Britain, they destroyed themselves, too. So we move on to the Revolution of 1789, which was very widely welcomed. It seemed that this was the defeat of tyranny, of the old style of monarchy, of religious power, the power of the Catholic Church. And progressives in many countries welcomed it as the beginning of a general process of emancipation.
- 2.27 Perhaps the most famous was the English poet William Wordsworth, who turned against it later. But he wrote of his feelings at the time, and you may know this line, "Bliss was it in that dawn to be alive, but to be young was very heaven!" Because it seemed the world was changing before their eyes and the ideals of the Enlightenment

were at last being embodied. What were the ideals of the Revolution? Well, the Enlightenment ideas of the nation and the sovereignty of the nation and the Enlightenment ideas of rights.

- 2.28** I'm going to read you a little bit from the famous Declaration of the Rights of Man and the Citizen, which was adopted in August 1789. Article 1—Men are born and remain free and equal in rights. Article 2— The aim of every political association is the protection of the natural and imprescriptible rights of man. These rights are liberty, property, security, and resistance to oppression. Article 3—The principle of all sovereignty resides essentially in the nation. Nobody and no individual may exercise any authority that does not expressly emanate from it. So the sovereign is not the king, the sovereign is the nation.
- 2.29** What about the rights of women? Years before, the English writer Mary Astell had written, "If all men are born free, why is it that all women are born slaves?" The French Revolution tried to, well, revive and made some attempt to resolve this question. But for many revolutionaries, the rights of women were quite problematic. Remember the painting of David, the Oath of the Horatii, which sees his sister weeping because her brothers are going off to fight. In fact, they're going off to fight her husband.
- 2.30** And so when the brothers—I can't remember how many there are. Three brothers, two of them are dead, killed in the patriotic struggle. The third one comes back and kills his sister. Why? Because his sister did not show the right patriotic feeling. Could women really be patriots? Could they really be citizens? After all, citizens had to be soldiers. They had to be willing to fight. Women didn't fight, therefore women could not be citizens. In any case, the presence of women in society was not a rather aristocratic custom and so on. So although there were important attempts to assert the rights of women, the French Revolution was not very sympathetic.
- 2.31** An example of that is its measures on divorce. It's often said, well, the French Revolution passed a divorce law, which is very good for the liberation of women. But if you look at the reasons they did it, in fact, they did it in order to give men more control over their wives. If you don't behave yourself, I will divorce you. That was the idea. And when they found that women were using divorce laws to get rid of their husbands, then they pretty quickly abolished divorce. To admit that women had equal rights was problematic for many revolutionaries.
- 2.32** A French woman Olympe de Gouges wrote a Declaration of the Rights of Woman and the Citizeness in 1791. And in England, Mary Wollstonecraft wrote A Vindication of the Rights of Women. This was an issue. This was becoming debated public. But Olympe de Gouges ended up being guillotined, and the revolution banned political clubs for women. Women were not to be allowed to discuss politics publicly. So the rights of women remains highly problematic for a very long time to come.

- 2.33** A defining characteristic of the French Revolution was the determination of radicals to start a new age on purely rational and natural principles. So early attempts to adopt a variation of the English system—Parliament, the King—was rejected. One parliamentarian shouted, "We want nothing that's English. We have no need to copy anybody." We don't want to copy anybody. We want to use our reason. We want to copy nature. So everything has to be new. This includes things like geography. The old historic provinces, Burgundy, Aquitaine, and so on, are abolished and uniform départements, departments are brought in. Weights and measures, meters and grams replace lieu and pousse and livre. The franc replaces the old Louis.
- 2.34** A new calendar with a 10 day—ten is the logical number. So a week has 10 days, a year has 10 months. We begin with the year one. New names for the months, named after natural phenomena, brumaire, foggy month, frimaire, chilly month. New religion, the religion of reason, the worship of reason or the worship of the supreme being. Few revolutionaries, some did, but few revolutionaries thought you could do without religion. Because without religion, how would society function and why would people behave in a virtuous manner if they didn't believe that somehow there was a higher authority than themselves?
- 2.35** So everything has to be new. Remember what I read from the Encyclopédie in the last lecture. "All things must be examined, debated, investigated without exception." That's what they're doing. This was precisely what some of their critics thought was most alarming and most dangerous. You can't begin from scratch. That's not how human nature works. The most famous writer was Edmund Burke, an English Enlightenment writer and politician who wrote in 1790 Reflections on the Revolution in France, which was probably the most influential criticism of the French Revolution of all time.
- 2.36** And what he attacked was its utopianism, what he called its abstract principles, its metaphysical abstraction. He talked about the fairy land of philosophy because he said that's not how societies work. Societies need instinctive loyalties and traditions, what he called prejudices. Probably, I guess, provocatively called prejudices. We need prejudices, and that's how society holds together. If you don't have these prejudices, he said, you can only rely on force. Indeed, he predicted very accurately that France was heading towards a military dictatorship because that was the only way that force would be exercised.
- 2.37** That was Burke's influential criticism. But nevertheless, when he's writing, the revolution has not yet reached its peak, not yet reached its peak of influence, even. And its radicalism traveled very far. First of all, across Europe, beginning in the Netherlands, Germany, Italy, and outside Europe, perhaps most famously now to the huge French slave colony of Saint-Domingue, today's Haiti, by far the most valuable colony in the world, the most valuable piece of real estate in the world, with a huge slave population. The news of the French Revolution did not immediately begin a slave rebellion. What it began was a conflict between white and free black citizens. It was the

conflict between them that eventually sparked a huge slave rebellion, partly because they began arming slaves to fight each other.

- 2.38** It was led eventually by the now famous Toussaint Louverture. After a prolonged conflict and a very bloody conflict in Haiti, the French under Napoleon, slightly jumping ahead, crushed the revolution and reintroduced slavery. Toussaint was captured and died in France. But finally, Haiti did become independent, and the importance of its revolution, which was very ambivalent. It brought horrors as well as freedoms. It showed that—did it show that liberty could go wrong? Did it show that emancipating slaves was too dangerous? That was a lesson that some people drew, but it certainly showed all sides that the slave system was not eternal. It was very fragile if they didn't realize that already. So that was the importance of the Haitian revolution.
- 2.39** Now, at the same time as this was taking place, France itself was collapsing into the Reign of Terror in 1793, '94, which is the revolution's most notorious episode, and which, as I mentioned in the last lecture, made some people think that, after all, the Enlightenment itself had proved too dangerous. Now, how can we explain the Terror? Of course, you could say, well, how much is it down to ideology? How much of it's the fault of Rousseau?
- 2.40** I suppose that raises the question, which is very difficult to resolve anyway, of what is the connection between ideas and actions? Do people read a book and then go and do what they've read? Well, no, not usually, hardly ever. On the other hand, ideas do influence in some ways what we do. I suppose we have to explain actions as some sort of interaction between what happens to us and what we believe. I suppose the Terror was that. It was a toxic combination of causes. Anti-royalism is one thing, anti-Catholicism is another, war against Austria and Prussia, economic hardship, factual conflicts among revolutionaries, paranoia about traitors and spies, rebellion in the provinces, and then finally, ideological extremism.
- 2.41** So the Terror happens. It's not something that anybody wanted or expected, but it happened. Nevertheless, there is some connection with the ideas of the Enlightenment, and it's often been linked with Rousseau and his condemnation of the corruption of society and the desire to have politics based on virtue and on the general will that we were talking about earlier. Some people have said this was the root of 20th-century totalitarianism. We can certainly ask whether terror is an inherent part of all revolutions. Most revolutions go through a period of intense violence. Whether or not it's a product of circumstances more than ideas is debatable.
- 2.42** But I want to quote to you something that was said in a speech in the French Convention, the French Parliament, by the principal theorist and practitioner of terror, Maximilien Robespierre, who himself was guillotined at a fairly early age. I think he was only 34. This was all a very young man's revolution. He was certainly influenced by Rousseau, and he insisted that terror is an emanation of virtue. And this is his speech of

February 1794, and it seems to me, as I say, it recalls Rousseau's condemnation of the corruption and frivolity of 18th-century society. This is Robespierre.

- 2.43 "We will substitute morality for egoism, probity for honor, the empire of reason for the tyranny of fashion, good people for good company, merit for intrigue, genius for cleverness, truth for brilliance, delight in goodness for satiety and voluptuousness, the greatness of man for the pettiness of great men, a magnanimous, powerful and happy people for an agreeable, frivolous, and wretched people. That is to say, all the virtues and all the miracles of the Republic for all the vices and all the absurdities of monarchy."
- 2.44 So virtue is to be imposed by terror. And it must be so because people have been so corrupted by society that only terror can cure them of their corruption. Well, I suppose the thing that's most known about the French Revolution is the guillotine. But it was a period that, however dreadful, was fairly short-lived. What happened is that the chaos and uncertainty of the Revolution gave way, first of all, to a rather corrupt oligarchy, and then to a dictatorship, the dictatorship of General Napoleone Buonaparte, or Napoleon Bonaparte, as he was Gallicized. He was Corsican, as I'm sure you know.
- 2.45 Then under Napoleon, to return of a monarchy, a new-style monarchy in which there's a famous painting by David. David was an all-purpose political painter. He served in successive regimes. One of his great paintings is of Napoleon's coronation. I suppose the most famous thing about Napoleon's coronation is Napoleon crowns himself. The Pope is there, but Napoleon is not crowned by the Church. He's crowned by himself by his own power and his own merit. One of his generals is supposed to have said to him, "It was a wonderful ceremony, your Majesty. The only thing missing were the hundreds of thousands of men who died destroying what you just reestablished." He didn't get promoted.
- 2.46 So what had happened? Well, maybe it's a pattern of revolution. You get the breakdown of the old regime and a time of optimism and unity. Then you get a period of continuing disorder as new conflicts emerge. Then you get a period of chaos and violence, an economic breakdown, and finally you get the restoration of order by some new dictatorship, which is often more efficient and more ruthless than the previous one. That seems to be the cycle of revolutions, or of many revolutions. And that was Napoleon.
- 2.47 What about the rule of Napoleon? Well, there is quite a lot to be said in his favor. He was a modernizer, if you think that's good. He's been called the last of the enlightened despots, though in rather extreme form. But I think that Napoleon certainly, like Frederick II of Prussia or Joseph II of Austria, saw himself as modernizing an archaic system. He creates a new system of laws, which is still used in parts of Europe and indeed in France. He liberates serfs wherever his armies reach. He liberates religious minorities. He abolishes the ghettos in Italy and Spain. He abolishes, if I remember rightly, the Spanish Inquisition.

- 2.48 So, many people followed him as the man who was bringing Europe out of the dark ages into a genuine enlightened period. And he was not a Stalin or Hitler, nothing like it. And indeed, he was admired, as you may know, by the great German philosopher and statesman Goethe, and by the great composer Ludwig van Beethoven, who dedicated one of his symphonies to Napoleon. So a lot of people thought Napoleon was a great blessing to Europe. Beethoven changed his mind afterwards. But nevertheless, for a time, Beethoven was very impressed, as many people were.
- 2.49 But eventually, what brought Napoleon down was not the things that he did domestically in his reforms, but what he did across Europe in terms of the blood and treasure and disruption that his wars caused. Assuming that they're his wars, a little more about that in a moment. About 2 million battlefield deaths, not counting all the collateral damage, which was very severe. Why did this happen? Was it all down to Napoleon's insane ambition? He himself is supposed to have said, "I wanted to rule the world. Who wouldn't have, in my place?"
- 2.50 The great distinguished historian Paul Schroeder has written a great book about this period, says that one thing he said about Napoleon is he didn't know how to make peace. And it's true. He was unwilling or unable to make a sustainable peace with other states. Why is this? Was it personality? It may be that he felt himself to be so much a parvenu that he could not rely on being accepted for long unless he could prove his constant military domination. It could be because he didn't know what to do with the army. What would he do with all these soldiers if he stopped his wars?
- 2.51 In this sense, there is a similarity, I suppose, in a way with the Nazi Germany. France was living off looting much of Europe. How would you untangle all that? It was difficult for Napoleon to make peace, but he didn't really try. And yet he was unable to win. He couldn't defeat Britain or Russia. And as I said before, France was very powerful and never more powerful than under Napoleon, but it could not be both the leading land power and the leading sea power. Therefore, you could say its final defeat was inevitable. Napoleon, after his defeat, said, "All my wars came from England." And eventually, all the other states, most of whom had been his allies at some time or another and had thought you could do a deal with Napoleon, all realized that you couldn't, that he was a danger to everybody, and he was a danger to European civilization.
- 2.52 Many of his own followers also thought that. His ministers, his generals began to think, this man is crazy and he's going to destroy us all. We have to get rid of him. A great alliance of all the other European states, largely paid for by Britain, defeated Napoleon. He was forced to abdicate in 1814, forced by his own army. He was rather gently treated. He was sent as Prince of Elba, had his own little tiny kingdom off the coast of Italy. But he returned from Elba to France in 1815, seized power again, and started another round of wars, which didn't last very long because, as you know, he was

defeated on the 18th of June 1815, at Waterloo by an international army, commanded by the Duke of Wellington.

- 2.53** And that was the end of Napoleon and the end of the second Hundred Years' War, and for some people, the end of the Enlightenment. All this was the fault of enlightened rationalism. You had to go back. Burke was dead by this time, but Burke had disciples. You have to go back and rediscover the religious and traditional links that held European society together. One of Burke's admirers, Joseph de Maistre, said, "It's crazy to think that a people can invent their own government any more than saying that they could invent their own language. We inherit these things. They make us. We don't make them."
- 2.54** Paul Schroeder, whom I mentioned a minute ago, has written of the transformation of European politics because the rulers of the major states agreed, or at least tried to agree, that they would prevent further devastating wars because these were so damaging and so dangerous, because wars brought revolutions. That's what happened to Louis XVI. You don't want to end up on the guillotine. Therefore, you don't want wars. Therefore, the great states have got to join together to prevent this in future. The Tsar Alexander of Russia called this the Holy Alliance. He was a very religious man, rather mystically religious, and he wanted it to be a Holy Alliance between the European states.
- 2.55** The British Foreign Secretary Castlereagh called this a piece of sublime mysticism and nonsense. But Castlereagh agreed that the great powers must agree to keep the peace, and they signed a treaty to maintain peace for 20 years in the first instance. And this was broadly successful. There was no general European war for a century, compared with the almost constant war of the previous two and more centuries. And this was a pretty extraordinary success, an extraordinary achievement.
- 2.56** And it became common to think of Europe as an entity, to talk about the concert of Europe, which was an agreement between the European states, especially the great states, to act as a collective policeman. And someone has suggested this was the first attempt at European integration. It was certainly something that you could see as a foreshadowing of the League of Nations or the United Nations in the 20th century. If states have conflicts or disagreements, they should meet together diplomatically; they should negotiate. If necessary, there should be international conferences to solve these problems without war.
- 2.57** And as I say, this was really, in many ways, remarkably successful. Though it was based on the assumption that Europe could stay, in a way, as it had been before the French Revolution. There wasn't really a restoration, but there was at least some desire for a restoration. Europe would go back to being a Europe of monarchies, of multinational states, of aristocratic government. After all, the aristocrats were the great cosmopolitans; if they couldn't keep the peace, who could? And that Europe could,

therefore, through political and social conservatism, could maintain peace and prevent revolution.

- 2.58** This, people like Castlereagh were always dubious about. You couldn't hold the lid on forever. And there he was right. And this is the subject of my next lecture. There were so many dynamic forces—economic, social, political, and cultural—that Europe was inevitably to change hugely over the next few generations. And also, partly for that reason, there were radicals in all countries for whom the French Revolution was not a deterrent, but a model. We must do this again, and this time we must get it right. And above all, Europe began to change into a new and unprecedented society, urban and industrial, and it spread its own model around the world. And those will be the subjects of my next two lectures. Again, thank you.
- 2.59** You mentioned that in the 18th century, the population of England grew a lot faster than France. Why do you think that was?
- 2.60** I think it was more that the population of France slowed down. I don't think anybody knows why. I don't think there's a very satisfactory answer, as I say. It may be partly the consequence of defeats and the shocks of the revolution and the Napoleonic wars, but it seems to have started slowing down seriously in the 1840s.
- 2.61** It could have been a lesser influence of religion because, of course, various forms of, primitive forms of contraception were regarded as sinful. So a lesser influence of religion may have meant that people were able to control their numbers of their children. It may be that a more meritocratic society, as the French thought of themselves, meant that there were advantages in not having too many children because then you could educate your small number of children better. You could say the French anticipated what has been the general reaction of most societies to modernization, to reduce the number of their children. But the French certainly did it first.
- 2.62** And it caused huge worry among many generations of French politicians who thought, in a way rightly, how can France remain a great power when the number of its people is not increasing in the way that the populations of all other countries are increasing? General de Gaulle wanted a France of 100 million people. And of course, France is twice the size of Britain, so it could have twice the population. It could have 140 million people without noticing, if you see what I mean. But of course, it still has 60-odd. The numbers have certainly increased much more slowly than in any other country. But an interesting conundrum.
- 2.63** So the question is about universal suffrage and how the rights of women, there's a question mark. But also in England, the Catholics weren't allowed to vote either. Could you say that Catholics weren't considered citizens either?
- 2.64** Yes, in some ways they were not. In those countries where there was a vote was not, at this time, and indeed for quite some time, considered an individual human right. It was

like being a member of a jury or holding some public office. In other words, you could say, well, what should be the qualifications for allowing someone to participate in political life? It wouldn't be for everybody. It would be for some people. And I'll come to this in another lecture. The numbers actually were still quite small, even at the end of the 19th century.

2.65 But it was only once you began to think that it was somehow a human right for everybody to be able to vote that then you said, well, how can you say that women shouldn't vote? They're human, after all. The answer to that was usually, "But they can't be soldiers." And as voting often means going to war, how can you allow women to vote when they can't fight? And the real reason was often, though this was said on the quiet, the problem with giving women the vote is that they tend to vote for Conservatives. And therefore, we don't want to encourage the Conservatives by giving women the vote. That was true in Britain. The Labour Party and the Liberal Party were very hesitant about giving women the vote.

2.66 And in France, the left, too, was afraid that women would vote for the right, which they probably did. I remember a colleague of mine setting as an examination question, if German women had not been given the vote, would Adolf Hitler ever have come to power? Discuss. But yeah, there were lots of reasons why there were hesitations in giving women the vote. And of course, purely a sense that, I'm the master in my own house. I don't want my wife or daughters doing things that I wouldn't approve of.

Lecture 3: Industry and Innovation

At a glance — Industry and innovation.

- 3.1 My first two lectures spoke of ideas and political events that changed world history, but the truly and even literally Earth-shattering changes, changes that in the long view of the history of humanity make the thoughts of Rousseau or the acts of Napoleon seem episodes of merely local and temporary interest, were happening at a quite different level and at first were barely noticed. So these next two lectures I'm calling Europe's Century, because I think that's what it was, and this one I'm calling Cities, Factories, and Nations.
- 3.2 So what was happening? A few examples. Somebody invented a pump for draining coal mines in 1712. Somebody invented a gadget for spinning cotton thread faster in 1764. Somebody invented an iron-making process in 1783. These were a few of the symptoms of a still rather mysterious and much debated socioeconomic transformation. It started essentially in England, and it would spread across most of Europe and eventually the world. Indeed, the transformation is still far from complete.
- 3.3 It's traditionally called the Industrial Revolution, of course. More precisely, it's the change from an organic economy to a mineral economy, from an organic economy dependent on power from wind, water, and human and animal muscle power, to a mineral economy in which power comes from coal, later oil, and eventually, I suppose, uranium, unless we manage to move back to an organic economy reliant on wind and water.
- 3.4 The term "Industrial Revolution" was invented in the 1820s by a French economist who was comparing it with the political revolution in France, but the term only became popular, generally, in the late 19th century. As with the Enlightenment, people didn't realize, they didn't think, wow, we're living through the Industrial Revolution because it was happening bit by bit in many different places. Leaving behind an organic economy now sounds bad. Wasn't it the industrial revolution that began pollution and global warming? Isn't this yet another thing that Europe should be ashamed of? Some people have said that. I think even Boris Johnson, the British Prime Minister, said something like that.
- 3.5 But even if we take this view, we would have to accept that most of us today would not be alive. Indeed, most of us today should not be alive. And also that most who were alive would exist in conditions we would consider extreme poverty, would die young, often in extreme suffering. Many women died in childbirth, for example. Of the survivors, few would have an education, few would ever travel more than a few miles from their birthplace. In short, we would be living like people in and before the 18th century.

- 3.6 Eighteenth-century Europe, led by England, began this process, which was the greatest change in human existence since the gradual development of agriculture in the Stone and Bronze Ages. Just to give you a figure, over the previous three centuries, total global per capita wealth had increased by less than 50% in three centuries. Over the next two centuries, it would increase by more than 700%, 14 times faster. We're rightly concerned with global pollution, but it's worth noting that the biggest source of greenhouse gases at the time of the industrial revolution and long after, was not coal-burning factories, but rice cultivation in China. The total production of CO₂ by agriculture remained larger than that produced by industry until 1960.
- 3.7 So we can't put too much blame on the steam engine. I suppose the real blame is us, and how many of us there now are. How can we explain the change from organic to mineral? And where did it happen? Perhaps for the reasons I've already mentioned, the end of religious wars, the growth of a different attitude towards consumption and pleasure, it seems that people were working harder and buying more. This has been called the industrious revolution, as opposed to the Industrial Revolution—people working longer hours, working harder, spending more money on stuff.
- 3.8 The population was also rising very steeply. So demand for goods was growing and people were inventing ways of meeting the demand, just in the way Adam Smith would have or did explain. As he said, "We don't rely on the butcher and baker's charity for our bread and meat. We rely on their self-interest." They want to make money out of us, and that's a good thing. So that's what people were doing.
- 3.9 But why then and why there? The simplest explanation is that it emerged from an already quite advanced commercial economy in Western Europe with a relatively, and I stress relatively, high living standard. For example, this is, I think, a fairly shocking figure. England in 1760 was slightly richer than India and China in the year 2000. So labor costs were high. A laborer in London was paid about three times the wages of a laborer in Peking in 1750, and hence it was worth trying to improve productivity by technology. In other countries, it wasn't. You wouldn't bother. In fact, they tried; it didn't work.
- 3.10 You wouldn't bother introducing machinery into France or India because labor was so cheap, you didn't need machines. Just use people's handwork. That's the simplest, the most obvious explanation, and there are others. Some people have suggested legal and political conditions. There was law and order. There laws that protected property and inheritance and so on. There were cultural conditions that have often been stressed. Individualism, science, of course, the attitude to science that we've already discussed. Even Protestantism, the so-called Protestant work ethic. Did Protestantism make you work harder because you wanted to prove that you were a decent person?
- 3.11 Then there's a question of resources. Coal, essentially. I like simple explanations. I like this one. The reason the Industrial Revolution happened in England was because England had a lot of coal. Holland, the other rich and advanced economy, didn't have

coal. So it happened in England, not Holland. Now there's a new explanation, which is slavery and exploitation. Here again, we see the decolonization agenda. That's to say, industrialization had nothing to do with European skills or education or government. It was just that they stole it from the rest of the world. Is that true? Well, economic historians over and over again have shown that slavery had very limited overall economic consequences. It made some people very rich, but in the economy as a whole, it was small.

- 3.12 But some historians, one in particular, has recently gone further. The crucial process for making wrought iron, which I mentioned earlier, and which has been described as "the cornerstone of the Industrial Revolution," was, it has been claimed, stolen from slaves in Jamaica. They invented it; the English stole it from them. If you follow this logic, British and European wealth is based on theft and exploitation. So huge reparations must be paid. One Jamaican academic has demanded the equivalent of several years of Britain's total GDP in reparations. But though this is an exciting story, examination of the basic evidence has shown that it is in fact made up. After all, there's a lot of money involved.
- 3.13 The familiar term is the Industrial Revolution, so I'll call it that. It took off roughly in the period from 1750 to 1850 across Britain, Western Europe, the United States, and eventually, further afield. For example, among the first were India and Japan. It included a transport and communications revolution through railways and later steamships, postal services, and finally, a global telegraph system by undersea cables. Of course, we still use undersea cables for transmitting all our digital traffic.
- 3.14 And it saw the growth of towns and cities. Old cities like Birmingham, sorry, like London and Paris grew very fast. They were the two biggest cities in Europe. And there were new cities too, growing up, like Birmingham, Manchester, Lille, Essen, and so on. Did this make people's lives better or worse? For a long time, this was the hotly debated subject. We might also look today at cities like Mumbai and Shanghai, let's say. Does living in cities like that, often highly polluted, cramped living conditions, highly stressful, etc. Does that really make people's lives better or worse than if they'd stayed in their agricultural villages?
- 3.15 Well, you might say, surely it was up to them to choose which they preferred. But nevertheless, one could argue that, in fact, people's lives got worse because of going and living in crowded and unhealthy conditions. And indeed, there is some indication of things that happened to them. The death rate didn't necessarily improve for some years, anyway. And even people's heights, which is a way of measuring well-being, may have tended to fall. So maybe the Industrial Revolution made them worse off. But the best answer which I think is generally accepted now is that because population was growing so fast, as I mentioned, you would normally have expected a collapse in living standards. When populations grow fast in an economy whose productivity is limited, then inevitably, living conditions fall.

- 3.16** This was predicted by the Reverend Thomas Malthus in 1798 in a very, I suppose now notorious, a very influential book, in which he said, well, if you look at the figures, population always increases faster than food supplies can grow. This inevitably means disaster, and it leads to what are often called Malthusian checks. In other words, if the population has reached a level which cannot be sustained by the economy, then you will have famines or you will have wars or you will have diseases which will bring the economy back to a sustainable level. Well, of course, it might be that Malthus in the long run was right. It may be, if you take the view certainly of many Greens today, that's just where we're heading.
- 3.17** But what the Industrial Revolution did was certainly to put that off for a couple of hundred years, at the very least. In other words, it prevented a collapse in living standards by creating new wealth and new employment. And certainly, from around the 1850s, because of efforts to improve public health, to provide clean water, to improve the standards of food, to import food from areas where it could be made more cheaply, then ordinary people's lives certainly did improve materially and very fast. So, you could say at least things didn't get worse in the period from 1750 to 1850. And from about 1850 onwards, they certainly got much better all across Europe, America, of course, and many other parts of the world.
- 3.18** Now, this is more, I suppose, more doubtful, but you might say, and this is a subjective judgment in which your view is certainly as good as mine, maybe in other less tangible ways, society improved, or maybe not. For some people, certainly, for some people, not so much, because it became more mobile, more fluid. Living in a village, you knew your place. You knew what you were going to do for your whole life. You knew what would happen to your children after your death. Now all that becomes much less clear. There's more chances of succeeding and also more chances of failing. So life is more fluid. Society is more mobile.
- 3.19** Now, arguably, it was more fun. Somebody recently looked at workers' memoirs and found that some people were saying, well, actually, it's a lot more fun living in the town than in the village. And certainly it became more fun from the middle of the century when you got a great increase in popular entertainments, of which the most famous and certainly the most globally influential was the creation of football in the 1860s, which was originally a schoolboys' game and then a university game in Cambridge, where the rules were first laid down. So football becomes the great new urban global form of entertainment. And I suppose I'd have to admit, probably England's greatest ever or Cambridge's greatest ever contribution to world culture.
- 3.20** That's the end of the first part of this lecture, which is society changed forever and really very quickly, in the period, in the 100 years after 1750. The novelist William Makepeace Thackeray said, he wrote, "Those of us who remember the days before the railways remember that we were living an entirely different age." Of course, that's a feeling we all have now. We think, can you remember what it was like before the

internet and so on? I suppose this was the first time in human history that people had felt they were living through this kind of revolutionary change in their own lifetimes. So that's that.

3.21 I want to look at some effects of these changes, perhaps somewhat quickly. A new way of thinking and feeling, which we generally call Romanticism, which is another cultural revolution, a response to, in some ways, a rejection of Enlightenment rationalism, which Romantics often see as soulless. These people who talk all the time about reason and the intellect, they miss out so much about emotion, about the spiritual side of life, about religion. That's what the Enlightenment misses, many of them say. They want to get back to a kind of culture in which emotion and feeling and intuition are seen as important in some way, as the most important thing.

3.22 Also, in some ways, Romanticism is a rejection of the new urban and technological society seen as dirty and crude. In some ways, we're still back to Rousseau again and the cult of nature. Two very different examples I'm giving you, which are very different and yet both very typical. If there was more time, we could also talk about music, literature, architecture, and so on. But there are two paintings here. Turner's painting, *Rain, Steam, and Speed*, from 1844. And Delacroix's painting, *The Death of Sardanapalus*, from 1827. On the face of it, these have absolutely nothing in common, in subject or in style. One is a rather impressionistic study of a steam train in a rainstorm, painted in a very loose and fluid manner. The other is a very detailed painting of a historical or mythological scene, in fact, of King Sardanapalus, who's about to be overthrown by his enemies, who orders his slaves to murder all his concubines. It's a rather, slightly erotic and very highly colored scene.

3.23 So they have nothing in common in subject or style, indeed. But what both have in common is that both are a rejection of earlier artistic orthodoxy. We don't any longer follow the old rules. We do it the way we think is right. Both are a very personal response to the subject, showing emotion, self-expression—and art becomes a way of expressing individual feeling in a way that was not true of classical art or music, which is often consciously following earlier models. What we want to do is, do it the way it was done in Aristotle's day and do it perfectly. Now it's saying the rules no longer apply. I, as an individual artist, express my feelings, my intuition, and my understanding of the world.

3.24 The artist, in many ways, becomes, or at least claims to be, a visionary. The artist is the great—Shelley, I think, says the poet is the great legislator of mankind. You get lots of people saying this kind of thing, and perhaps in a sort of way, we still believe it. We think that the purpose of art is to teach us things. It's to shock us, to make us reconsider our view of the world. This is new.

3.25 Romanticism affected and still affects our way of looking at things. And it also had an effect on public life and politics. I'm not saying Romanticism caused political changes. The growth of cities and of industries does that. But Romanticism helps to shape, I

think, how people responded to these changes. Perhaps the most famous revolutionary painting ever was also by Delacroix, *Liberty Leading the People*. It shows a symbolic female figure holding a tricolor flag, who is leading a crowd of revolutionaries, a boy, a student in a top hat, a worker, and they're trampling over the bodies of the troops of the reaction as they create a new future.

3.26 It seems to me this is a romantic idea of popular action. It's a great heroic, epic gesture. And what we're talking about now, at least I think we can properly call it the Age of Revolutions. It begins in 1789, of course. But in Paris, you have another revolution in 1830, which is Delacroix's painting, another one, or attempted one, in 1832, 1834, 1839, 1848, 1851, 1870, 1871, all these in Paris. And finally, in 1871, this whole Romantic revolutionary period comes to an end. I'll say a little more on that later. But this is the idea of revolution as a bold, epic, sacrificial gesture. So the Romantic idea of politics, I would say, is heroic, popular, dramatic, poetic, whereas the reality was often accidental, confused, and usually disappointing.

3.27 However, although revolution is very important, or the idea of revolution, I think even more important and more clearly linked to Romanticism is a new ideology or a pretty new ideology, which is that of nationalism. It seems to me that nationalism is very closely entangled with Romanticism. The simplest definition of nationalism would be that every nation should be a self-governing state. Or another way of putting it would be to say that the cultural and the political should be identical. This is different from 18th-century patriotism, which I mentioned in an earlier lecture, because now it becomes linked with a certain culture and language. In other words, it's what is often called ethnic nationalism, as opposed to civic patriotism. It's linked to an ethnic group, not simply to the inhabitants of a state.

3.28 So for example, the French Revolution could see itself as a nation, but it could be an expanding nation. It could take in Belgium, it could take in Holland, it could take in great lumps of Germany and Italy, and it would still be the French nation because its people had chosen to be French citizens. Nineteenth-century nationalism would say, well, that's completely absurd. A nation is usually a language group. So one socialist German poet said, "Germany"— which didn't yet exist as a single state—"Germany is everywhere where the German language is heard," and nowhere else by implication. It's ethnic rather than civic. It's linked with language.

3.29 We can also see Romantic nationalism expressed in art, music, the interest in history. Of course, there's a huge amount to say about that if we had another eight lectures on Romanticism. Ernest Gellner thought that you could explain this by saying that language and education become crucial to identity, to personal identity, in an industrial urban society. In a pre-industrial society, people speak lots of different languages. There may be a different dialect in every valley or even every village. It doesn't really matter because people don't travel very far. In any case, most of them are not educated and most of them are peasants, so it doesn't matter. Insofar as there is a

higher language, it may well be Latin. Or in the case of England, in the Middle Ages, it might be French. So what? It doesn't matter.

- 3.30** But in the 19th century, people start moving, people start looking for jobs in cities. Their language, the language they speak, the culture they belong to, becomes crucial in their life chances and in the way they feel about themselves. Now, that may not be the only explanation, but it seems to me a very sensible explanation and a pretty simple one. And Gellner, indeed, reaches the conclusion that it's nationalism that makes nations, not nations that make nationalism. In other words, often a nationalist minority, often of intellectuals, students, artists, say, "We are the Czech nation, the Irish nation. We are going to make this nation a reality." At first, most people don't care. Most people are peasants. What could they care about this? But in the end, it's often a top-down creation of the nation in which you are made to learn a language.
- 3.31** Italy, great example of a successful nationalist movement. Most people in Italy didn't speak the same language. They spoke various dialects, which were often incomprehensible to each other. But the nationalists say, "There should be a single Italian language, and you must learn it at school, and you must learn it at university, and then we will become a real nation." It's really an urban middle-class phenomenon, though interestingly or ironically, they tended to like peasant life and folk traditions, sometimes invented. There are numerous cases of, for example, musicians who set out to write folk music. There are people who invent folk poetry.
- 3.32** Nationalism is a form of radicalism against the old regime, against the old regimes that were often restored after the fall of Napoleon, against the aristocracies. The aristocracy is a very cosmopolitan class. You have a lot in common with other aristocrats in other countries, socially, politically; you may intermarry and so on. To be told that what really matters is the nation—we've already seen this in the case of the French Revolution—if the nation is sovereign, you monarchs and you aristocrats are not. You have no right to rule the nation because every member of the nation is an equal, at least in some senses. It's a form of radicalism, or at least it may begin as a form of radicalism.
- 3.33** Two examples of a conflict—I'm talking a lot of conflicts, of course, within, let's say, the broad nationalist stream. On one hand, Giuseppe Garibaldi, Romantic revolutionary. He fights for freedom in South America. He comes back to Italy, fights for freedom in Italy. And eventually he leads a remarkable, heroic, if you like, or foolish, revolt of the thousand, about a 1,000 men who land in Sicily and start a nationalist revolt in Sicily. Then it spreads to the Italian mainland. It causes the collapse of most of the governments in Italy, and eventually Italy is indeed united. But it was not the Italy that Garibaldi wanted. He wanted it to be a democratic republic. It turned out to be a monarchy with very restricted political rights, which immediately set about crushing major rebellions.
- 3.34** So you could say, well, it looks as though the nationalists are able to bring down systems, but not necessarily create them. And a very different nationalism, really, won

out. The great exponent of this was the Prussian aristocrat Otto von Bismarck, who said a number of pithy things. "If there has to be a revolution, we prefer to make it, rather than suffer it." In other words, we will take over this movement and we will make sure it turns out the way we want it. And Bismarck is the big winner and the big political transformer of Europe. He defeats Austria, he defeats Denmark, he defeats the other German states, and finally, he defeats France. All planned wars, all cold-bloodedly planned.

- 3.35** And he said quite openly in a famous or notorious speech in the Prussian Parliament in 1862, he said, "The great questions of the day will not be settled by speeches and majority decisions. That was the mistake of 1848"—the 1848 revolutions—"but by blood and iron." And indeed, he was right. Blood and iron were what won out. Europe was transformed by nationalism and would still continue to be transformed by nationalism for a very long time yet. But the great changes at this time were the creation of Italy and the creation of Germany and a new balance of power in Europe.
- 3.36** But there was another great political change, which was also connected with the social and economic changes that I've been talking about, was, of course, a broadening demand, strongest in towns and cities among the middle classes and the working classes, for greater rights. Again, in pre-industrial society, not many people had rights. The clergy had rights, the aristocracy had rights, the landowners had rights, but peasants didn't have rights. No one thought they should, or not very many people thought they should, and probably not many of them thought they should, really.
- 3.37** The idea of a peasant going into Parliament was pretty strange. In 1789, when France elected its first National Assembly, there was one peasant in the whole, out of the whole group, and he was a kind of mascot. But now you're talking about big city populations and large urban, millions of people living in cities. They want greater rights. But how would they get these rights? Well, there's a choice in a way. You either fight for them or you argue for them, to put it simply. What are the rights you want?
- 3.38** Well, you want the political liberties to speak, to meet, to write, to publish, to organize, which one liberal politician in France called the necessary liberties, because they're the things that make everything else possible. You want economic rights. Some people want free trade, freedom to combine, which is to say, to form trade unions, to go on strike. Some demand the right to work. Society has the obligation to give you a job if you haven't got one, and the right to welfare. Also religious and intellectual rights, the right to be religious or indeed the right to be irreligious. And also, I suppose, finally, political rights, the right to be represented, to have the vote, the right for governments to be accountable to the people. All these are the rights that are being demanded, but how do you do it?
- 3.39** I said earlier that this was the age of revolutions, and Bismarck—I quoted him a moment ago—pointed to 1848 as a mistake. But the revolutions across Europe culminating in 1848 and usually starting off in France, the Austrian statesman

Metternich famously said, "When Paris sneezes, Europe catches cold." And often, if there was a revolution in France, it would spread. And in 1848, that's precisely what happened. And you can actually follow. You can draw a map with circles on it showing how the news of revolution in Paris spreads by train, by steamboat on the rivers, by the arrival of newspapers. And when the news comes through, then you get a revolution breaking out in Austria, in Germany, in Italy.

3.40 But this great popular revolution, the springtime of the peoples, as it was called, failed. I haven't got time to go into why, but the main reason is that the revolutionaries soon showed their limited ability to govern the divisions among themselves—class divisions, too—and also because conservatives essentially held onto the levers of power, which in the long run means the army. Power grows out of the barrel of a gun, as Mao Zedong famously put it. And so what happened after 1848 is that conservatives returned to power, but often a different kind of conservative, of whom Bismarck was one example, a highly conservative figure, a reactionary figure, but one with a realism to say, as you will recall, if there has to be a revolution, we intend to make it. So no longer do you stand still, you take control of what's going to happen, and you offer people things in return for their good behavior.

3.41 The last great outbreak of revolution in 19th-century Europe was in 1870 to '71 in Paris, and it ended in a bloodbath. And it led—the phrase that I like, the distinguished French historian François Furet to say, "Amid Paris in flames, the French Revolution said farewell to history." If you see this whole period from 1789 to 1871 as the time when people felt that revolution was going to happen and revolution was the way in which they would finally get whatever it was, democracy, national rights, a republic, then 1871 was the end of that period because it finally shows that this is not going to work. "The French Revolution says farewell to history."

3.42 So what's the alternative? Of course, it is through peaceful or fairly peaceful pressures. Though how peaceful they were depended largely on governments. A major occasion of violence were strikes. Workers want to organize. They want to be able to demand wages. They want to be able to demand jobs. And governments usually forbid this and arrest those who try to go on strike, who use troops to suppress strikes, who bring in workers to break strikes. This is a cause of violence and repression in most countries or in many countries. If the state continues repression, it pushes workers towards more violent action, riots, the sabotage, machinery breaking, and so on.

3.43 And then often more violent reaction by the police or the army. You also have the rise of socialism of various kinds from the 1830s onwards. At the early days, what Marx called utopian socialism, which essentially we're aiming at some sort of utopian view of small communities, which would be, you might think, a bit like Rousseau, living out in the country, sharing everything in common, leading a perfectly happy life, and that everybody else, when they realized how wonderful this was, they would all copy it and it would all happen all over the world. The only people who came anywhere near to

doing this were religious communities in America—the Shakers, among the most famous, but at least people who wanted to live a community life with everything in common, and saw competition, capitalism, as the enemy.

- 3.44 Then later on, from the middle of the century, you get mass parties, many of them increasingly influenced by Marx, from the 1880s, the 1890s, the 1900s. And in some countries, these socialist parties become major and indeed, even the largest political parties, owners of newspapers, of social clubs, running trade unions, running welfare organizations, and so on. Should socialists be revolutionary or reformist? And there was a very angry division here in which the pure revolutionaries accused the others of being cowards and traitors.
- 3.45 Marxism, it seems to me, is a bit ambivalent here. If you think of Marxism, Marx predicts, has a whole theory of history, in which revolutions will inevitably happen when the conditions are right. So when one class becomes so powerful, it's able to take over power, then you will have a revolution. But if the conditions are not right, then you won't have a revolution. For Marx, or at least for many Marxists, if you're living in Germany or France or Britain in the 1890s, you think, well, OK, Marx says there's going to be a revolution inevitably one day, but clearly the day has not yet come. Therefore, there's no point in starting riots or shooting policemen because we know that revolution is a scientific process and you can't push it faster than history will allow. It's very easy for Marxist parties to become, in practice, reformist, to stand for elections in Parliament.
- 3.46 The exception, or at least the important exception—oh, by the way, they thought that, well, maybe one day revolution will come, but it may come peacefully. It will come because of some future breakdown of the capitalist system. And everybody will then say, thank goodness the socialists are here to come and sort things out for us, and everyone will peacefully accept a revolution. The great exception to this is Lenin in Russia who creates the Bolshevik Party in 1903, dedicated to revolution by violence. You could say the main reason for this is because Russia is very different from Germany or France, and you haven't got much choice.
- 3.47 But Lenin's theory is a development of Marxism, in a sense. I'm not going to go into detail here, but basically says that you can make a revolution happen even earlier than history would tend to suggest. You can have a vanguard, i.e., people like Lenin and his friends, who know what you've got to do, who know how to carry out a revolution, and they can use the power of the state to make a revolution happen. You don't have to wait for it to happen on its own. You can make it happen. And indeed, he looked back to the French Revolution and the Jacobins, and said, look, the Jacobins, people like Robespierre, they were just a bunch of bourgeois, but nevertheless, they managed to make a pretty good revolution. So surely we, 100 years later, can do it much better, and we will.

- 3.48** So that was the division within socialism. But there was a general pressure for greater voting rights in Britain, which was generally thought to be the epitome of reformism, of gradual reformism. The working class, or at least the respectable, as they would have said at the time, the respectable part of the working class, was given the vote in 1867 and 1884. In France, meaningful manhood suffrage came in 1870. In Germany, there was manhood suffrage after 1871 for the Reichstag, though this had very limited power. So Western Europe was a country in which there was increasing political representation of ordinary people, of working people.
- 3.49** But in other states, in Austria, and only much later in Russia in the early 20th century, was there representation. And their voting was unequal. It wasn't one man, one vote. It was rich man has more votes than poor man, basically. And there were various clever ways of doing that. And also there were usually upper chambers which could make sure that the lower house, which was elected, was not given too much freedom. Of course, we still have that in the form of the House of Lords, though sometimes the House of Lords seems to be more left-wing than the House of Commons nowadays. But we still have the House of Lords.
- 3.50** And of course, in all countries, or almost all countries, there is a Senate which is elected in a different manner, the original aim of which was to prevent the lower house from being too radical. Anyway, nevertheless, despite the limits, there was the emergence of a new democratic political leader who operated through parties, through parliament, through electoral campaigns and through oratory, through speechmaking. Two leading examples of these, one in France, one in Britain, were Léon Gambetta and William Ewart Gladstone. The equivalence in America would be Lincoln, clearly.
- 3.51** These are men who go around the country addressing public meetings. Their speeches are reported in the popular press. They become great celebrities, as well as parliamentary politicians, and both of them become the leaders of the governments of their countries. Gladstone was the first senior British politician to go around making public speeches. And his conservative opponent, Disraeli, said it was very undignified for a statesman to go around spouting in public like a demagogue. But Gladstone did that. He made very long speeches, and crowds of people came, and he attracted quasi-religious following. Indeed, the churches were very important as well in spreading democratic politics.
- 3.52** You can actually hear Gladstone's voice. You can go on YouTube and actually hear how he sounded in old age. In fact, he says something like, oh, you can hear my voice now, but it's not what it once was when he could address thousands of people in public. Anyway, listen to him. It's a remarkable experience.
- 3.53** Women, too, had particular demands, though they weren't, at this time, quite the same as men's demands, or they weren't allowed to be quite the same. They were the right to work. There's a wonderful picture here, which I like, of a young woman. They were called pit brow girls. This was in the north of England. Women who worked at coal

mines. The law would not allow them to go underground anymore. This was seen as a great reform to protect women, but it also protected men because it meant that women could not compete with men. But the women insisted that they had the right to work on the surface, helping to sort the coal. And there was a big campaign to let them keep this right because some men wanted to stop them.

- 3.54** The right to work, which many trade unions were not in favor of. They thought women were cheap labor. Women should be staying at home looking after the children. If women were allowed to work, it would bring men's wages down. This was for a long time the official view. Indeed, I'm old enough to remember when many men still thought this and even some women. Women wanted the right to work. They wanted rights to education. In hardly any country, if any country, could women go to university until the second half of the 19th century, and then in very small numbers.
- 3.55** They wanted rights to property. Could married women own property? Or did their property become their husband's property, as it did in many countries? What about rights within the family? Did they have the rights over their own children? Or if their marriage broke up, would the husband automatically take the children? Could the husband decide everything that was done in the family? Had they got the right to divorce? I mentioned earlier that the French Revolution brought in the right to divorce, but it was pretty quickly abolished when women started using it.
- 3.56** And eventually, though this came quite late, would they have the right to vote? There was a trend towards accepting votes for women in national elections. They often had the vote in local elections where it was thought quite appropriate, as this local elections were about things like schools, welfare, roads, and so on. That was fine for women. It was part of their legitimate interest. But in most countries, in fact, I think in no country and in no major country did women have the national vote as late as 1900, because this was thought to be a matter of war and peace decisions which women were not involved in. But it took the First World War to give the final push, and then it came very, very, very quickly.
- 3.57** But for women, too, they had a choice. Should their campaigns be peaceful or not peaceful? Two extreme cases would be the French revolutionary Louise Michel, who is shown here being arrested in 1871. She narrowly escaped the death penalty and was sent off to exile in New Caledonia, came back and became a well-known anarchist writer and speaker. Millicent Fawcett, the extremely respectable and intelligent and determined leader of the official women's suffrage movement in Britain, not the suffragettes who went round setting fire to things and chaining themselves to railings, but the women who tried to operate through the political system by persuasion.
- 3.58** And as I think I said earlier, men were often very reluctant to give women the vote for Parliament in all countries because it seemed that they were trespassing on what was properly a male preserve. But once the vote was seen as a human right, then there was no way you could properly deny it to women, though it took the First World War to give

the final push. So by the end of the century, there had been genuine movement in obtaining political and economic rights all across Western Europe and even the beginnings of it in Russia. Several countries had embryonic welfare systems. Workers' parties and trade unions were now generally accepted, although there still were occasionally violent strikes.

- 3.59** But it could now be said, which would have been unthinkable 50 years earlier, even by a conservative Prime Minister in Britain, A. J. Balfour, I quote, "There is no party that does not recognize to the full all that trade unions have done. Trade disputes have been carried on with wisdom and moderation." Well, when Balfour was born, trade unionists risked being arrested and, not long before that, being transported to Australia and so on. So a huge change had taken place.
- 3.60** But further east, in Eastern Europe, rights were uneven and were certainly not secure. I've given here a list of the extent to which votes had already been conceded or would be conceded. I'm just going to read out some of them which give a sense of how many people could now vote. France was the most democratic country. All men, all adult men, had the right vote, which meant 27% of the total population had the right to vote. In Greece, it was 23%, in Germany, 22%, but as I said, they didn't have much power. In Belgium, 21%, in Britain, 16%, in Denmark, 14%, in Italy, 10%. Not very many, but there were educational tests in Italy. Norway, 9%, Austria, 7%.
- 3.61** What about women? The first European country, well, it's not quite a country, which gave the vote to women in national elections was the Grand Duchy of Finland, which was part of the Russian Empire in 1906, in Norway in 1913, in Denmark in 1915, in Russia, Estonia, Latvia, Lithuania, 1917, after the Russian Revolution. And then in most countries, UK, Austria, Germany, Hungary, Poland, and others, in 1918. But then this may surprise you, in Spain, 1931, in France and Italy, not until 1945, and the very last was Switzerland in 1971. So no women had the national vote, really, in Europe until well into the 20th century.
- 3.62** And the reason was, I can't remember if I said this earlier, it was partly the idea that citizenship was male because it was connected with military, willing to fight for the country, also because it was thought that women would tend to vote for the right. So many left-wing parties were not very keen on giving women the vote. And because there was a patriarchal resistance to wives and daughters having the right to disagree politically with their fathers and husbands. So Catholic countries, I think, tended to be more, to be slower.
- 3.63** But there were also other demands which were not yet met and which would be very explosive in the future, which were demands for national rights. OK, we've seen Germany is united, Italy is united, but there are still large multinational empires and states. Austria-Hungary, Russia, to some extent Germany, which includes a large French and Polish population, and of course, Britain with Ireland. In all these countries,

national demands were not met. Nevertheless, there seemed to be reason for optimism at the end of the century.

- 3.64** This was a time when there was a general belief in Progress, with a capital P, and most Europeans were pretty content that they were experiencing Progress. Well, in Greek tragedy, hubris precedes nemesis, and when everything is going well, that's when things start to go badly. That's going to be the subject of my next but one lecture. But the next lecture is going to be on empires and globalization. Thank you.
- 3.65** I'm wondering if there has been a paradigm shift of a factor such as race or religion later on in history, and if so, at what point in time did that happen?
- 3.66** I don't think one can give a simple answer to that. Before the emergence of nationalism of the sort I've mentioned, people's identities were often defined by religion. I mentioned a moment ago the case of Ireland. Why were the Irish, or at least those in the south of Ireland, not happy to be part of the United Kingdom? The main reason is because they were Catholic and the rest were Protestant. In many countries, in Holland and Belgium, and in other countries in Central Europe, the division was, and to some extent often is, religious, or religion is the basis of ethnic identity. The difference between Serbs and Croats, for example, in other parts of the Balkans, it's very clear.
- 3.67** So I think religion was always there. Religion does indeed become, and I didn't really mention this, but religion does become a part of organized politics, partly as a result of democratization. Because once power spreads beyond the aristocracy, especially towards the peasantry, towards their main sense of identity is often religious. And so you get in many countries the emergence of religious parties. The biggest party in Germany was the Catholic Party.
- 3.68** You get Christian democratic parties emerging in other countries and indeed in post-Second World War Europe, the largest parties in Italy and in France and in Germany, France for a time, and in Germany, Italy, for a long time, were Christian democratic parties, which were essentially based on religious affiliation. So religion is always there as part of this mix. And for some countries—Ireland I mentioned, Poland is another one, clearly—religion is a crucial part of their sense of national identity.
- 3.69** Now, the other part of your question was religion and race. Within Europe, I don't think that race—people used the word race, though they don't mean it in the sense that we mean it now. I don't think within Europe there is, until at least the end of the century, much of a racial element in politics, as a national element. The racial element in politics largely takes the form of antisemitism. So extreme German nationalism becomes identified with antisemitism. And the same in Russia.
- 3.70** What is the reason for that? Well, because the only— well, you could say, well, Jews are not really a race, but they were considered a race, that they were the only racial minority, clear racial minority, in countries like Poland, Russia, and so on. And therefore, they tend to be treated as the outsiders. And also because often Jews were

associated with aspects of modern life that conservatives didn't like. Jews were often involved in liberal politics, were in favor of human rights. And for those, many people saw the Jews as, therefore, the supporters of a kind of radicalism that was undermining the status quo.

3.71 You see that very clearly in Russia, where there's major violence against Jews in the late, in the 1890s, often orchestrated by conservative politicians. But that's the main racial element in European politics. Of course, there is a racial element, or there comes to be a racial element, in external, in Europe's relations with the outside world, which I'll come to in the next lecture. The only way I suppose you could say there is something that is akin to racism is a sense of, that different social classes were biologically different. I don't think this was ever a very common view, but it came to be accepted in some circles towards the end of the century.

3.72 Some people were afraid that the urban working classes were becoming degenerate. They were poisoning the purity of the race because they were, whatever, alcoholic, diseased, because they were immoral in their behavior, and therefore they had to be in some ways controlled or eliminated. Maybe people with no jobs should be put into camps. Maybe they should not be allowed to marry or have children. Maybe they should be sterilized. All these things were proposed by some people round about the turn of the century and often actually by people on the left. But there we are.

3.73 There's questions about, you mentioned Romanticism wasn't the driver for civilization. But could you not say that the shift of the patron of the creatives from the private to the public drove the nationalization of creativity? The devolution of creativity drove a change from an engineer to an inventor, and therefore technological advances, and therefore the industrial revolution?

3.74 That's a big question. I don't think I would see that. I'm not sure I can see much of a link between cultural movements and invention, if only because most Romantics— I mean, Turner may have been an exception in that he's one of the few people who did a painting of a railway train. But most Romantics are very suspicious of modernity and of innovation. They're ideal. As I said, it's an irony because most of them are middle class and live in cities, but their ideal is a rural society of folk-dancing peasants. That's basically it. And they tend to be often overtly hostile to factories, machinery, machine-made goods, and everything that stands for the modern world.

3.75 You touched on it a little bit, but could you just expand on the difference between nationalism and patriotism?

3.76 I would say, I mean, these two words, I think to some extent it depends on how, obviously, on how you use the words. If, by patriotism, you mean a feeling of loving your country— in other words, it doesn't necessarily have any political aspect at all. You could say, I like London. So what? That may mean you're a patriotic Londoner or

something like that. It's a silly example. If, on the other hand, you say London should become an independent state, then you become a nationalist.

- 3.77** If you like, nationalism is patriotism with an ideological aim. It doesn't say, and I think someone explained this rather well, I forget now who it was. A patriot may be quite happy with his country or her country as it is. I love Ireland. A nationalist is usually not very happy with the way things are and wants to make them different. We must make Ireland purer, stronger, more independent, and get rid of the people who are not purely Irish. That's what nationalism tends to become.
- 3.78** The way I was talking about 18th-century patriotism is also—and so I'd say there's another way you could talk about patriotism, which is another kind of ideology. The sort that was the ideology of Pitt, if you like, which is to say, people like me and my friends really represent the interests of the country. And you, the king, the ministers, you don't. That makes us the patriots, and you are not the patriots. So it's a political discourse, if you like, a form of political language.
- 3.79** What makes that into nationalism in my argument is to say that, once you say the nation is sovereign, that by definition makes you a nationalist. Because you're saying, as the French Declaration of the Rights of Man said, "The nation is the only source of power." Pitt would never have said that. I don't think he could have understood what it meant. Once you start saying the nation is the only source of power, it makes you, in a sense, a nationalist. And once you start saying we are not happy with the way the nation is, we've got to make it different, which may just mean we have to make it independent, then you become a nationalist.
- 3.80** But I mentioned the case of the Austro-Hungarian Empire or the Austrian Empire, a multinational empire. There were Poles, Italians, Germans, Czechs, Hungarians. You could say, well, look, I'm a Hungarian patriot, but I'm very happy living in the Habsburg Empire because I think it's a great system. It keeps us all happy. It keeps us all at peace. It's fine by me, but I'm very patriotic. I love Hungarian music. I do Hungarian dances in my spare time. I eat Hungarian food and all that, but I don't want to change things. Whereas a Hungarian nationalist would say, we are going to destroy the Habsburg Empire and we are going to make Hungary into a sovereign independent nation.

Lecture 4: Imperial Impact

At a glance — Imperial impact.

- 4.1 If, and I suppose it's not entirely sure, if we're still here in future centuries and if people are still writing history, when they get to the 19th century, they'll surely have a lot to say about the great age of European empires, which reach their greatest extent at the end of the 19th and the beginning of the 20th centuries. And there is a photograph here of the great Delhi Durbar of 1911, a grandiose occasion on which the King Emperor George V was present, the only time a British monarch was present at such an occasion. It seems to be an expression of huge power, but it was, I think it's clear, rather a façade.
- 4.2 But nevertheless, empires were important, and it may be that future historians will think that empires, rather than nations or parliaments or revolutions, were the most important historical phenomena of the 19th century. The historian Niall Ferguson, who's not wholly unsympathetic to empire, has suggested that the British Empire created the modern world. The cultural theorist Edward Said, who is one of the most famous critics of empires, came to a not-dissimilar conclusion. The British Empire, he said, had made the world one.
- 4.3 If they're right, then it might follow that much of the present-day controversy about empires and colonialism is deep down, or perhaps not very deep down, a debate about the modern world. If we reject the modern world, we reject the empires that did so much to create it. History is largely the history of empires—the Chinese, the Persian, the Roman, the Byzantine, the Aztec, the Ottoman, the Mughal, and many others. Of the European empires, the older empires, the Portuguese, the Spanish, the Dutch, still continued in part through the 19th, and indeed, well into the second half of the 20th centuries, though they lost much territory due to the Napoleonic Wars.
- 4.4 The British lost one empire in the 1770s, the 13 American colonies, but gained another, more or less simultaneously, in India, and continued to expand thereafter, reaching its greatest ever territorial extent in, I think, 1920, '21. Why did empires expand so much in the 19th century? If we look at a map of the world, very familiar map, we shall see that a very large part of the world was at one time covered by European empires or indeed by European colonies of settlement.
- 4.5 Why did they expand? Well, I've been thinking about this and I think there are at least nine reasons. I'm sorry there are so many reasons, but it's not entirely my fault. But I'd say one reason is that several major non-European empires, the Chinese, the Mughal, the Persian, and the Ottoman, were in various stages of decline, and this left a power vacuum for European states to step into. And also there was a power vacuum for other growing states or semi-empires in Africa and elsewhere.

- 4.6 Second, exploration by sea and land brought different societies into contact and made trade, migration, and aggression possible. Third, many parts of the world, particularly in Africa, Australia, and parts of America, had few, if any, strong and stable political organizations, and nothing that could be called a state. This made them vulnerable, and sometimes indeed made them willing to accept Western innovations, or at least regard them as inevitable.
- 4.7 Technological differences connected with industrialization. Weapons, transport, communications created much greater differences in power than had previously existed. Now I'm on my fifth reason. Population growth in Europe, but also in India and China and elsewhere increased pressure to migrate because this could relieve social pressures at home and hence be encouraged by governments. But population growth is a major cause of imperial growth.
- 4.8 Next cause is global trade. Increased global trade, which I've already referred to, made empire potentially profitable, or at least made it seem potentially profitable. I think probably in every case, practically, the hopes of easy money out of empire were disappointed, but both colonizers and colonized thought that this was economically beneficial.
- 4.9 Global instability, for all these reasons, made some people willing or eager, even, to accept imperial rule as better than being open to predators, slave traders, pirates, traders. And so there are a number of countries that actually asked to join empires, including Corsica, New Zealand, very famously, Fiji, and indeed, at one point, Morocco. There were some South American countries, too, that asked, could we join this great global system? Then finally, humanitarian lobbies, including missionaries and anti-slavery groups, often press their own governments to take over territories that were subject to violence and aggression. Those are the general reasons for imperial expansion in the 19th century.
- 4.10 So I mentioned the older empires that already existed. The British Empire was not quite as old as the others, but was growing dynamically. But towards the end of the century, in the final phase of imperial expansion, we had another lot of countries, Germany, Italy, the United States, and Japan, which joined in. And this was at a time, and this, I think, was the great imperialist illusion, that the world would be permanently divided into empires, that this was the shape of the future, and that they must, therefore, have their share.
- 4.11 The British colonial secretary, Joseph Chamberlain, put it like this famously in 1902. "The days are for great empires, not for little states." So you could imagine a world in future in which there might only be five or six global states, and you'd got to make sure you were one of them. This also acted as a stimulus to the British and the French—older empires, but now forced to react to other countries, particularly Germany, which was trying to expand its territory. And ironically, these imperialist ambitions became

most grandiose just as the age of empire was about to end, though the end was admittedly fairly long, drawn out.

- 4.12 I'm going to give you a quotation because I think it's quite good. It's from a French colonial official, writing in 1910, and he's describing the mixed and rather incoherent motives for why you should want to keep colonial territories. "We remain," he says, "because we're already here, because we want to believe that we can continue the conquest without great effort, because we do not want to lose the benefits of the sacrifices already made, because we consider the interests of the nation and of the natives who immediately attach themselves to this kind of enterprise, and finally, because the honor of the army, the prestige of the flag, and sometimes the existence of governments are at stake." So a whole lot of motives.
- 4.13 What I'd like to do is to look first in more detail at the largest of the empires, the British, and to see something about its characteristics and why it formed the way it did. I would say there are three things to remember. First, the most obvious, it was very big and complex. One historian has rightly called it a global mosaic of almost ungraspable complexity and staggering contrasts made up of literally hundreds of units, including self-governing dominions like Australia and Canada, internally autonomous protectorates like the Gulf States, dependent territories linked by treaty, and directly administered Crown colonies like Hong Kong.
- 4.14 Another historian, John Darwin, says we shouldn't think of this so much as an empire as a world system. I'll quote him. "The British Empire formed the core of a larger British world system managed from London. It was not a structure of global hegemony, holding in thrall the non-Western world. British power lay in combining the strength of its overseas components and managing them, not commanding them. It depended on the willingness of political and business elites in different parts of the world to acknowledge the benefits that membership of the British system conferred, and concede, sometimes grudgingly, that its various costs were worthwhile."
- 4.15 The British Empire prided itself on being, essentially, commercial, based on trade and economic development. And I suppose the best symbols of the British Empire are the cities that it helped to build—Bombay, Melbourne, Hong Kong, Singapore, Calcutta, Cape Town, all the rest. And many British commentators and politicians prided themselves on being part of a system which was more or less voluntary and which brought benefits. Because it was a commercial system, it grew in an unplanned manner, and British governments were actually often reluctant to take on new territories which were expensive and gave them more responsibilities.
- 4.16 So when there was expansion, it was often led by the men on the spot, as they were usually called, or in the case of India, by the East India Company, which began as a trading company and ended up as what we would nowadays call a quango, an autonomous non-governmental organization. So the Victorian historian, Sir John Seeley, famously said that the British Empire seemed to have been created "in a fit of

absence of mind," because there never seemed to be any plan behind it. It just grew spontaneously.

- 4.17** The French Empire, on the other hand, was largely desired, first of all, to keep up with the British. "We must not allow the Anglo-Saxon world of the future," as one influential political writer put it in the 1860s, "to grow up without French participation." And later, after their defeat by Germany in 1870, it was a way of compensating for its defeat, a way of trying to strengthen France by gaining territory overseas. Said one of its leading politicians, "The French people would not be content to count for no more in the world than a big Belgium."
- 4.18** So the British thought empire was mainly about commerce. The French convinced themselves it was about civilizing less-civilized peoples, and that this gave them the moral right to take possession of backward countries. And for that reason, France's Democratic Republic, after 1870, was particularly keen on imperial expansion, and much of the French left remained so as late as the 1950s.
- 4.19** Now, to go back to the British. It was a system, but it wasn't a huge power structure. It was managed with very small resources. And there is a dramatic picture here of the disastrous retreat from Kabul in 1842, in which a British army, a small British army, admittedly, was completely wiped out. I think there was one survivor by the Afghans. And there's a very dramatic oil painting of the last little group of 20 soldiers, stuck in the Afghan mountains, surrounded by Pathan warriors who are just about to wipe out. That was by no means the only military disaster in British imperial history. There are quite a few of them.
- 4.20** The reason is that the resources behind it were actually quite small. The Colonial Office, in 1903, consisted of only 113 clerks. The Indian Civil Service, which was the highest branch of Indian government, had only about 2,000 British officials to rule, what, 300 million people? Uganda in Africa, when it was taken over by Britain in the late 19th century, had only 25 British officials to govern a territory larger than the British Isles.
- 4.21** An elderly lady wrote to me recently about her own father's experience as a young colonial official in East Africa. When he'd left university, he was sent out there as a colonial official. He had to walk 200 miles to his post, build a mud hut as his headquarters, and then single-handedly try to keep the peace among warrior tribes. So this is not a huge, powerful structure. It's been very well described as a brontosaurus with huge vulnerable limbs, which the central nervous system had little capacity to protect, direct, or control. So it had to rely on broad acceptance by its peoples, on one hand, and not being attacked by other powers, which, of course, eventually did happen.
- 4.22** I think one of the best expressions of what it was like is a short story by George Orwell that some of you may know, called Shooting an Elephant. Orwell himself, in his young days, was a police officer in Burma during the British Empire period. He talks about how, as a young official, he was fetched out one day because an elephant, a rogue

elephant, had gone on the rampage and had killed a couple of people. So he, as a young man, had got to sort this out. So he got someone to go and borrow a rifle. And then he describes how he lay down in the road with the mad elephant 100 yards away and surrounded by a crowd of people who were watching him, who were the Burmese people.

- 4.23 And he says, they were watching me. I'd got to shoot the elephant because that's what they were expecting me to do. But if the elephant had come and trampled me, they wouldn't have minded. They would have thought it was all part of the show. And then he says at the end something like, this is what it was like. He says, you're always posing as the sahib who's got to do certain things. But you're not really controlling what's done. They, the situation, is controlling you. And I think there's a huge amount of truth in that. So the empire relied on broad acceptance and not being attacked.
- 4.24 Now, it was not, despite what many critics today repeat, a system essentially of violent oppression, racism, and exploitation. Or if it was, it was a very inefficient one. Even the East India Company, widely attacked, even in the 18th century, for its big profits, provided relatively cheap government to India. The empire from the 1830s to the 1950s became the world's main anti-slavery organization. In the 19th century, says one of its leading historians, Ronald Hyam, it had, I quote, "a profound sense of moral and religious purpose. It was at times brutal, exploitative, and ruthless, and so it can't be called an ethical empire," he says. "Nevertheless, it had an ethical policy."
- 4.25 Strengths and weaknesses of the British Empire. Well, I've listed them there, the pros and the cons. One, economic benefits, free trade. There was a large British market for colonial goods, a lot of it a cheap investment, technical expertise—that's a strength. A weakness, it cost a lot of money to British taxpayers. A strength, it had a strong navy. A weakness, it had a small army. It relied on acquiescence or cooperation from its subject peoples. But in the 20th century, that acquiescence or cooperation was being withdrawn. It offered its member states protection from other states and from non-state predators like slave traders, pirates. But on the other hand, it was very difficult to defend itself against multiple enemies.
- 4.26 Also, OK, the empire was Britain's biggest customer, and it was economically important. And here are a few figures comparing the British with the French. The French, as I said, was largely about prestige and keeping up with other countries. It never turned out to be very economically important to France, but the British Empire certainly was important to Britain. Whether it was profitable is another matter, but it was important. And here I've given you a few of the statistics.
- 4.27 Exports of goods, 35% of all British exports went to the Empire. For France, it was only a small fraction of their exports that went to their Empire. Investments in the Empire, 45% of total British investment was in the Empire. In France, it was only 9% of their overseas investments. To give an example of two West African colonies, the British colony, the Gold Coast, by the end of the century, was producing 55,000 tons of

chocolate a year. That was big export. In the Côte d'Ivoire, they were producing 47 tons. 55,000 tons, 47 tons. It shows the great difference in the economic importance of the British and the French Empire.

4.28 But who was actually benefiting from this? An authoritative economic summary of the costs and benefits to Britain concludes that it wasn't very important. It was not entirely negligible, but the economic benefits to Britain amounted to, he thinks, at most about 5 or 6% of national income. Not very much reward for a very big effort. Indeed, it may have had some damaging effects economically on Britain, in that it encouraged Britain to persist in certain industries such as textiles that largely were based on exports to the Empire, whereas countries like Germany were concentrating, and indeed the United States, were concentrating on more modern industries, such as chemicals, electrical industry, and so on.

4.29 Critics of empire today accuse them of exploitation and impoverishing their colonies. This was sometimes true, but it's also today sometimes used to excuse the failures of former colonies generations after they have become independent. And this has become part of nationalist rhetoric, an excuse for misgovernment today, and even used to justify demands for reparations. The argument has often been made by present-day nationalists that India, in particular, was impoverished by British rule. But this is not borne out by serious research by Indian economic historians.

4.30 What happened is that India was a big exporter of textiles in the 18th century, and it lost much of its overseas market, though in fact, its textile production continued to increase because it lacked for a time in technology, but not because the British were destroying its textile industry or preventing it from exporting, but it fell behind in technological terms. But when it caught up, later in the 19th century, Indian industry and commerce did rather well. By about 1900, India had the world's fourth largest textile industry after Britain, America, and Russia. So India is number four, and it had by far Asia's biggest railway network.

4.31 However, the British can be criticized for not fostering agriculture and rural welfare in India, and the probable reason is they didn't have the resources. As I've noted, imperial government was in fact quite weak. Nevertheless, what Darwin calls the British system did do much to create a global trading system much larger and more developed than anything that had previously existed. Some benefited from this, some did not. The beneficiaries included North America, Argentina, Australia, Malaya, and the Gold Coast —Ghana, as I mentioned, big chocolate producer. Those are the pros and cons of particularly the British Empire, its strengths and weaknesses, its economic advantages and disadvantages, and how it ran, as I say, on a shoestring.

4.32 I want to look at another, a different aspect of European expansion, which is not primarily to do with empires, but simply with population and migration. Millions left Europe as its population boomed. Millions went from Britain, Ireland, Italy, Germany, and Russia, of people desperate to improve their lives. No doubt, the ability to go to

places where there were already Europeans or European governments encouraged this and made it easier. Indeed, was often actively encouraged by home governments. But it's important to realize that most migration went not to European empires, but to the United States. The diagram on the screen shows the volume from Europe to America, which dwarfs all other movements of population. Others that are important are those from China, from India, and from Africa. But the overwhelming majority of European migration went to North America.

- 4.33 Migration is often today accused of creating genocide, but this is quite a recent accusation and relies on a very loose definition of genocide. One generally accepted case is the German war against the Herero people in southwest Africa. But there's little doubt that in most cases where indigenous populations fell, either permanently or for a time, the main cause was the arrival of diseases such as smallpox in populations that had no natural immunity. This was a disaster, but not a deliberate policy.
- 4.34 How did indigenous peoples react to the arrival of Europeans as traders, missionaries, conquerors, in some cases, rulers? Well, they responded in very different ways and contradictory ways. Some made alliances with European states, some resisted European states, some requested to join European empires, some collaborated with empires, some accepted opportunities given for education and trade. Some came into conflict with European settlers, some intermarried with European settlers. Some adopted European ideas, customs, and beliefs, such as Christianity. Some refused to work for Europeans. Others were eager to do so. Some took opportunities for better lives. Slaves were liberated. Women, the young, and lower castes also sometimes benefited.
- 4.35 There is a wonderful photograph here of the Zulu king Cetshwayo, who dressed in a rather smart suit when he came to London in 1882, soon after having fought a war against the British. But he came to London, he met Queen Victoria and various politicians and was willing to make a calculated deal with the British Empire. And that was not unusual. You had to make a calculation of what it was that served your interests and what might not. European ideas and practices were often welcomed, at least at first, though later nationalists might reject them and still do.
- 4.36 But there are two pictures here, one of a well-known Indian thinker of the late 18th and early 19th century called Raja Ram Mohan Roy, who was very eager to amalgamate European and Indian ideas and to produce a reformed version of Hinduism, which was not unlike the natural religion that Jean-Jacques Rousseau advocated in Europe. But another Indian thinker, Mahatma Mohandas Gandhi, rejected European ideas and culture, despite having been trained as a barrister in London, but went back to promoting a nativist Indian way of life based on simplicity and on, for example, famously on spinning one's own cloth. So there's a huge difference between these two responses, one early in the period of contact with Britain, one late in the period of

contact with Britain, one of acceptance, one of rejection. And this depends very much on the historical circumstances changing.

4.37 Slavery, I need to say a few things about, because in recent years it has become a highly contentious subject, and I've already mentioned it in earlier lectures. Nobody denies the importance of slavery or its horrors. The British Prime Minister William Pitt the Younger, whom I mentioned earlier, called in a speech in the House of Commons in the 1790s for what he called "an atonement for our long and cruel injustice." So when people sometimes say, "Why doesn't the British government apologize for slavery?", one might say William Pitt apologized in the 1790s, surely the first such apology by a head of government.

4.38 So why has it become so controversial now, again? Several arguments, it seems to me, are made, some of them rather simplistic and perhaps misleading. One is that slavery by Europeans was uniquely bad because it was racist. Other forms of slavery, however bad, were not racist. That is to say, European slavery treated Africans as inferior beings and created ideas about race which would justify this. Therefore, European slavery was the origin of racism, the invention of racism in today's world. That's one argument.

4.39 Another argument which I've touched on earlier is that slavery was the source of European wealth and even the basis of the Industrial Revolution. A third argument is that emancipation was essentially brought about by the slaves themselves, fighting back. And the Haitian, the Saint-Domingue revolution is usually cited there, not by European abolitionists, so European abolitionists can't take any credit for it. And fourthly, in any case, European abolitionism was not ethically motivated, but it only happened because slavery had become unprofitable. And some add, anti-slavery action by the British Empire was really only a cloak for further colonial expansion.

4.40 There's no time in a short lecture to discuss all these accusations fully, but all can, I would say, be countered. Now, was slavery by Europeans uniquely bad? Well, I would say all slavery is bad. Slavery was universal. Even former slaves owned slaves. Most slavery created or built on ideas of inferiority. After all, burying slaves alive with their master or making them fight wild animals as the Romans did, surely is at least *prima facie* evidence that you regarded them as inferior. So I'm very skeptical about the idea that European slavery was somehow different because racist. And finally, I can't see any obvious link between racism in the world today and the Atlantic slave trade, but that's something that one could debate.

4.41 Second point, was slavery the source of European wealth? Well, as I've said before, although profitable, slavery was not economically dominant. And even historians who emphasize its importance explicitly deny that it explains the Industrial Revolution. Also, it's odd that this argument is applied to Britain alone, though France had a larger slave-based economy. So why didn't France have an Industrial Revolution? Moreover, if slavery was of such fundamental importance to the British economy, it's hard to explain why Britain led the way in abolition. Unless, as I say, you were to say, well, it wasn't

profitable anymore. But then all the evidence is that it was becoming increasingly profitable, which is why it took a civil war in America to abolish it. British abolitionism, one leading historian has said, was comparable to suicide for a large element of Britain's trade.

- 4.42 Now, did the slaves bring about their own emancipation? Certainly, slave rebellions added to the demands for abolition, but they were not enough to bring it about. Again, one could cite the example of the United States. It took a major war to bring about abolition, not slave revolts, though there were such things. Finally, there is huge evidence that abolition was, to a large extent, ethically, more precisely, religiously motivated. British Empire anti-slavery activity in Africa brought little or no economic benefit, and it also risked serious damage to relations with other countries, particularly the United States and France. Lord Aberdeen stated in 1843 that "Great Britain desires and is constantly exerting itself to procure the general abolition of slavery throughout the world." This had wide popular support in Britain, but it made other countries particularly annoyed.
- 4.43 Finally, allegations that Britain was and indeed still is racist because of slavery two centuries ago has to ignore the huge and sustained popular support for abolition among women and men in Britain. And it also ignores much present-day evidence that Britain is one of the world's least racist societies. Nevertheless, getting back to the subject of empire, it may seem, it does seem, that empires are surely obviously racist institutions. I'm showing a photograph here of a white man in India having a bath and an Indian servant pouring water over him, which is, I thought, was a good symbol of the obvious subordination of one race or of many races to another race.
- 4.44 And this power was, to some degree, based on coercion, and if not by coercion, on the assertion of cultural superiority. I think that's undeniable. But on the other hand, you could say imperial rule was often, even usually, less violent and oppressive than what went before, and in many case, unfortunately, less violent and oppressive than what has come after. So pros and cons there, disadvantages and advantages.
- 4.45 Much of today's decolonization, I think, is based closely on the idea of cultural humiliation. This is the core of Edward Said's idea of orientalism. Frantz Fanon, one of the gurus of anti-colonialism, argued that colonialism created a psychological condition of inadequacy and inferiority among colonized people. Undeniably, it did among some, and those who would be most likely to feel this inadequacy and inferiority were traditional rulers who were displaced or at least subordinated, and some of the educated indigenous middle class, many of them educated and employed by the empires themselves. I have no doubt that many of them did feel bitter humiliation and resentment.
- 4.46 But was that the general experience? Should we feel very sorry for Zulu warriors who were humiliated because, they complained, under British rule, they had, I quote, "practically lost control over their girls and women"? Previously, young girls had been

obliged to marry much older warriors on pain of death. Certainly a humiliation for the older warriors. But was it a humiliation for the young women? Many lost from colonial rule, but many gained.

- 4.47 What about all the freed slaves? It's usually said about 160,000 African slaves were taken from slave ships by the Royal Navy in the 19th century. One of them became the first Anglican bishop of West Africa. Many women, many younger people in societies that were highly hierarchical, especially societies based on authoritarian traditional rule and on polygamy. Many people of lower status. It was not uncommon in India for people from lower castes to convert to Christianity as a sort of liberation. All those spared violence in areas which were subject to a high level of warfare, tribal warfare, those spared forced marriage, those who obtained education and economic opportunity. So however one looks at empires, it must, it seems to me, be admitted that many people lost and many people gained.
- 4.48 Not all empires or imperialists were the same. And I can give you the example of two unqualified imperialists, David Livingstone and King Leopold II of the Belgians. Leopold was a ruthless exploiter of a private colony in the Congo called the Congo Free State, including forced labor and violent coercion of people to work, for example, as rubber collectors. Whereas Livingstone was a missionary and an enemy of Arab slavery, which he said had made central Africa the open sore of the world. And he believed that colonial rule and some white settlement, "20 or 30 good Christian Scotch families," as he put it, could end slavery and bring improvement and stability.
- 4.49 Now, this vision, like the great imperial visions of statesmen, proved an illusion. And soon after they reached their largest extent, early in the 20th century, European empires, as I say, began to decline. So the period of empires was a passing phase, now long over. But nevertheless, there are present-day controversies. And as a sort of epilogue, I'd like to look at two or three of these, which I think give us reason to think and, I suppose, to debate. One source of controversy in Britain and elsewhere has been the fate of the so-called Benin Bronzes, which were taken, or if you like, looted, pillaged, confiscated, removed, by an expedition, a British expedition, in 1897 against the Kingdom of Benin.
- 4.50 Now, was this a case of gratuitous colonial violence, or was it justifiable retaliation against a violent slave-owning state which had just massacred a peaceful diplomatic mission? Should we be glad that slavery was ended by this intervention and that the human sacrifice of slaves, which was commonly practiced, was stopped? And if we think that was a benefit, should the objects that were confiscated, which include many, I think about 5,000 bronze statuettes, which it's been said were used for cult purposes, including human sacrifice, should be given back to the present king of Benin? Or should they be kept in European museums as part of a global heritage?
- 4.51 Interestingly, a group of African Americans, descended from slaves sold by the predecessor of the present oba of Benin objects to these treasures being given back to

him. They say they should be kept in European museums because the descendants of the slaves are more likely to be able to see them, and also that they will be a memorial to the slaves for whose bodies these objects were exchanged. So I think it's a moral dilemma, not one which has an easy answer.

- 4.52** A second point is the much-debated concept of Orientalism. I've got another painting by Delacroix, I suppose I must quite like Delacroix, a famous or notorious painting called *Women of Algiers*, which shows women in a harem. Many Europeans were fascinated by the idea of the harem and about Arab women as a symbol of voluptuousness and eroticism. So this could be seen as an insultingly racist painting. And the European fascination with other cultures in the 18th and 19th century can be and has been interpreted as a means of subordinating them and controlling them.
- 4.53** So that so-called Orientalism is a way of creating a stereotypical image of another culture and of using that as a way of exerting power over that culture. European science—did it not name and classify non-European species? Isn't that another form of power? What about theories of evolution and natural selection? They were used to create a hierarchy of races and cultures. Certainly, some people believe that. European ideas and values undermined or replace those of others and claim to be superior. So should we now be cooperating and welcoming the trend towards what is called decolonization, the decentering of Europe, the provincialization of Europe, as a way of reversing this colonial trend of subordination?
- 4.54** Again, this is something that one can debate and should debate. What should we think of it? Well, I would say that the theory of Orientalism, Edward Said's theory, has been much criticized as a distortion. In other words, many people, at least this is the reply, many people who took an interest in other cultures did so very genuinely. Many of what we now regard as cultural heritage from other cultures was in fact preserved by Europeans who are interested in those cultures at a time when indigenous people often disregarded them and allowed them to fall into ruin.
- 4.55** Present-day decolonization includes demands to decolonize classics, mathematics, even computer science. This seems to have very little connection with the complex realities of empire. It seems to be based on highly theoretical ideas about colonialism, which, as I've suggested earlier, it shows very little awareness of the complexities of empires, let alone their possible benefits. And yet it seems to me inconsistent in that very few people, I think, want to decolonize things about individual freedom, universal rights.
- 4.56** And on the contrary, I think some of the people who advocate decolonization in certain contexts are quite keen on pressing European ideas on other cultures in other contexts. An obvious example of these would be ideas about gender rights, gay rights, transgender rights, which many progressives wish to force, as it were, onto African and Arab cultures which dislike them. And yet this is not seen by them as a form of coloniality. So I think there is at least an inconsistency here.

- 4.57 So how do we conclude? Well, I think we could honestly conclude pretty obviously that the age of empire was a mass of contradictions and unintended consequences. It based itself often on illusions about its permanence, misunderstandings of history, sometimes misunderstandings of other cultures, but not always. But in any case, far too complicated for it to be considered as wholly good or wholly evil. It did do much to create the modern world, as Niall Ferguson argued of the British Empire, and so, as I suggested earlier, our judgment of empires must depend to some extent on how we judge the modern world. And there I will stop. And if you have any questions, I shall try to answer them.
- 4.58 My question is, in the British Empire, do you know approximately the proportion of colonies that wanted to opt in in a voluntary way of some type?
- 4.59 No. I'd have to go through the whole—I mean, it would be quite a complex answer. I mean, there are some cases in which I think it's pretty unambiguous. In the case of Fiji, OK, you could say that's a small example, but nevertheless, the Fijians are several times to be allowed to join the empire because they were subject to attack by slave traders. And the British at first said, oh, we don't—it's too much of a nuisance, basically. We can't take everybody. And eventually, Fiji did become part of the empire.
- 4.60 There are other cases which are, let's say, somewhat ambivalent. The famous Treaty of Waitangi, which was signed by Maori leaders in, I think, 1840, was a voluntary treaty between the British Crown in the person of a naval officer and the Maori people, for New Zealand to become part of the British Empire because the alternative seemed to be that New Zealand would be taken over by some other European country, possibly France, or indeed would become subject to the depredations of European gun runners, uncontrolled settlers, woodcutters, and whiskey salesmen and so on.
- 4.61 But then afterwards, some of them at least regretted it. And there were wars, Maori and British wars, mainly over land settlement. You could say, well, does that mean that the Maori changed their minds? But nevertheless, no doubt, some of them did, and to some extent they did at least. But eventually there was some settlement. But you could say, well, New Zealand is a case in which there was a request to join.
- 4.62 Morocco. Now, I have to remember the details of this. Morocco was nearly bankrupt in the late 19th century. It had previously been nominally part of the Ottoman Empire, but in effect independent. But there was a request to join the British Empire. I don't think it was an official request, but there were people who said, maybe we could join you. And the British government said, no, you'll be much too expensive. We can't possibly do that.
- 4.63 And indeed, there was even a delegation from Mexico in the middle of the century, in which at least a Mexican delegation asked if they could join the British Empire. And Lord Palmerston, who was then Foreign Secretary, said something like, we have all sorts of requests like this, but what they always come down to is sending soldiers and

sending money, and we're not going to do that. There was at least one South American country that asked to join, and I can't remember which one it is.

4.64 But otherwise, there were many ambivalent cases, of which the most obvious, I suppose, are the Indian princely states. India was ruled by the British, but roughly half of India was semi-independent. They were princely states who had accepted a subordinate position, but which were internally self-governing and were connected by various treaties with the British. So you could say, well, had they consented to that? Well, in a sense, they consented. They might have felt they had no choice in the matter or that not consenting would be worse. But nevertheless, there was a degree of an agreement between sovereign parties.

4.65 So I think the whole thing is rather complex. As I think Darwin, in my quotation of Darwin, there are also, there are places that ask for protection. The Arab Gulf States were all protectorates. In other words, they signed an agreement by which Britain, in this case, and the French had similar relationships, would protect them from other countries; would therefore run their foreign policy but would not be responsible for their internal government. Morocco was a French protectorate eventually. It retained its king and its internal self-government.

4.66 Earlier, you said men on the spot were a driving factor in the expansion of empire. Would you say they were more driven by nationalistic sense or other motives?

4.67 All sorts of motives. Often personal ambition, sometimes money, often sometimes nationalism, patriotism, sometimes a sense that they were on the side of history. We represent the future. These territories are backward, uncivilized, violent. Sometimes religious or ethical motives. It's our duty. Sometimes requests. For example, British expansion into, well, I mentioned Benin, was sometimes requested by other African peoples who were subject to attack from Benin. So people on the spot might say, yes, OK, we'll protect you, or we'll end up sending a military force or something.

4.68 The home government, I mentioned only 113 clerks in the colonial office, which meant that each one of them would have been nominally responsible for 10 or a dozen territories, which meant that communications were very slow. So it might take days or weeks or months for news of what was happening to reach London, and the same for Paris. So in that case, the people who were there would be expected to make the decision and would make the decision.

4.69 In some cases, the French Army was pretty notorious for this. It was partly military ambition. Your career would be improved if you could conquer some territory. Sometimes they were being told not to do this by the government in Paris, and sometimes they did it nevertheless. Then the government in Paris couldn't disavow what they'd done. I think there's one famous case in which some general on the spot is told, you must not occupy the oasis of something. And so what he did was to change the name of the oasis and then occupy it, and then come back and say, I haven't

occupied the oasis of so-and-so. I've occupied the oasis of something else. But it was in fact the same place.

- 4.70 But these people were sometimes completely out of control, and some of them were an absolute menace. There's no doubt about that. As I said, there's a huge difference between someone like David Livingstone, who is there peacefully. His motives are mainly religious and he believes he's doing good, and someone like Leopold of the Belgians, who is in it to make a lot of money very quickly and doesn't really care too much how it's done and doesn't ask too many questions. It's a huge and varied—I mean, I don't suppose Leopold knew that people were having their hands, well, I don't know, were having their hands chopped off for not collecting enough rubber, but I'm pretty sure he didn't want to know. What he wanted was to see the bottom line, and he was leaving it to other people to do these things. I think that's how it worked. It's a hugely complicated story.
- 4.71 It seems to me that the British culture drew a lot more from its colonies than the other empires, like the French or the German. Why do you think that is? The French don't like tea.
- 4.72 But they like coffee.
- 4.73 Yes.
- 4.74 I mean, there's a lot of debate. There's been a huge amount of debate over this, in which there's a whole school of thought that says European culture, and particularly British culture, was hugely affected by the empire. There are lots of popular books about this, too. You could say, well, the British drink tea, loads of things. We eat curry, the British national dish is now chicken tikka masala, that kind of thing. In all sorts of ways, you could say, well, culture was a—Kipling was a hugely popular author. There were lots of boys' comics that wrote about imperial adventures. The whole of popular culture was steeped in this idea of the empire.
- 4.75 There are other people, in particular one historian, who says, well, actually, this is not true. Most people were not in the least interested in the empire. It was very difficult to get MPs to turn up for debates on imperial questions. Most people who read boys' comics about adventures, they were about cowboys and Indians in America. They weren't about the Bengal Lancers. In fact, empire had a very small effect on people's consciousness.
- 4.76 I mean, I'm not sure that these questions can ever be very easily resolved. How would you prove it one way or the other? Yes, people did drink tea. Did this mean they were constantly thinking, "Thank god for the empire, otherwise I'd have no tea"? Did they think, every time they drank a cup of tea, this comes from Ceylon or from Assam? Probably not. And don't forget, the most emigrants from Europe went to the United States. That seemed to be the land of opportunity, not Australia, not South Africa.

Some people went there, but far fewer people. And I think there was a huge interest in America.

4.77 We all know that we're subject to American culture, and we probably have been to some extent since the late 19th century. But Queen Victoria went to see Buffalo Bill's Wild West show, if I remember rightly. That was the big crowd-pleaser. Chief Sitting Bull came to London and performed in Buffalo Bill's touring circus. There were things like that, but I don't think the empire was necessarily the dominant thing, even though governments in all countries tried to make people more empire-conscious.

4.78 But the French politician Jules Ferry, whom I mentioned earlier, saying the French don't want to be just a big Belgium, he also said the only thing that the French population is interested in about the empire is the belly dance. He wanted people to be more interested in the empire, and they weren't. It was hard to get people to migrate to colonies. It was hard to get businessmen to invest in colonies. You have these colonial visionaries saying the future of the world is all empires. But a lot of people just didn't believe it or thought, well, not my problem. I think it's a matter of still open debate.

Lecture 5: World War I Era

At a glance — The World War I era.

- 5.1 I finished my last lecture by talking about Europe having reached a stage in what I call the European century, in which most people were confident about the power of the European states, the future of their empires, the progress that they had made politically and economically. And so Europe at the end of the 19th century, although there were reasons to worry—there are always reasons to worry. People worried about the crudity of bourgeois culture, the decadence of some of its intellectuals, the whether or not some of the working classes were in decline, et cetera. The French worried about their slowly growing population.
- 5.2 There were lots of reasons to worry. There are always reasons to worry, but probably fewer people worried about the state of their societies, I would guess, than at most times in history. That's why the events of 1914 were such a shock to most people at the time, and why many historians call this the seminal disaster, because it's from this that the other disasters of the 20th century stem. From what seemed at first an unpleasant, if you like, even tragic, but not hugely important event, which was the assassination in Sarajevo of the Austrian Archduke Franz Ferdinand and his wife.
- 5.3 There's even a slightly ironical twist to this in that they were in an open-top car making a visit to what was the Austrian province then of Bosnia, and their driver took a wrong turning. And then tried to reverse and stalled the engine. And that just happened to be at the place where a young Bosnian Serb student was standing with his pistol and he was able to jump up onto the running board of the car, shoot the Archduke and his wife, and they both died.
- 5.4 Now, this, in retrospect, is the beginning of the seminal disaster, but it didn't necessarily seem so at the time. For many people, it was an incident that had taken place a long way away. The British government didn't discuss it for weeks. It was much more interested in what was going on in Ireland. Ireland was having one of its usual periods of difficulty. The French press was dominated by another political scandal in which the wife of a minister had murdered a journalist, not something that happens every day. One politician said he hoped it wouldn't become a habit. People were not concentrating on these events. They were concentrating on other events, other problems. They were enjoying the summer.
- 5.5 And then all of a sudden, this crisis comes, for most people, out of nowhere. These people were not only the naïve and the ignorant, they were also leading intellectuals, such as the historian and Member of Parliament, G. P. Gooch, who wrote a well-respected history of our time in 1911, in which he wrote, "The most striking outward feature of the history of the last generation is the shrinkage of the world." We've heard this before. "As the world contracts, the human race grows more conscious of its unity.

We can now look forward with something like confidence to the time when war between civilized nations will be considered as antiquated as the duel."

- 5.6 Three years later, the war starts. Another, indeed, a more famous book by a man called Norman Angell, which became a European bestseller, was called *The Great Illusion*, came out at about the same time. And Angell argued that because economic links were so close between the European states—for example, England and Germany, Britain and Germany were each other's best customers— a war between them would be, first of all, mad, and that no sane person would contemplate it, but that if a war did happen, it would cause such economic havoc that it could only last for a short time, and then it would have to stop because the world economy would collapse.
- 5.7 Well, the world economy nearly did collapse, but Angell, of course, was quite wrong about war being unthinkable and war being short. It was that that was the great illusion, not the war itself. So how did it happen? How did this seminal catastrophe, which was the cause of so many other catastrophes, take place? Now, I said most people were confident, and I think that's undoubtedly true. But nevertheless, there were tensions beneath the surface which did worry some people. And I would say that this is briefly a list of these tensions.
- 5.8 Every major continental state had adopted mass conscription and propagated military values. Public culture and education encouraged more or less aggressive nationalism. Nationalist political movements existed in most countries. The idea of war was present in popular literature, art, and theory. And the growing power of Germany and Russia and the relative weakness of France and Austria, the other two continental great powers, created instability. Both fear of the future, in some very influential people, and a window of opportunity in, fatefully, in 1914.
- 5.9 In 1914, indeed, the period from about 1913 to 1916 was period, and this is the fatal situation, in which both sides thought they could win. A few years earlier, the French or the Russians would have been sure they could not win a war. A few years later, the Germans might have decided that they could not win a war. But in this period, both sides thought they could win. And more dangerously still, the Germans, when I say the Germans, I really mean German politicians, German statesmen, and especially German generals, thought that they only had a brief period in which they could possibly win.
- 5.10 I'm showing you a painting, which in a way I rather like, and I think is quite eloquent. It's a French painting by a French military artist. Military art was very popular, and it's called *The Dream*. It shows young French soldiers on maneuvers, doing their training in the countryside. It shows a long, long line of soldiers asleep in—I don't suppose they had sleeping bags, but wrapped in their blankets with their rifles all neatly piled up, their flags folded. They're all asleep, but they're dreaming. What are they dreaming of? They're dreaming of victory. They're dreaming of the Napoleonic armies who were seen in the clouds in their dreams.

- 5.11** For many people, they didn't expect war to happen soon, but they knew what kind of war it would be if it did happen. They knew, if they were French, this would be their opportunity of reversing the defeat of 1870. For the Germans, it would be a repeat of that victory. For the Russians, it would be a way of finally imposing the power of Russia as the new giant. For Austria, it would be a war that would save their empire from collapse and so on.
- 5.12** So although war was, as it were, unthinkable, or at least that no was thinking it was going to happen when it did, few people would not ever think that war was possible. We may have got into the position in our own cultures in recent years of just not thinking about war at all. It may be that that has changed now. But until a few years ago, nobody thought that a war was conceivable. In 1900, 1914, people certainly thought it was conceivable, even if they didn't expect it to happen straight away.
- 5.13** There was one unknown danger, which is the famous or notorious Schlieffen Plan, of which there is a map on your screen. And the dangers, the unknown danger, was this, basically this. There were in continental Europe two major alliances, one between Germany and Austria, one between France and Russia. The Germans were quite sure that, if a future war happened, they would end up having to fight both Russia and France simultaneously. And the only way they thought they could do that was by defeating the French first. Why defeating the French first? Because France was a more developed country than Russia, as well as a smaller one. And so the French would be able to gather their troops together and begin fighting quite quickly.
- 5.14** The Russians, the Germans assumed, would take several weeks longer. And hence the Germans would have several weeks to defeat France. And then with France defeated, they could turn their forces east against Russia. In the meanwhile, they would leave only a small force in the east, and nearly all their armies would be concentrated in the west. That was the plan, a very logical plan. And an important thing to note is that the German army was pretty independent of civilian control.
- 5.15** Now, the most dangerous part of this, well, there are two dangerous parts in this, or perhaps you can say the whole thing was very dangerous—one was this is the only plan they'd got. They decided, well, this is our only option in case of war. This has got to be what we do. Secondly, the only way they thought they could defeat France quickly was by taking the French by surprise and hence by sending their troops through neutral Luxembourg, neutral Belgium, and in the original plan, neutral Holland. So they would invade three neutral countries. And one of those, Belgium, had its neutrality guaranteed internationally, including by Britain. So there was clearly a danger that by marching into Belgium, you might bring Britain into the war.
- 5.16** The third thing, and conceivably even the most dangerous, was because this was seen as a race against time, there was no cooling-off period in the German plan. In most countries, indeed in all other countries, you could start to mobilize your army. That's to say, you call up the reserves, you have all the men turning up at their barracks, getting

their uniforms, getting their rifles, going into barracks, moving in their train, trainloads of men moving towards the frontier, and then you could stop and wait. In the German case, you couldn't do that because if you did that, you would have lost your advantage of surprise.

- 5.17** So what the Germans were planning was that they would begin invasion almost immediately on the ninth day of mobilization. So whereas all other governments might think, OK, there's a crisis, we'll start to mobilize our troops just in case, in the German case, there was no just in case. If you were doing this, it was a decision to go to war. And that's what happened in 1914.
- 5.18** There's been a historiographical game ever since in trying to decide who was really responsible for this, who was really to blame. And it had, and still has, political implications, too. So even in the 1920s, all governments were trying to show that they had done the right thing and the others had done the wrong thing. And this has not entirely disappeared. You might say, well, this is one of those questions that can never be entirely resolved, which is why historians like talking about this kind of thing. If you wanted me to, I could talk about it for quite a long time, but I'm not going to. I'm just going to talk about the question of responsibility.
- 5.19** Who was responsible for this? And a number of answers have been given over the years. They tend to be the same answers that get recycled by every generation. One answer would be, everyone was responsible because every great European state was quite militaristic and quite imperialistic, or indeed, very much so. And all of them were ready to fight if they saw it as being in their interests. They were all ready to fight. They were all up for it. So therefore, they were all ready. They were all, in a sense, all equally to blame.
- 5.20** This is pretty close to being the position taken in a very widely read and, in many ways, excellent book by Professor Christopher Clark of my own University, Cambridge, called *Sleepwalkers*. The title suggests the approach. Or you could say that no one was to blame. It was an accident. The British Prime Minister Lloyd George famously wrote after the war that the nations of Europe had slithered into war. So this idea is that somehow it was all a terrible accident that nobody really wanted, but they lost control of events.
- 5.21** A third answer, which I suppose most famously would have been Lenin's, was Lenin's view, that this was all down to the system, capitalism, imperialism. That was why the war happened. So you don't need to look at the actual events. You can say, well, yes, but, whatever the events, it was the system that was to blame. Or, of course, and this has been argued by different historians and different governments, indeed, since the 1920s, as I said, you could say it was the French and the Russians. They escalated the conflict in the Balkans that took place after, that was taking place after the murder of Franz Ferdinand. It was really their fault. Otherwise, it would just have been a minor

local conflict between Austria and Serbia. But it was really the Russians and the French who made it into a European war.

- 5.22** Or it was the British even. You could say, well, if the British hadn't got involved, it would have been purely a continental war that would have been over fairly quickly. It was the British getting involved that turned it into a world war, and the British motive was essentially the defense of their empire and their position as, in some ways, the hegemonic global power. Or you could say it was the Germans. Or you could say, well, why not the Austrians? What had happened after the murder of Franz Ferdinand was the Austrians gave an ultimatum to Serbia, an independent state, but which they blamed for the murder. They said the Serbs, which quite rightly, the Serbs had trained and armed the terrorists. Therefore, it was the Serbs' fault. The Austrians were quite keen on a war with Serbia to put an end to the threat of Serb nationalism once and for all, they hoped.
- 5.23** So you could blame it on the Austrians. So you could blame it on any combination of the states or all of them or none of them. As I said, this is a bit of a historiographical game. But I'll just say what my view is, and that is that the ones who actually brought war about in 1914, as opposed to general considerations of the system, et cetera, were the German and Austrian generals, because they had decided that war was going to happen, and they had decided that this was a good time for it to happen, and they had drawn up the plan that meant that, once a crisis began to escalate, it would inevitably result in a general war among the great power. And that was the Schlieffen Plan.
- 5.24** Norman Angell, as I said in his book *The Great Illusion*, had said that war would be hugely damaging, and here he was right, and therefore that it couldn't last long, and here he was wrong. Developed states proved that they could mobilize huge resources. We've seen this even in the 18th century. States were able to fight a series of major wars. Now they could mobilize far greater resources. And this became the first industrial war. I want to give you a few statistics which I hope make the point.
- 5.25** Wars are fought with money. This war, too, was fought with industrial capacity, and it depended on how much money and how much production you could mobilize, really, which decided who was going to win. Let me give you an example of Britain. By 1918, 947,000 women were working in the munitions industry. Nearly a million women working in the munitions industry. None of them would have been in it before. By 1916, the British Army was using every week the equivalent of 50 years of pre-war production of explosives. The British Army fired, before the second, no, I think the third battle of Ypres in 1917, they fired off 321 trainloads of shells, and making those shells had required 55,000 workers to work for a whole year.
- 5.26** 75% of the casualties came from shell fire, and the British manufactured 15 shells for every German soldier. Now, the cost of a shell today is, we'll think about what this means in modern financial terms to give you an idea of what this cost. A shell today costs around about \$2,000. The British manufactured 15 shells for every German

soldier. So we're talking about \$30,000-worth of shells for every German soldier. And a couple of ingenious historians rather cold-bloodedly worked out that, in present-day values, it cost the Allies about \$80,000 to kill a single German soldier.

5.27 And as one of these historians pointed out, that was far more money than that soldier was economically worth, which is one way of looking at it. So this was the first industrial war, and it was won, essentially, by the side that could mobilize money and equipment. This was a new and shocking experience. New weapons, such as poison gas, were used; the casualties were huge; and this caused cultural as well as political and, of course, emotional trauma in all the countries involved. This is a famous painting by a very conventional pre-war artist, a portraitist, John Singer Sargent, which shows a line of men blinded by gas. Even now, it's a fairly shocking picture, even though we might say, oh, yeah, well, in fact, gas didn't kill all that many people, and they usually got over it. But nevertheless, the idea of people being killed by gas was a very shocking one.

5.28 Another picture, which, of the sort that we're all familiar with, this is by an artist called Paul Nash, *The Menin Road*. The Menin Road was part of the battlefields of northern France because mass artillery created unearthly landscapes, the sort of moonscapes, almost, of craters, dead trees, pools of water, and so on. People were shocked by this new vision of war. It strikes me that we see the same thing in Ukraine today in many ways, but we're no longer shocked by it. We take it as kind of, this is what things are like. But this was the first time this had happened, and it did cause a great, as you know, psychological trauma, which meant, in the postwar period, a great reaction against war, a great increase in pacifist feeling, which I'll come to in the next lecture.

5.29 This war is an embryonic total war, and I'm going to talk about total war more with regard to the Second World War in my next lecture. But nevertheless, this is getting towards what we might see as total war. There are a number of signs of this. Quite unexpectedly, I think, there was immediate large-scale violence against civilians by the various armed forces. The Germans who invaded Belgium shot a lot of Belgian civilians. In Poland, the Russians carried out attacks on Jewish populations. In Serbia, the Austrians carried out appalling atrocities against the civilian population, right from the very beginning.

5.30 The second thing was the use of, well, in effect, of starvation through blockade. The British blockaded Germany, and eventually this caused or helped to cause mass starvation. The German female death rate during the war rose by 51%. Third was unrestricted submarine warfare against civilian ships. Famously, the liner *Lusitania* was sunk off Ireland by a German submarine. And, oddly enough, before the war, when someone had said, well, is there not a danger that submarines might sink civilian ships? And a naval officer said any officer who ordered such a thing would be caught, marshaled, and shot. But in fact, the commander of the German submarine was decorated. By this time, pre-war standards had gone.

- 5.31 Another aspect of total war is mass mobilization and mass casualties. Another which is going to develop, of course, much more later is the aerial bombing of cities on both sides. OK, these were relatively small planes dropping relatively small bombs and causing relatively little damage. Finally, genocide, the genocide of the Armenians, which Hitler later commented on when he said, "Who remembers the Armenians?" In the sense that, this is—genocide is something you can get away with in wartime and nobody really notices.
- 5.32 It also became a global war. There were devastating conflicts in Africa between colonial armies. Colonial subjects came to fight in Europe. Volunteers, Australian, New Zealand, Indian, African. If I remember rightly, New Zealand had the heaviest casualty rate on the Allied side. And eventually, Britain and France invaded the Ottoman Empire. And as you know, America entered the war finally in 1917. And the reason it did so, or at least the thing that was the last straw, the Americans were getting closer to helping the Allies, was that the Germans were encouraging Mexico to attack America. So the Germans were trying to extend the global war even further, so thinking that if Mexico attacked America and they would be offered the return of Texas and New Mexico, then that would distract the Americans and prevent them from joining in the war in Europe.
- 5.33 OK. All these pressures of hunger, of mass casualties, and all the rest. Eventually, the disruption of ordinary life eventually caused all the competent countries to start breaking down, some faster than others. You might even say that Britain was the first because there was a rebellion in Dublin in Easter 1916. But that was a relatively minor matter. But in other countries, there comes to be a breaking down of central authority and of the state. First of all, in Russia, in February 1917. It depends which calendar you use, February or March 1917; the Tsar abdicated and a liberal Republic was introduced.
- 5.34 But the continuing strains of war, because the new democratic liberal government in Russia was trying to continue to fight on the Allied side, brought about a second revolution in October/November, carried out by Lenin and the Bolsheviks, which began a Communist revolution. Russia then signed a peace with Germany and, in the ensuing civil war in Russia, seven million people died. Russia was the first to break down, but the others were not far behind. The French army came pretty close to mutiny in 1917. Austria started to break up. The Italian army—I haven't mentioned Italy, but Italy was fighting on the Allied side in very difficult conditions in the Alps against Austria. The Italian army came close to collapse. The Austrian empire started to break up.
- 5.35 And the key was a revolution in Germany, which took place in 1918, when the German army itself, which was by far the most powerful and best trained in Europe or had been till it suffered such huge casualties, the army began, in fact, to stop fighting. And the generals told the Kaiser, Wilhelm II, the Emperor, that he'd got to abdicate. So he did. Germany at last got a truly democratic system. But immediately, fighting began between the government and the extreme left, who wanted a Bolshevik-style

revolution and extreme right-wing forces joined in against the extreme left. A very nasty, a disruptive period of violence began in Germany, too.

- 5.36** One anti-communist student in 1920, because the violence carried on, said, "No pardon is given. We shoot even the wounded." It was pretty vicious, as you can tell. The Ottoman empire, too, broke up. The war began between Greece and Turkey, a very bloody war, and there was also unrest in all the European empires. The war had caused eventually a general breakdown or near breakdown of all those involved, except America. But then America had only been slightly involved, really. The end of the war, the armistice of November 1918, was not the end of violence and chaos, which we tended to forget because of all the stress on the end of fighting on the Western front.
- 5.37** Now, historians are much more willing to stress the continuing violence that took place in the 1920s. It was impossible to put back together what had been broken, and the breakdown of the multinational empires, which was probably inevitable—the Ottoman Empire, the Austro-Hungarian Empire, the Russian Empire, the German Empire—it didn't end tensions. In fact, it often caused conflict within and between newly independent states.
- 5.38** Just to give you one rather gruesome example, which I think shows where Europe had got to, the Prime Minister of Bulgaria was murdered and his head sent to the capital in a tin. During the 1920s, nevertheless, it seemed that Europe, or at least Western Europe, had a chance of recovery and stability. But this was interrupted by economic crisis, to a large extent due to the war. The war had left huge debts, a legacy of inflation. Many markets had been lost, supply chains broken, new barriers to trade erected between countries which had previously been enemies.
- 5.39** There was a general period of instability, of which the most famous example was the hyperinflation in Germany in 1923. If my rather poor arithmetic works, the value of the mark fell from the—in the equivalent of gold, the paper mark, in other words, the mark that everyone used, went from being equivalent to one gold mark to one trillion gold marks in a couple of years or indeed in a few months. So you needed, and you may have seen photographs of this, vast piles of banknotes being used to do a small amount of shopping. People were going to the shops with a wheelbarrow full of million mark notes to buy their groceries.
- 5.40** This is supposed to have left a permanent mark on the German psyche, which is, some people say, why German governments today are so worried about anything that seems inflationary. But it's interesting to note that this hyperinflation in Germany was directly linked to the war. After the war, Germany was required to pay what we call reparations, in other words, financial damages, to the other countries who blamed Germany for the war, not unreasonably. The Germans stopped paying in 1923. So the French who were the toughest, invaded the Ruhr, the main German industrial area on the east bank of the Rhine. This caused the collapse of the German economy, broadly speaking, and the hyperinflation. So the hyperinflation itself was a consequence of

military action by France and the way that the German government responded to it, which was by printing lots of banknotes.

- 5.41** That was in 1923. Things seemed to be recovering. Indeed, there was a boom in the late '20s, which was ended by the Wall Street crash of 1929, which was really the familiar kind of boom and bust, which I suppose we got fairly used to. People think there's an easy way of making money, which is to speculate in the stock market. So stock prices rise, and then all of a sudden people realize that the companies are not able, through their profits, to pay out the dividends that they owe. Stock prices start to fall, and then they start to fall very fast as everyone panics. Lots of people go bankrupt. There are stories of New York stockbrokers jumping out of skyscraper windows.
- 5.42** The effect of the Wall Street crash was particularly devastating in Germany and America, and it was made worse by economic mismanagement. I say that with some hesitation because it used to be said, well, we know how to—governments have learned since then how to deal with things like inflation or with depression, but I don't think we really have. But they certainly didn't deal with it very well in 1929 and the early '30s, because the standard response of all governments was austerity. You have to cut spending. You have to try to maintain the values of your currencies. You have to stop trading with other countries or put large barriers in the way of other countries' exporting, which is often called "beggar your neighbor" policies.
- 5.43** So you want to maintain your market share and you don't care what happens to the others. There was a huge collapse in world trade. And from our point of view, the worst effects were mass bankruptcy and mass unemployment and crowds of people queuing up for nonexistent jobs. The result, of course, was to aggravate already quite severe political extremism. And we see a phenomenon which has often been called the militarization of politics, in which politics becomes organized around the use of violence against opponents, and in which many political parties in some countries, not in all, start organizing their own militias in uniform, both left-wing parties and right-wing parties, and even fairly moderate parties start organizing their own uniformed security squads. The notorious SS means security squad.
- 5.44** Violence in the streets between political parties becomes endemic in some countries. Almost happened in Britain. The British government brought in a law which banned the wearing of uniforms, but in other countries, it became the norm. This was the circumstance in which the Nazis came to power in Germany. The main reason for Nazi support— the Nazis never won a majority in Germany, but they did become the largest party in the Reichstag. And due to the system of proportional representation, which I must admit, I've never been a great admirer of, though some people think it's a panacea, it meant at that time that it was impossible to form a majority government without including the Nazis.
- 5.45** And once the Nazis were brought into power, with Conservatives saying among themselves, "This man, Hitler, is a bit of an idiot. He's just a rabble-rouser. We'll make

him Chancellor, but we'll just tell him what to do and we'll use him as a puppet." Well, Hitler was not usable as a puppet, and the Nazis came to power in Germany in 1933. Now, why did they come to power? Because German voters were desperate to have a government that would do something to cure mass unemployment. That was the reason. Nobody wanted another war, or at least not many people did. They were not terribly attracted by the Nazi policies of anti-Semitism. Some people were, but the essential thing was, it looked as though the Nazis would do something about unemployment.

- 5.46 The sort of people who voted for the Nazis were mainly— in fact, they drew support from all classes, but principally from lower middle-class shopkeepers, clerks, people who were very vulnerable to economic crisis and, too, non-organized workers, small craftsmen, independent businessmen, and so on, rather than trade union members who tended to go towards the communists. So there was indeed a polarization in which some people moved further and further to the left and others further and further to the right. And it was the right, the Nazis, who won out.
- 5.47 We often call this phenomenon totalitarianism, which I want to say a few words about. The emergence of what is commonly called totalitarianism, which the word itself was invented, it seems, in Italy in the 1920s, where the fascists were in power. In fact, they'd come to power in 1922, led by Benito Mussolini, who was a former socialist turned extreme nationalist. It was a word that the fascists liked to apply to themselves. I think Mussolini said something like, "Yes, we do want total power. We are totalitarian." But what does this word mean?
- 5.48 I would say, if you want to define it, it would be something like this. Extreme utopianism. You intend to make a new world by violence. In that sense, it's very different from, let's say, old-fashioned authoritarian conservatism, which basically wants to keep things as they are. Totalitarianism wants to change things. So extreme utopianism, one. Number two, total control of society, of politics, the economy, political parties, everything. Third, the rejection of legal and moral restraint. There are no more rules that apply to you. Fourth, famously, the adulation of a leader— Mussolini, Hitler, Stalin.
- 5.49 Next, I would say, mass mobilization of the population through a ruling party. Mass mobilization. You're not as old-fashioned authoritarians were, if I can call them that. You just want to keep people quiet. Totalitarians don't want to keep people quiet. They want to make people active. They want to get people into the streets. They want to enroll people in the party. They want to remake society. And finally is terror and violent repression of opposition. That's what I would say totalitarianism is.
- 5.50 What can history explain about such a phenomenon? Well, I think what history can explain is often quite limited. You might also want to explain it through some ideas about psychology or philosophy or sociology. But history can at least explain how things happened, who did them, as it were, who made the decisions, and also something

about the ideas that underlay them. I mentioned in an earlier lecture that some people blame 18th-century ideas for totalitarianism. We go back to Jean-Jacques Rousseau with the idea of the corruption of civilization and of the all-powerful general will.

- 5.51** It's been suggested that totalitarianism is a modern phenomenon which is based on some form of, if you like, distorted rationality and utopianism. All that may be true. But I think we ought not to forget, too, as I said, that what brought the Nazis to power in Germany, or indeed the Bolsheviks and Communists to power in Russia, was not a general call by society to them, but it was the seizure of power, in the case of Russia, by extreme violence. And in the case of Germany, too, the seizure of power by a large but still minority political movement of power through, again, through violence and terror.
- 5.52** But some people say we shouldn't use the term totalitarian for a number of reasons. One is, you could say, well, total control was never actually achieved. If you read 1984, which is a novel about totalitarianism, you realize that such a thing has never actually happened. It certainly never happened in the 1930s and '40s. There was no way in which any government could really control everything, and they really knew that. So should we take the theory for the practice? Maybe we should say, well, there was never such a thing as totalitarianism, really.
- 5.53** And also, people on the left often object to putting communism and fascism in the same category because they say, after all, there were huge ideological differences. Stalin, however violent, was trying to create a communist society, which some people think would be rather a good thing, whereas the Nazis were only ever aiming at violence, repression, and conquest. Yes, there were ideological differences, and I think we have to accept that, but it seems to me that that is not—that totalitarianism can contain ideological differences.
- 5.54** And a third objection is that the degrees of violence and control varied at different times. So can we talk about a totalitarian system if it was sometimes totalitarian and sometimes not? For example, you might say that the Soviet Union was totalitarian under Stalin, but it wasn't totalitarian in the 1950s and '60s, well, in the '60s and '70s. And fascism might have had a period of totalitarian violence during the Second World War, but it, on the whole, it wasn't really totalitarian at all. Can we talk about totalitarian as a system?
- 5.55** I would have thought it's really, if we want to keep the term, it's not so much a system as an ambition, a willingness, a desire to use the most extreme methods to create a new society. If we don't use it, it seems to be we're missing something terrible about the first half of the 20th century, which is the terrible similarities between systems which were supposedly opposites. I'm showing you a photograph of a Soviet labor camp built under Stalin with a Nazi concentration camp, and they're strikingly similar, as we all know.

- 5.56 There was similar adulation and sentimentalization of leaders. Here's a photograph of Stalin holding a little girl in his arms and a big bunch of flowers and a big smile on his face, and Hitler with another little girl and a smile on his face. We know that these people were vicious psychopaths, but they had to be presented as all-powerful, wonderful human beings.
- 5.57 Estimating the dead, and I'm talking now about the interwar period, not the Second World War, but the numbers killed are unprecedented, at least killing this number of one's own people. Even if some of it was, you might say, an unintended consequence, is surely unprecedented in European or world history, though it's happened since. But to run through some of these figures, in the Soviet Union, the period of war communism, so-called, in 1921 to '22, and of famine, is reckoned to have killed 5 million people. The collectivization of agriculture in the early 1930s is supposed to have killed over 8 million people. So awful was it, though you might say there's a terrible cynicism here. Over 2,000 people were punished for cannibalism. So you have a regime which is starving people to death and then punishing them for cannibalism.
- 5.58 And then Stalin's great terror of the late 1930s, in which Stalin imposed a purge of supposed or suspected traitors, is reckoned to have killed about a million people. If you total all those up, we're talking about the Soviet Union killing or causing the deaths of about 14 million people in the interwar period. The fascists had still not quite got into gear, as it were, but we're talking about fascist violence in Italy in the thousands. Italy's attack on Abyssinia in the 1930s, several hundred thousand. The Spanish Civil War, followed by a so-called white terror against the left, about 200,000 killed. Internal repression by the Nazis in Germany and the killing of disabled people, about half a million killed. Fascist violence in the Balkans and so on, several hundred thousand. In the one case, we're talking about tens of millions. In the other case, we're talking about a million, I suppose.
- 5.59 But then comes the war. I want to finish by looking at how people reacted to this. And the answer is that many turned a blind eye. Why is this? It's extraordinary in retrospect that many intellectuals didn't want to know the bad side of the political cause they were attracted to. Many of them were attracted by extreme politics if that seemed to be on the side of history and if it fitted intellectual theory. Most obvious, this was the case for Marxists, who insisted that the Soviet Union was a paradise, that nothing was going wrong. And if there were a few traitors, they deserved punishment. But basically, everything was wonderful.
- 5.60 But there were fascists and Nazi intellectuals, too. Large numbers of the SS had doctorates. There were writers, artists, and philosophers who were much attracted by Nazism and fascism. Martin Heidegger, one of Germany's most influential philosophers, was a member of the Nazi Party, and the leading Anglo-Irish author and playwright, George Bernard Shaw. And his frivolity is still, I think, annoying. But he claimed to be

attracted by both communism and fascism. And he said this in a BBC broadcast in 1929. "Who can blame Signor Mussolini for describing democracy as a putrefying corpse?"

- 5.61 Lenin and Stalin had begun a great communist experiment which would prevent the collapse and failure of world civilization. And he says, "And the Nazi movement is in many respects one which has my warmest sympathy." So I like the Nazis, I like the fascists, I like the communists too. Because? Why? Because democracy is dead. The liberal states are weak and corrupt. And that's what many intellectuals began to think.
- 5.62 At the height of Stalin's Great Terror in 1936, a publisher, very well known at the time, publisher called Victor Gollancz in London, who was the director of the Left Book Club, a very influential publishing house, in 1936, he named Stalin his Man of the Year in the middle of the Great Purges. They didn't know or they didn't want to know. But many people, almost certainly most people, including most politicians, may not have been impressed by the Nazis or the communists as much as intellectuals were. But it was often too frightening to admit, even to oneself, the truth of what was happening.
- 5.63 And a symbol, I think a very telling symbol, is this photograph of the international exhibition in Paris in 1937, in which you see all the pavilions of the different exhibiting states with the Eiffel Tower in the background, but dominating the whole scene are the Nazi German and the Communist Russian pavilions facing each other as two great rivals, or so it seems, two enemy ideologies which were going to dominate Europe's future. But then, in August 1939, the Nazis and the Communists signed a non-aggression pact to the astonishment of the world. Someone in the British Foreign Office joked that "the isms had become wasms." But this pact was what enabled Hitler to go to war in the following months.
- 5.64 I want to end with a quotation from very distinguished historian, Tony Judt, in his book, *Postwar*, who sums up the results of the seminal catastrophe. He says, "The cumulative effect of these blows was to destroy a civilization. The scale of the disaster that Europe had brought upon itself was perfectly clear to contemporaries, even as it was happening." And of course, there was much worse to come.
- 5.65 But, and here I end on a note of relative optimism, the liberal states and peoples were not dead yet. A Gallup poll in Britain early in 1939 showed that 87% now favored an alliance of Britain, France, and Russia to stand up to fascism, though, of course, soon after that, the Russians and the Germans cozied up to each other. At a similar time, a poll in France showed that 76% of the population were willing to contemplate war to stop further German aggression. It's as if public opinion was actually in advance of politicians and had realized that they were facing dangers which they could not any longer pretend did not exist. And there I'll stop for the moment.
- 5.66 You mentioned that in your lecture, too, about Napoleon's rise to power, you mentioned that he was acting on his own self-interest. Could you say the same about

Hitler and Stalin in the earlier part of the 20th century, or were they working towards a better country for themselves?

- 5.67 Well, I think that Napoleon, let's say, is a more normal character than either Hitler or Stalin. I think we're talking about people who are not like most people, who do not have the same motivation as we do, in which things like even normal ambition, normal patriotism, normal concern for one's family and one's fellow citizens, are pretty well absent. I think it seems to be very difficult to be able to say precisely what motivated people like Hitler, Stalin, or even Napoleon. There are psychological and spiritual depths that it's quite difficult to plumb. I think that they were probably acting under some internal compulsion.
- 5.68 I mean, were they psychopathic? Must have been moving towards the psychopathic spectrum, as it were, in which they have very a little sense of solidarity, community with other human beings. In that case, what they're doing is all about themselves. The ideologies that they're following, the causes that they espouse, are ways for themselves to live out the fantasies or nightmares that are in them already. But I'm not a psychologist, and a real psychologist might find that a rather crude explanation. But I think it's difficult to say why they did what they did.
- 5.69 OK, circumstance. Had Stalin been born in a different place, in a different time, and Hitler, too, well, what would they have been? Same with Napoleon. Nothing. But I mean, times of extreme disorder enable very strange characters to rise to the surface. The things that in normal life would be regarded as criminal tendencies become then great virtues. I was reading, well, perhaps we should leave. I'll leave this to, perhaps, to discussion after the next lecture, which we'll be talking partly about the Holocaust. But there too, many people have said, how could people do these things? I'll talk about that later. But I think in the case of the leading figures, they are something and always will remain something a mystery.
- 5.70 This question is about pre-war, both wars, similarities with the current-day situation. Looking at art and literature, it seems that there's more war films, Dunkirk, 1918, Napoleon, making that into the public consciousness. Then also the collective anxiety aspect. There's an automation anxiety with the rise of AI, and also climate anxiety, which also has totemic leaders such as Greta Thunberg. Do you think there's factors in the current culture that are pushing us towards war?
- 5.71 That's a very interesting question. I don't think that war—OK, the sorts of wars that there are some cultural expressions of, as you say, Napoleon or the Second World War, seem to be much less present, probably, than they were in pre-1914 culture. When there were a lot of novels about the future war, what would happen when war came. I don't think we have—there aren't many novels about the Third World War that I'm aware of or films about what it would be like if there were to be a world war. There were those things in the 1960s and '70s. It seems to me that they don't really exist now.

5.72 And as far as the green movement is concerned, which is, of course, a mass movement of a spontaneous kind, I suppose. I think the green movement is in some ways a rather worrying phenomenon in that I think it would have all sorts of unintended consequences if it were ever able to become a dominant political force, is likely to be anti-war rather than pro-war. The only thing that I suppose, if you take a pessimistic view, you could say, well, if the Greens are successful in pushing the certain Western societies and Western economies towards economic collapse, then it could, as an unintended consequence, encourage aggressive acts by countries, of which the obvious examples are China and Russia, which do not in any way obey the dictates of the green movement.

Lecture 6: World War II Era

At a glance — The World War II era.

- 6.1** By 1945, Europe had been reduced to a state of moral and material devastation, unseen at least since the 30 Years' War of the 17th century. Yet, little more than 30 years earlier, before 1914, it had seemed to be riding the crest of the wave of progress, peace, and prosperity. In the last lecture, we looked at the seminal disaster that started the process of descent. But how did Europe once again turn on itself, when the First World War had been called the war to end war, and it ended with optimistic determination to make sure that war never happened again, that a new era of peace would be brought in, that relations between states would be organized in a quite different way?
- 6.2** Well, we've looked at some of the causes in the last lecture, but nevertheless, we have to remember that most people, certainly all progressive people, felt that they had entered a new era, and the League of Nations was there to make sure that peace and harmony prevailed. Disarmament and pacifism were very widely supported. Many countries had tried to embrace democracy, the countries that had previously been part of authoritarian or semi-authoritarian empires. We had been given the vote.
- 6.3** There were many who clung to visions of a world socialist revolution or to a future United States of Europe. And also, attempts were made by the victorious Allies to appease Germany, often in the belief that Germany had been too harshly treated in the peace treaties of 1918. We've looked at some of the causes why this broke down in the last lecture—economic disruption, the militarization of politics, the rise of totalitarianism, and yet, nevertheless, the democracies were determined to try to prevent the worst from happening through what was widely called the appeasement of Germany and Italy, too.
- 6.4** So there were attempts, repeated attempts were made to negotiate with Germany and Italy, who were the main disruptors, to try to find out what sort of deal could be done with them, what it was they really wanted, how they could be satisfied, and how they could be persuaded, as it were, to join in the family of nations that was being built by the League of Nations.
- 6.5** And the last attempt at appeasement was in the famous or notorious Munich conference of 1938, when there was a conference between Britain, France, Germany, and Italy, with the Czechoslovak government as helpless spectators, to try to come to some agreement about the future of the German-speaking part of Czechoslovakia, the Sudetenland, which was claimed by Germany, and in which the British Prime Minister, Neville Chamberlain, was able to, as he thought of it, negotiate a deal which would keep the peace and also persuade Hitler to sign an agreement never to go to war again.

- 6.6 And when Chamberlain got back from Munich, he was one of the most popular men in the world, mobbed by cheering crowds, receiving 40, 000 mainly congratulatory letters and hundreds of presents, including a present from the French people of a stream for fishing. He was a keen fisherman. He was suggested for the Nobel Peace Prize. Portugal erected a statue to him on behalf of grateful mothers and so on. It seemed that peace had been saved and could be saved by negotiation, engagement, appeasement.
- 6.7 There were some dissenting voices, most famously Winston Churchill's, who said, "This is only the first sip, the first foretaste, of a bitter cup." But most people were, for a time, happy. And many people since then, politicians and historians, have thought whether Hitler could have been stopped. Was there some way in which the march of Nazi expansionism could have been halted, if the democracies had been less accommodating, had been more willing to risk war and try to deter the fascist dictatorships?
- 6.8 And I think, it seems to me that the answer is, in theory, yes, this could have been done, but in practice, probably no. And I must admit, when we're faced with today's dilemma in which we know that there is a possibility of, and indeed, it's now being predicted, of a major war in Europe and possibly a Chinese invasion of Taiwan, which many people again say is likely, if not inevitable, that we are having to grapple with the sort of problem that Chamberlain and his contemporaries grappled with in the 1930s and are not doing it much more successfully.
- 6.9 How do we know what the right thing is to do? Is it always to be engagement and negotiation, or should it be rearmament, deterrence, an expression of the willingness to fight? I don't think we really know any more than they knew. Could Hitler have been stopped? In theory, yes. The Germans remilitarized the Rhineland, which had been demilitarized after the First World War in 1936. And we now know that, had there been any resistance by the French, the Germans would have pulled out, and Hitler would probably have been humiliated and possibly overthrown. But the French Army had no plan for resisting the Germans, and hardly any political figure in the West thought that they should have done.
- 6.10 So we can now say, in theory, knowing what we know, they should have done this, but nobody at the time thought it was good. Even Churchill, I think, thought, if the Germans wanted to remilitarize the Rhineland, they had the right to do so. And as far as the Czech question was concerned, it seemed, or at least it could be presented, as being a case of self-determination by which the German speakers of the Sudetenland wanted to leave the Czech Republic and join Germany.
- 6.11 Would you really fight a war to force these people to remain part of Czechoslovakia, or if you'd accepted, as the Western powers did, that they could, if they wished, join Germany, could you then fight a war over the speed with which this should be done? It was almost impossible. Public opinion did not support it. The Americans certainly did not support it. The other parts of the British Empire didn't support it. The Canadian high

commissioner has said something like, "How could you consider fighting a war over a timetable?"

- 6.12** We know now, I think we know, or at least it's pretty clear, that had there been resistance in 1938, had the Czechs been supported in resisting Germany, as of course, we recently encouraged the Ukrainians to resist Russia, probably the German army would have overthrown Hitler because they knew they were not in a condition to fight. But hardly anyone at the time knew that. And so that's why I say, in theory, Hitler could have been stopped. In practice, it was probably impossible to do it. These things are never simple, and hindsight is a very tempting way of exercising one's superiority.
- 6.13** Hitler's aims, we now know, which they didn't know, you might say they should have known. Hitler's aims were global war, a global war of racial superiority, a war for "lebensraum," which essentially meant the seizure of territory which would enable Germany to win a global war against Britain and America. Hitler had been— his experience of the First World War had been of Germany's defeat by the British Empire and the Americans. He was fighting on the Western front, mainly against the British. And he had a very strong idea of the strength of the British and Americans, and also of Germany's defeat by blockade, of the starvation of the German people, in effect.
- 6.14** He thought in a future war, a future world war against Britain and America, Germany needed to have the agricultural resources which would enable it to resist a blockade. That would mean dispossessing Eastern Europeans of their land and their food supplies and using them for Germany. That was lebensraum. Also, Hitler and the Nazis believed that war was both inevitable and desirable. They also believed, or at least they had some fears that their, and this reminds us again of 1914, that their window of opportunity was quite short. So they thought war was necessary, and they thought it was necessary soon.
- 6.15** And Hitler, indeed, was rather disappointed afterwards that he'd agreed at the Munich conference not to go to war over Czechoslovakia, and he thought the next time he would have his war because war was going to come. You were asking earlier how one can explain how people like this think, how they behave, and I think it's very difficult to do so. We can, to some extent, analyze what we know about their thoughts and their view of the world. And that, I think, is as close as one can get to Hitler's.
- 6.16** But Westerners found it very difficult to understand. It was very difficult to understand that there might be someone who actually wanted to have a war, when their assumption was that war was the worst catastrophe that could befall Europe, indeed the world, and that everyone would want to avoid it. They couldn't understand that some people actually wanted it to happen. So for example, the British Foreign Office lost its copy of Mein Kampf, which you might say was rather careless, because that's where they could have read what Hitler had said about what his intentions were, though they would probably not have believed it. Many people said, well, OK, he said all this stuff, but it's just all talk. He can't really mean it.

- 6.17** When the British Foreign Secretary, Lord Halifax, went to Germany and met Nazi leaders, met Hitler, he said, "We're not talking the same language." He couldn't really understand. One of them said to him, I think it might have been Hitler, said to him, "You're having all this trouble in India with Gandhi and the Indian nationalists. All you have to do is shoot Gandhi and a few hundred of the Congress leaders, and your problem's over. Why can't you just do that?" Halifax said, well, that's not really how we do things. But couldn't really understand that all this was how the Nazis thought.
- 6.18** And he said to the German ambassador, "My dream is that one day Mr. Hitler and the King will enter Buckingham Palace side by side, amid cheering crowds." There was always this belief that if you could only just get through to Hitler and find out what he was really wanting, then you could come to some deal. As Chamberlain said something like, well, we're all human after all. There must be some way that we can understand each other, but they couldn't understand him.
- 6.19** The French Prime Minister, Daladier, seems to have got a bit closer, perhaps because the French had had closer dealings with the Germans for a long time. But he came to England and had a meeting with British ministers and diplomats, and he said, "You have to understand something. Hitler is not like the Kaiser. He's like Genghis Khan." And the head of the foreign office said, "Well, it's very eloquent, but it's all complete nonsense." And of course, he was right, but they couldn't see that.
- 6.20** And in response to the danger, the clear danger, a common response was to become more pacifistic, to insist more on disarmament rather than resistance, including some pacifist groups who advocated quasi-military training in non-violent resistance or psychological exercises, including knitting, sitting in silence, and folk dancing. That was supposed to neutralize the threat of the Nazi stormtroopers. In France, there was a campaign of what was called moral disarmament. You have to make people feel that disarmament is the right thing to do.
- 6.21** And the left remained until quite late on, certainly until the middle or late 1930s, pretty pacifist. One of the leaders of the Labour Party said, "If we don't arm, the fascists won't." This is always an illusion of liberals, that if they behave in the right way, other people will copy them. That, I think, is the context as to why it was difficult to stand up to the aggression of both Italy in Abyssinia and of Germany in Central Europe.
- 6.22** In short, they couldn't grasp the psychology of the people they were dealing with. The former Prime Minister, liberal Prime Minister, Lloyd George, called Hitler "the greatest German of the age." Veteran Labour party leader George Lansbury went to meet Hitler, and he was very pleased to find that Hitler didn't drink alcohol, was a nonsmoker and a vegetarian, and therefore, he thought, well, Hitler's fine. He wants peace. "Germany needs peace," wrote Lansbury. "Nobody understands this better than Herr Hitler." If Germany were given a fair share of the world's resources and markets, Hitler would cooperate in discussions on how to abolish war.

- 6.23 It was impossible to be more wrong. And only after Hitler had carried out repeated aggression and violence at home did public opinion and political opinion begin to change. And I pointed out in the last lecture that opinion polls in both France and Britain showed that public opinion was turning towards a belief that resistance, even by war, was going to be necessary.
- 6.24 War came in 1939, as we all know. What had changed? Well, Hitler had over and over again proved his duplicity, and it became pretty well impossible to trust him, or even try to trust him, as Chamberlain had done. Public opinion had shifted, as I said. But then Russia signed a non-aggression pact with Germany in 1939, which gave Hitler the green light. And then Britain and France decided that they had to resist. And the occasion of their resistance was Hitler's threat to Poland. And so Britain and France guaranteed Poland's security.
- 6.25 Though they still hoped for a last-minute settlement, Chamberlain was still hoping that if you could offer Germany colonies in Africa, it might be a way of getting Hitler to stop. But by that time, many people in the public and in the political world had decided that war was going to come. But what were they expecting? Most people were expecting a repeat of the First World War. That is to say, a long war and a static war.
- 6.26 The Germans were using more steel for barbed wire than they were for tanks in 1939, because they, too, were expecting another First World War of fixed, fortified trench lines that would go on for several years. The French and British realized that they might win a war like that because they would have their empires to mobilize. They tended to control the world's communications by sea. The Americans would probably come in at some time or another. So a repeat of the First World War scenario would mean that Germany would inevitably lose. And of course, you might say, well, that was actually true because that's what happened.
- 6.27 But the Germans realized that, too. And the German army, in a way that seems to me slightly reminiscent of the Schlieffen plan in 1914, had come up at the last minute with what they knew was a very risky plan for winning the war quickly. We will lose a long war, so we have to win a short war. And the chief of the German general staff said something like, "Even if there's only one chance in 10 that this will work, we have to take it." So what happened was that the German army completely deceived the French and British as to the main area of their attack.
- 6.28 The map shows it in a slightly simplified version. But the British and French were sure that the Germans were going to attack in Holland and northern Belgium. And the Germans started doing this. The British and French then moved their main forces up into Belgium. And then, as you probably know, the main German attack came to the south through Luxembourg and the Ardennes forest and cut off the main French and British armies in the north, cutting them off from their supply lines, their bases, their reinforcements, and forcing the British army, which was quite small, to retreat to Dunkirk and then to be evacuated to Britain.

- 6.29 And meanwhile, the French army found it impossible to stop the German advance. All their plans had been nullified, their communications and their logistics were disrupted, and eventually they decided to ask for an armistice. So this devastating success placed the whole of Western Europe under German dominance or was in the hands of Germany's allies. A few neutral countries like Sweden and Switzerland and Spain, and Russia, of course, at the moment, on friendly terms with the Nazis and supplying them with large quantities of oil and food supplies.
- 6.30 So, Germany dominated strategically. Could Hitler have won? Could the Nazis have become the dominant world power? Probably not, as long as Britain refused to make peace. And that, I think, is the world's debt to Winston Churchill, who became Prime Minister in May 1940, and who persuaded his government, some of whom wanted to start negotiations with Italy and Germany, to refuse negotiations and to insist that Britain would continue the war in all circumstances, which some of his colleagues thought was completely mad.
- 6.31 They thought, well, we've lost. We can't fight on our own. France has surrendered. We have to start negotiating. So they were willing to offer Gibraltar to Spain, Malta to Italy, to make all sorts of concessions in the hope that Britain would survive. Churchill said no. Even if we're defeated, it won't be worse than giving up now, so we're going to fight on. OK. And I think the world's debt to Churchill is precisely that. Britain still controlled the seas, and it had the support of the empire and increasingly of the United States' economy.
- 6.32 That put the Germans in a very difficult position. It put them in the position of having to fight the long war, which they had tried to avoid. I want to quote a German U-boat officer who was really rather perceptive. And he said, he wrote this. "The English can hold out under existing conditions for years. The U-boat arm"—the U-boats are German submarines—"the U-boat arm will not break them, nor airmen either. Time is on the side of the English, and we cannot afford to give them time." I think that was absolutely right.
- 6.33 And Hitler himself, looking back on what had happened a few weeks before he committed suicide, said he had, I quote, "underestimated one factor, the extent to which Churchill's Englishmen were influenced by the Jews, and so denied Germany its ultimate victory." So there was a stalemate, 1940, '41. The Germans could not invade Britain. Britain could not defeat Germany. So what do you do? What Hitler decided to do was that they had to attack Russia.
- 6.34 The reason being, the immediate reason, apparently being that Hitler thought that Britain was continuing resistance in the hope that Russia would enter the war on Britain's side. If Russia could be defeated, then the British would give up. And if the British gave up, the Americans would be powerless to intervene in European affairs. So Germany would have won. And Germany was perfectly confident in its ability to defeat Russia, partly because they thought that the Slavs were racially inferior, but they knew

that communism and Stalin had done huge damage to Russia, and particularly the Russian army.

- 6.35** During Stalin's great purges of the late 1930s, thousands of senior army officers had been executed. So the Russian army was in a pretty bad state. So the Germans were pretty sure that they could defeat Russia quite quickly. And that would be that. So in the summer of 1941, Germany invaded Russia. In December 1941, the Japanese attacked the British and French empires in Asia, and of course bombed Pearl Harbor. And Hitler declared war on America.
- 6.36** Many people say that was his fundamental error, but there was a certain logic in this. If, by declaring war on America, he could encourage and help the Japanese to fight a war against America, then America would not be able to intervene in European affairs, and also Russia would be afraid of the threat from Japan, which indeed it was, very, very afraid of the threat from Japan, and that would also weaken Russia. There was a logic in Hitler's willingness or decision to make this into a world war.
- 6.37** Germany's position seemed on the face of it very strong. It largely controlled the Euro-Asian continent, and it looked as though it was defeating Russia in 1941-42. But the Royal Navy's blockade of Germany and of occupied Russia, as in the First World War, cut off or reduced essential supplies to the Axis war effort, which included oil, fertilizer, not a very glamorous product, but it was this in part that was responsible for a catastrophic fall in agricultural productivity in both world wars and hence for food shortages. Animal feed, the same. Much animal feed was imported from outside Europe, as it still is.
- 6.38** Rubber, all from outside Europe. Copper, nickel, cotton, wool. So the Germans had to manufacture synthetically oil from coal and manufacture synthetic rubber. And this caused chronic food and fuel shortages and strangled industrial production. Consequently, the German conquest of Western Europe was giving them far less benefit than they expected. Let me give you a couple of statistics. By the end of 1941, Britain had shipped in over 5,000 American aircraft. Germany had occupied France and Holland, both of which had aircraft industries, but the total number of aircraft that they'd received from France and Holland was 78. So 5,000 the British get, 78 the Germans get.
- 6.39** The same disparity was really there across the board. And the most crucial item, I suppose, is oil. Germany had at most eight million tons of oil per year. And from this, it had to try to supply Italy and its conquered territories, which it was hoping to use as centers of production. Whereas Britain imported over 10 million tons of oil in 1942, despite the submarine campaign that the Germans were waging in the Atlantic. And in 1944, Britain was importing 20 million tons a year. So Britain alone had more than twice the amount of oil that the whole of German-occupied Europe had.

- 6.40 It's often said that, in talking about wars, amateurs talk about tactics and professionals talk about logistics. Wars are won by supply, and the supply of oil was crucial. In fact, one historian of the German war effort has said that the British didn't have any need to worry about German ships like the Tirpitz and the Scharnhorst and the Gneisenau, which caused the British Navy a great deal of worry because they hadn't got any oil for the ships to sail. I don't know if that's true, but it's significant that the Germans were very short of oil.
- 6.41 For this reason, almost certainly, Germany could not have won, as many of its military leaders increasingly realized. But on the other hand, they and the people who supported them didn't think they could actually lose. They were so strong in their possession of the European continent, or so it seemed. So it was a general belief that the Nazis could make peace with the Western allies, who didn't like Russia after all, and allow the Germans to get on with fighting the Russians. But of course, that didn't happen.
- 6.42 I want to look at some rather grim, very grim, facts about this war. It was the nearest ever that humanity has ever had to a total war. The German propaganda minister Goebbels, in a famous meeting, public meeting, in Berlin in 1943, asked the audience, "Do you want a total war?" You can see the film, the film you can, I expect it's on YouTube. "Do you want a total war?" he says, and the crowd shouts back, "Yes." So they knew what they were doing. And in this total war, vast numbers of people were being killed or were dying every day.
- 6.43 What do we mean by total war? It seems to me, if it's total in its aims, and the aims of this war are subjugation, destruction, even extermination. Total in its methods, there are no moral, legal, or humane restraints. Total in its mobilization of the state, its people, its economy. One military historian has said that if 40%-plus of the economy is devoted to war, then by definition, it's a total war, and that was happening. And finally, total control, control of public and private life, of all property, censorship, propaganda, rationing of food and clothing, punishment of dissent.
- 6.44 And I think people realized what sort of war this was going to be, not even like the First World War or like any previous war. A senior British diplomat, Sir Robert Vansittart, said in September 1940—which seems to me to show that people knew what they were facing—he said, "Either the German Reich or this country has got to go under, and not only under, but right under. Right under." The total aims included genocide on the German side. I've mentioned the lebensraum ambition, and also a thing called the hunger plan, which was drawn up by the German army. How do we survive in this war when Germany cannot feed its own people?
- 6.45 And the answer is, you have to take the food supplies from Eastern Europe, from Poland, the Ukraine, and Western Russia. And they were expecting that this would cause 35 million deaths from starvation. The Germans would not starve, their enemies would starve. And this was only a beginning. There's extermination, or

exterminatory intents, on both sides. Hitler, I mentioned this earlier, said in 1939, "Who now talks about the Ukrainians?" Sorry, "Who now talks about the Armenians?" People had forgotten the Armenian genocide in the First World War. Hitler thought they'd soon forget about genocide that he might commit.

- 6.46 The Poles were to be destroyed as a society and subjugated. The Slavs were to be cleared out and starved. The Jews were to be removed and/or killed. And as I say, the expected result of these plans ran into the tens of millions of deaths. But the Russians were doing their part, too. War provided a pretext and an opportunity and a cloak for actions that went far beyond military necessity. In Poland, both the Germans and the Russians were aiming at exterminating Polish society, not necessarily of exterminating the Poles, but reducing them to slavery.
- 6.47 And one of the things that the Russians did early on was to massacre the Polish officer corps, whom they had taken prisoner when they invaded eastern Poland. Because the Polish officer corps, many of them reserve officers, included not just professional soldiers, but doctors, lawyers, academics, politicians, the whole of the Polish elite. And they shot them, tens of thousands of them, and buried the bodies, many of them in the Katyn forest.
- 6.48 There are photographs of their exhumation because the Germans found them and thought this was useful propaganda to use against the Russians. And layers and layers of bodies were found. The weight of the corpses had crushed those underneath, but it was found that they had papers and letters that showed that the time of their death had been when this territory was occupied by the Russians.
- 6.49 On the other hand, the Germans themselves were setting out on an even broader campaign of extermination by the use of so-called Einsatzgruppen on the Eastern front, who were to exterminate Bolshevik leaders and Jews. The Germans liked to think that many Bolsheviks were Jews and vice versa. But the final solution, the final solution to the Jewish question, as the Nazis called it, was not random violence. So there was plenty of random violence in which some people in Poland and the Baltic States joined in. Some of the most horrible atrocities, the most gruesome atrocities, were of local people turning on their own Jewish population with the encouragement of the Germans and carrying out some slaughter, a pogrom of the Jewish population.
- 6.50 But the real atrocity, the "Final Solution," is not random, but a plan ruthlessly carried out from 1941 onwards, with the creation of a whole network of death factories, of which the most notorious is Auschwitz-Birkenau. And this is a photograph of its notorious main gate with railway lines running through it, through which trainloads of victims were brought to be gassed and burnt.
- 6.51 This was planned from the autumn of 1941. The notorious Wannsee conference was held near Berlin in January 1942 to coordinate the plan between various government departments. The extermination camps in Poland, Auschwitz, of course, Treblinka, and

Birkenau, and Belzec, were operating from early 1942 with the use of gas chambers. And this process continued right through the war. The last large group of victims were Jews from western and southern, sorry, from eastern, well, western and eastern and southern Europe, and from Hungary, who were deported and killed en masse as late as 1944, just before the Russians arrived.

- 6.52** Of course, we know that Jews were not the only victims. Disabled people, Roma, homosexuals, were also victims of the Nazis, but overwhelmingly, the victims were Jews. What can history say about this? Well, I think what history can say is somewhat limited. I don't know that anyone can explain this in any deep philosophical or moral sense. All that historians can do is to try to look at how and when and where and by whom these things were done and to try to draw some conclusions about the whole event.
- 6.53** I think one of the most interesting historians is the American historian Christopher Browning, who has done precisely this by looking minutely at the detail of the timing of events and of decision-making. So Hitler made a speech to the Reichstag in January 1941, before the invasion of Russia, in which he said this. "Today, I will once more be a prophet. If the international Jewish financiers in and outside Europe should succeed in plunging nations once more into a world war"—blame it on the Jews, of course—"then," he says, "the result will not be the Bolshevization of the Earth, and this the victory of jury, but the annihilation of the Jewish race in Europe."
- 6.54** So Hitler has started the war. He blames it on the Jews and says it will lead to the annihilation of the Jewish race in Europe. The beginning of the genocide is really in 1941, and that, as Browning points out, is when Germany seems to be winning. Because it had sometimes been said that the Germans, the Nazis, carried out the Holocaust when they thought they were losing. But it seems that it was really begun when they thought they were winning, and hence it was something that they really wanted to do. And they started to do it when they had the freedom of action, as they saw it, and it continued as long as the war continued.
- 6.55** They persisted with the genocide even when this was damaging their own war effort. After all, they were short of labor and of skilled labor, and it would have been sensible to use—after all, these are ruthless people. They use people. Why not use the Jews as laborers? But no, it was more important to kill them than to use them. And Browning talks about the killings being carried on by ordinary men. He did a study of a police battalion that was used in the early stages of the Holocaust in murdering people in Eastern Europe, and found out, by looking carefully at the cases, not everyone quite agrees with this, but that they were not fanatical Nazis.
- 6.56** They were fairly ordinary policemen, soldiers, and that their motivations seemed to have been very, let's say, low-level and banal, not to be seen as weak by your mates, not to be seen as trying to get out of doing an unpleasant job, wanting to show that you're a tough guy. And that even those who refused to do it or said to their

commanders, "I don't think I can do this today; it's making me feel bad," they were just told to keep out of the way until they felt better. So they were not being told, "You kill these Jews or you'll be shot." They were doing it for reasons that are really pretty feeble. The Jewish philosopher Hannah Arendt talked about the banality of evil, and I think that's a lesson that one takes from this. Very evil things are being done by very ordinary people.

- 6.57** I want to look at some other aspects of total war. One is the use of hunger as a weapon, which both sides used and perhaps always had been used in war, but now on a much bigger scale. I'm giving you a list here of the number of calories that different groups were having as their daily intake in 1941. Britain was pretty well-off. On average, 2,800 calories a day, which is adequate for health. Germany, 2,570, also adequate for health. Though by 1945, the German calorie count had gone down to 860 a day, which is certainly not. In Norway, 1,600, which is about 60% of the necessary level. In France, 1,300, about 50% of the necessary level.
- 6.58** But in Eastern Europe, we're talking about a quite different story. In Poland, the legal amount was 845 calories. For Jews in Poland, 400 calories. That is quick starvation. And of Russian prisoners of war, the Germans were allowing 10,000 of them to die every day of starvation. So hunger is also a weapon of war and a weapon of genocide. Total war was not only practiced by totalitarian states, though I suppose totalitarian states find it easier to do, but the Allies were also using total methods, of which bombing was the most obvious.
- 6.59** And of course, the atom bomb was eventually used in Japan, as we know, but this is not part of our story. But this was deliberate and planned. The Lancaster bomber was commissioned in 1936 in Britain. It could carry up to 10 tons of bombs, and over 7,000 were built. The Royal Air Force reported that there was bound to be—this was in September 1939—there is bound to be incidental loss and possibly heavy loss of civilian life. They'd gone further than that by 1942, predicting a scale of bombardment which would far transcend anything in human experience, involving the destruction of eight million houses, 900,000 deaths, and 1 million serious injuries. That's what they were expecting or planning for. And in fact, the Royal Air Force dropped nearly a million tons of bombs on Germany.
- 6.60** There's a photograph here, an aerial photograph, of a firestorm in Hamburg in 1943. This was probably the single biggest loss of life in Europe during the war, 37,000 people killed in one bombing campaign. Total German losses from bombing, 353,000 killed. Total civilian bombing over the whole of Europe, 600,000 killed, over a million seriously injured. A firestorm, you may know, is something that happens when a fire reaches a certain intensity, a certain temperature, and then the convection draws in air at gale force and feeds the fire, makes it even hotter, and makes it uncontrollable, and also uses up all the oxygen so that people who are in that area will either die of heat,

burning, or suffocate through lack of oxygen if they're sheltered, for example, in bunkers or in underground shelters.

- 6.61** This was perfectly deliberately done by the British, by the Royal Air Force, who had actually experimented on how to cause firestorms, and it was done as the deliberate main tactic. Now, why? Why would you do this? Well, the obvious answer is because you're fighting a total war, but that's perhaps not quite enough of an explanation. The main, I suppose, rational explanation is because there's no other way of fighting. There was no way Britain could invade Germany. The only way of stopping the war or fighting the war was by aerial attack.
- 6.62** And the only way of doing this was by bombing cities, because at that time, aircraft could not hit small targets. They could only hit big targets, and that meant cities. So you essentially are aiming to bomb a city— and what the RAF officially called de-housing. In other words, you say, we're aiming to destroy all the houses so that the workers can no longer work, the factories can no longer produce, and we shall therefore destroy the German economy.
- 6.63** Now, this was questioned morally during the war, famously by the Bishop of Chichester, who said it was destroying civilization. And since then, by many historians who have often said, well, not only was this a barbarous act of war, but it also didn't work, which you might think makes it worse. But did bombing work? I think that recent research has shown, in fact, that it did. I'm not sure if that's more disturbing or less disturbing. But yes, bombing Germany worked.
- 6.64** It was a huge effort. In 1944, Britain had 50,000 air crew, 174,000 ground staff servicing the aircraft, 26,000 aircraft were produced, and this was a major proportion of the war effort. But in Germany, what really worked more than anything else was that Germany was forced to defend itself against aerial attack. Two million workers were engaged in building aircraft, and this absorbed over 40% of German total war production. Whereas if I remember rightly, the production of tanks for fighting the Russians was only 7% of production. 70 % of all Germany's fighter planes were in the West, and home air defenses, guns, and so on, fire brigades, absorbed over 900,000 men.
- 6.65** So the key effect of the bombing campaign was, first of all, to force Germany's war effort into air defense and away from everything else, and in the end, indeed, to destroy the German infrastructure. It also did demoralize the population. Demoralized workers were staying away from their jobs. Nazi party members were no longer wearing their party badges, were no longer giving the Hitler salute. The Gestapo reported that no leading industrialists any longer believed that Germany could win. And this is pretty symbolic. In August 1943, the chief of the German air staff, the chief of Luftwaffe, committed suicide. So the German economy and German society were indeed breaking down, but at huge cost.

- 6.66 Other parts of total war, I'll cover this very quickly. Partisan warfare ends distinctions between soldier and civilian, and also of age and sex, and also of legality. Can you just kill civilians? The answer is yes, you can, if you accuse them of being partisans. Total methods, mobilization and control of your whole society. Even in liberal Britain, this was unprecedented and largely voluntary, or at least accepted. The Labour party leader, Clement Attlee, said in 1940, "It's necessary that the government should be given complete control over all persons, rich and poor, employer and workman, man or woman, and all property." Eventually, 90% of men and 40% of women were engaged in the armed forces or some other form of war work.
- 6.67 The Nazi regime was less confident it could ask its people to do this, but instead it exploited occupied territories and used millions of slave laborers. Soviet Russia used extreme methods of compulsion in war, as in peace indeed, and was also helped to maintain support at home by the terrible atrocities committed in Russia by the Germans.
- 6.68 And yet, if there is a total war being fought, not every aspect of it was total. Let me just very quickly mention some differences. There were differences between the East and the West. The fighting in the East was far more atrocious than the fighting in the West. Certain methods were not used. Poison gas was not used, though people had been terrified it would be. Women were not used for frontline combat, either by the Nazis or by the Western Allies, though they were by the Russians. And aims, in the end, it turned out that Germany, Italy, and Japan were relatively little changed as societies.
- 6.69 Though there had been a plan in 1944 called the Morgenthau Plan, which was to de-industrialize Germany, to destroy all of German industry, and reduce Germany to being a purely agricultural society, that proved to be impossible, but it's interesting that it was contemplated, but that degree of totality was not enforced.
- 6.70 I'm getting near the end of the story. The end of the war in Europe began with D-Day in June 1944, which was a huge effort. I said a minute ago that amateurs talk of tactics, professionals talk of logistics. D-day required 7,000 ships. It required 500 trainloads of petrol immediately, and it required control of the oceans, particularly the Atlantic. Then came the battle of Normandy and 10 months of large-scale conventional fighting to end the war in Europe. The continuing existence of Nazi Germany was costing huge numbers of lives every day. Death camp victims were still being gassed. Soldiers on all sides were dying. People were dying in aerial bombardment. People were dying of starvation. So the war had to be ended as quickly as possible, but it still took 10 months after D-Day.
- 6.71 The Germans carried on resisting. Why? Fear, and I think probably particularly fear of Russia, fear of what the Russians might do to them. The patriotic bomb plotters who tried and failed to blow up Hitler in July 1944, who were genuinely heroic—pity they didn't succeed— but their aim was to make peace with the British and Americans, and carry on fighting the Russians. The Allies were not interested in encouraging that sort of

thing. They were determined that the alliance should remain solid and that therefore they demanded unconditional surrender of Germany, and that certainly prolonged the war.

- 6.72** It took time to push the German forces back. It took time to capture ports to supply the armies through Antwerp and Rotterdam. There was a failure in September 1944 to capture bridges across the Rhine at Arnhem, which was aimed to win the war by Christmas 1944. But then there was a German counterattack in December '44, the so-called Battle of the Bulge, which was intended to stop the Allies from using the port at Antwerp. But once the Rhine was finally crossed in March '45, German resistance then crumbled. Hitler committed suicide on the 30th of April, and Germany surrendered on the 7th of May.
- 6.73** So, let me draw a few concluding points. Could Nazi Germany have won or at least survived? Well, I've said I don't think it could. Not in the long run, as long as Britain and America could control the oceans and hence keep Russia in the war, and America, as long as America maintained its role as arsenal of democracy. What happened? Well, the Germans started losing on the periphery, first of all, in North Africa, Russia, and then Italy. And of course, there was also a war going on against Japan in Burma and the Pacific.
- 6.74** The Germans never seized control of the seas despite their U-boats. There were never enough of them. It couldn't defend itself against bombing. And then came D-Day and the general advance of American, British, Canadian, Polish, and Russian forces. So there was no need to use the atom bomb. Someone I knew, in fact, he was a master of my college. His name was Harry Hinsley. He had worked as a very young man. In fact, he'd been recruited as a student at Bletchley Park in decoding secret German signals. I asked him once what did he think was the main importance of the work that he and others had done in Bletchley Park. He said he thought it probably shortened the war by several months. And that if that had not happened, probably the Allies would have used the atom bomb on Berlin, which is worth thinking about.
- 6.75** Now, the war ends. Famous photographs of American and Russian soldiers embracing each other as they meet up in Germany. And also it seems to me that only then in 1945 did Western audiences really understand the evils of the Nazi regime, insofar as they even yet did. You could say, well, they had many of the facts. Many of the facts had been published in the press, but these seemed not really to have sunk in. They were too awful for people to comprehend, and they were even dismissed as propaganda.
- 6.76** But then the camp at Belsen, Bergen-Belsen, was liberated by the British army, and it was full of thousands of deceased, starving, and dying people and piles of corpses. The BBC reporter Richard Dimbleby sent a report to the BBC of what he'd seen, and they refused to believe it. Only when they got the film did they believe what had been happening. So the ruins were not only physical, but also moral. And I'll come back to this in my next lecture.

- 6.77 Is it possible to say how the people of Europe, and these are my last thoughts, how European culture was affected by this collapse of civilization? The exiled German philosopher, Theodor Adorno, famously said that writing poetry after Auschwitz was barbarism. But, of course, people did still write poetry, and indeed, it seems this was the main reaction. People didn't want to think too much about it. They wanted to forget. They didn't want to talk about it. They wanted to get back to normal, including by denial.
- 6.78 It took a long time for the experience of the war to be processed, insofar as it ever has been processed, often by a later generation, and for terrible and shameful experiences to be acknowledged openly in works of history and literature, in film and television, and in public speeches. One French historian has called this "a past that wouldn't pass." And to give one example, again, a French example, it was only in 1995, 50 years after the end of the war, that President Jacques Chirac acknowledged officially that the French state had taken part in the Holocaust. Similar stories of denial or delay or obfuscation can be related of other countries, too. So how Europe coped with a legacy of the war will be the starting point of my next lecture. Thank you.
- 6.79 A very interesting lecture again. Thank you. Was there any sense in the late 1930s in Germany that a war was inevitable? If not, this might be too crude, but why didn't Hitler stop wanting to expand, for instance, by not going into Poland?
- 6.80 Hitler's whole *raison d'être*, in a way, was that there would be a revenge for the First World War in which Germany and the German race and the Aryan race would finally dominate the world. To say, well, do you really think this is good idea? Well, that was his idea. There was no alternative. On the other hand, the German people were not in favor of war. And indeed, I remember my colleague, Sir Richard Evans, great historian of the Third Reich, saying that, in fact, German morale was much shakier than that of France or Britain in 1940. If the Germans had started losing, then morale would have collapsed.
- 6.81 But the German people didn't want war. Didn't elect the Nazis, well, 40% of them, in order to have a war. They did so because they wanted to have a cure for unemployment. The terrible effect of the collapse of France in 1940, which I described earlier, which was due not to Hitler, but to the brilliance, unfortunately, of the German general staff—it made Hitler seem like a genius, and his prestige among the German people became unassailable after 1940 because it seemed he'd won this war almost cost-free.
- 6.82 And after that, it was too late to do anything about it. And even so, unless you could blow Hitler up, he never lost that grip. And it seems that people, or many people, I'm generalizing, people began to realize that they were losing, but they still hoped that Hitler might come up with some brilliant solution because after all, Hitler had proved he was some sort of a genius. And so they couldn't surrender to the Russians, but

maybe Hitler would manage to pull some miraculous victory or at least something that would save them from the worst, out of the hat, as it were.

6.83 And so, I'm sure you probably know that many of the details. The army, or conservatives in the army, tried to blow Hitler up in 1944 and carry out a military coup. But Hitler wasn't blown up. And when Hitler was able to go on the radio and say, "I'm still here, I'm not dead," the whole coup collapsed, which shows the extent to which Hitler had still managed to maintain some sort of grip over the whole nation and its organizations.

Lecture 7: After the Wars: Europe Divided

At a glance — After the wars — a divided Europe.

- 7.1** In this lecture, I'm going to talk about the post-war period, the Cold War and the end of empires. In 1945, as you know, much of Europe was in ruins, not only physically, but as I said in the last lecture, morally. Over 40 million people had died in Europe alone, and most of these were not soldiers, but civilians, victims of mass murder, of starvation, of bombing.
- 7.2** Germany, which was, I suppose, almost universally regarded as Europe's most educated nation, leaders of literature, science, music, had committed genocide. Millions had been enslaved. About a million German women were raped, mainly by Russians, in 1945. More than 50 million people were without homes. More than 6 million people were displaced, many of them ethnically cleansed from Eastern Europe.
- 7.3** So what was left? Well, physically, huge destruction. Three-quarters of the buildings in Berlin were uninhabitable. Economically, much of the continent was starving and workless. Socially, millions of people displaced, orphaned, homeless. Politically, too, many states had been destroyed. Their rulers were dead, exiled, or discredited, and national pride was shattered. Psychologically, what does it do to millions of people who've lived through these deeply traumatizing experiences? But morally, too. What happened to Germany?
- 7.4** As I said in my last lecture, there had originally been a plan to reduce it to being a purely agricultural society, and this could not be done, partly because it would have been too damaging to the whole European economy, but instead it was divided. Divided into occupation zones by the Russians, the British, the Americans, and the French. Large parts of Eastern Germany, some of the oldest parts of the Prussian Kingdom, were turned into another country, Poland, and their population expelled. And Germany was about to be, or soon would be, divided permanently between the Russian and the Western Allied zones. I'll just mention in passing that over a million German prisoners of war died in Soviet camps.
- 7.5** Many other people all over Europe had been, to some degree, complicit in the horrors of the last generation. Many had either shared in totalitarian ideas and crimes, or at least acquiesced in them. Millions had collaborated with foreign occupiers, and many had betrayed others, their neighbors. Millions had been indifferent. That was probably the main reaction to the sufferings of victims. They were too busy looking after themselves and their families. Most, arguably, as I suggested in the last lecture, wanted really to forget what had happened and to evade responsibility.
- 7.6** Should we conclude that Europe's culture had been tarnished by this experience? The Nazis had praised Wagner's music, which Hitler had been devoted to, or at least pretended to be. Should one listen to Wagner after the Holocaust? And what about

other fundamental European ideas about progress, which had been used to justify things like the communist totalitarianism? Evolution, which had been used to create a racist ideology which the Germans had used to justify the Holocaust. Science, which had been used in the most abusive ways. As Churchill once said, "The nation itself had been used as an excuse to attack others."

- 7.7 So it could be said that much of European culture had been used to justify tyranny and genocide. And indeed, that's what many people today do say, and which I'll come back to later. Fortunately, there's something to be put on the credit side of the balance sheet. Millions had fought back against totalitarianism. Many had risked torture, death, and I suppose even worse, the death of their families, because in many cases, whole families would be punished for the acts of one. Some people had indeed risked their lives to save victims.
- 7.8 And European culture was also a symbol and a motive of resistance to totalitarianism. People who resisted often felt they were doing so in the name of European ideas, such as human rights, patriotism, human equality. These had been used as a motive for resistance. Nevertheless, people were aware of humiliation that they had suffered and the crimes that had been committed by others and perhaps even by themselves. The immediate reaction, pretty naturally perhaps, was one of retribution, punishment, and scapegoating.
- 7.9 Here is a fairly typical picture taken in France in the summer of 1944 of two women accused, no doubt, of having sexual relations with the German occupiers who are being paraded through the streets with their head shaved and often daubed with Nazi symbols, with painted swastikas on their foreheads, and so on. Beaten up, humiliated, and surrounded by a crowd which is clearly enjoying the spectacle and sees this as a way of, I don't know, excusing or, in some ways, atoning for the humiliation they themselves had suffered.
- 7.10 And in all occupied countries, there was a post-liberation wave of killing of collaborators. In Belgium, it was very small, only 265. But in France, it was about 10,000. In Yugoslavia, it was around 70,000. And trials followed in all countries. In France, 25,000 people were put on trial for collaboration. And some of them, well, a few were shot, including the Prime Minister or the former Prime Minister, Pierre Laval. His death was somewhat gruesome, and it's fairly typical of the time. He tried to commit suicide before his execution. But rather than allowing him to kill himself, his captors pumped out his stomach—he'd swallowed poison—managed to get him conscious again so he could be carried out and tied to a stake and shot.
- 7.11 But most people escaped or received minor penalties, and pretty soon people wanted to put this behind them. In Germany, there was a program of denazification, as it was officially called. But after the first wave, I think it's pretty undeniable that people wanted not to hear any more about this and even to see themselves rather than others as victims. For example, many German civilians were forced by the Allies to go to watch

newsreel films of concentration camps. But one observer recorded that they were refusing to look at the screen. They were just turning their heads away. I think this seems to be symbolic of a whole attitude; we don't want to know.

7.12 Many prisoners who came back, who had survived the camps and who came back, found that their friends and their families didn't really want to talk about it with them. They say, "Oh yes, but we were suffering, too. We were pretty short of food. It wasn't very nice here either. We don't really want to know what happened to you."

7.13 Now, you could say, well, wasn't this in the long run necessary? Did Europe, the peoples of Europe, not really have to move on and find some way of living with the past? I suppose they did. Certainly, they did manage to do this, and perhaps it would not have been helpful for the conflicts to be continued indefinitely. Whether they ended too soon is a matter of opinion, I suppose. But many people think that the denazification process in Germany was very superficial and that many people got away with it, certainly got away with it for many years.

7.14 But people wanted to forget and move on. I think two things clearly helped this. One was the beginning of the Cold War, which I'll come to later. It gave you something else to think about, something else to worry about, and also to forget some of the things that you preferred not to have in the forefront of your mind. We know there are notorious cases of Nazi, Gestapo officials or SS men who were recruited by Allied intelligence services to help them in their resistance to communist infiltration. So the beginning of the Cold War was a great distraction.

7.15 And the other thing was the beginning of economic recovery, which was helped by the American Marshall Plan, which essentially provided dollar credits so that European countries could import necessary goods from America or using dollars. And this helped to begin a period of rapid postwar economic recovery and rebuilding, the creation of welfare systems, the creation of full employment, the mass building of houses to replace those destroyed during the war.

7.16 I think we ought to recall that one country had a rather different experience, which was, of course, Britain. Britain had been victorious, but had suffered damage and, in particular, economic devastation. The huge costs of the war and of the attempt to continue a global postwar military and naval presence, and also the occupation of much of northern Germany meant, I suppose, many people would have felt ironically that rationing of food and necessities had to be continued in Britain longer than it was on the continent because of the costs of victory, in a sense, so that food and necessities continued to be rationed in England until 1954.

7.17 Nevertheless, London staged the Olympic Games in 1948—obviously, a deliberate attempt to say normal life, civilization, is resuming, and also a thing called the Festival of Britain in 1951, a nationwide arts festival, which was meant to be a tonic to a weary and exhausted country. And a newly elected Labour government did create a welfare

state between 1946 and '48, including the National Health Service, which remains a huge presence in British life. As one conservative politician said, "the nearest thing the British today have to a religion."

- 7.18** The Cold War. Inevitably, perhaps, tensions got worse between the Western Allies and the Soviet Union. The Soviet Union was determined, and I think one can understand why, to hold on to the territories it had occupied, which in part it saw as a defense against possibly German or other Western aggression, but which was also intended as a step towards the spread of communism throughout Europe. And so the Russians imposed obedient communist regimes on their occupied territories and suppressed any democratic opposition. This was the creation of the famous "iron curtain," as Winston Churchill called it in March 1946, which remained in place until the late 1980s, as you will know.
- 7.19** And I don't suppose any of you are old enough to have actually seen it, though bits of the wall remain, have been preserved in Berlin, but a fortified boundary that ran right across Europe from the Baltic to the Adriatic. Barbed wire, minefields, guard dogs, machine gun posts, and so on. I'll be saying more about the Cold War later, but it spread globally and it lasted intermittently for 40 years.
- 7.20** The other great change in the world, which I think is necessary to summarize, is decolonization—the fairly rapid end of European empires over the next generation. The empires had been built up in the 19th century. They reached a peak in the early 20th century, and they declined and disappeared at the end of that century. Why? I think the answers are pretty obvious. The decline of European power, wealth, and prestige. Secondly, the hostile or at least ambivalent attitude of the USA, and the, thirdly, the encouragement of anticolonial rebellions, often communist-inspired by the Soviet Union and China.
- 7.21** So this was the process of decolonization, but there were certainly great differences in how it happened in different places. The biggest event, I suppose, without doubt, was the independence of India, which was by far the most populous and largest of European colonial dependencies. India had had a degree of internal self-government since the 1920s, and it had been promised full independence during the war to help ensure Indian cooperation. The tragedy was that Hindus and Muslims, against the preferred policy of Britain, forced a partition into Hindu India and Muslim Pakistan, and this was accompanied by huge ethnic cleansing and bloodshed.
- 7.22** Who was responsible for this is still a matter of heated debate. Many Indians blame the British for either creating or encouraging divisions between Hindus and Muslims. Some British historians would answer that it had always been the policy of the British government and the colonial authorities to keep India united, but they hadn't got the power to prevent the partition, which became an unstoppable movement of ethnic cleansing, violence, and the movement of people.

- 7.23** Yet the independence of India, perhaps a little strangely, was not generally taken as meaning that the age of empires was over. Indeed, postwar economic need in Europe, fear of communist influence, and even progressive ideas about welfare meant that the European empires, and especially the French and the British, intended to have a future. I want to talk about France and then Britain, the two largest European empires still existing.
- 7.24** France regarded its empire as crucial for its great power status. And indeed, the capital of free France during the latter part of the war had been in Algiers. And it made a huge effort to hang on to its empire. Indeed, it has retained many smaller colonies, now renamed overseas territories or overseas departments. And it has tried to follow a neocolonial policy in Africa, practically up to the present day. But it also fought two major wars in Vietnam, then called Indochina, and Algeria, to retain them in its empire. And these wars were at first supported by many on the left.
- 7.25** If you remember, I mentioned that the French justified their empire in terms of having what they called a civilizing mission, spreading what they saw as the progressive values of the French Revolution and of European civilization to less developed parts of the world. And so many on the left saw those who were rebelling against the French Empire as essentially reactionary. These were reactionary forces who were against the civilization of the modern world. And the Algerian war, in particular, led to appalling bloodshed and also nearly caused a civil war in France, and it ended only in 1962.
- 7.26** Britain, too, expected to retain much of its empire, especially its African empire, which was seen as economically valuable and not ready for self-government. But in the late 1950s and early 1960s, this changed. And the Prime Minister, Harold Macmillan, made a very famous speech in South Africa in which he said "a wind of change" was blowing through the continent. And after that, British policy became largely one of preparing colonies for independence and hoping to keep them economically and politically close to Britain through the Commonwealth—of course, as you know, a free association of former colonial states.
- 7.27** But in Britain, too, there was serious violence, both in Kenya and in Malaya. But empires were very complex, and decolonization was complex, too. So I'd like to recall the main examples. So, India—Britain negotiated independence with India, hoping to keep India as an ally and member of Commonwealth, which it is. In Vietnam, France fought a war from 1945 to '54, which it lost. But then America took over the Vietnam War, as you will recall, until 1975. And the common element for both France and America is to resist a Communist takeover, backed by Russia and China. But both America and France failed.
- 7.28** In Malaya, a British colony, there was a so-called emergency between 1948 and 1960, in which the British successfully defeated a Chinese-backed rebellion led by communists. The rebellion was largely confined to the Chinese minority in Malaya and opposed by the Malay majority. And as the British promised future independence and

continued to protect Malaysia, as it became, from Indonesian aggression, this was usually seen as a successful example of decolonization. Relations between Malaysia and Britain remained, and I suppose remained pretty friendly, and in the case of Singapore, very friendly indeed. In fact, I think Singapore and Hong Kong are probably the only places in which people will openly say that they thought the Empire had been a very good experience.

- 7.29** It's often been said, or at least some historians, especially an American historian called Caroline Elkins, has recently written about the degree of violence that took place in the Malayan emergency. And of course, there was violence. It was a civil war. But most people, I think, still would say that it had been a successful outcome, which was in fact the creation of a peaceful and constitutionally governed Malaysian state, and a prosperous one.
- 7.30** The worst episode in British decolonization was in Kenya, or Kenya, as it was called at the time, which was the Mau Mau rebellion between 1952 and '60. It was largely a hyperviolent conflict between Africans. Very few white settlers, in fact, were killed in this, though they were very, very frightened by it, because Mau Mau appeared to be, and if you like, you can say there was a racist element here. It seemed to be an extremely reactionary African terrorist movement, drawing on the worst relics of African superstition, with people forced to take oaths, to drink blood, whatever. And many British authorities and British people felt that this was a terrifying resurgence of ancient barbarism. So it made it a very nasty episode.
- 7.31** And the British colonial authorities suppressed the rebellion with unusual severity. Over 100,000 convicted Mau Mau terrorists were hanged, which had never happened before in any British colony. Many more died in the fighting. Large numbers were interned. The civilian population, as in Malaya, were placed in protected villages, which was a way of cutting them off from Mau Mau, or from the communists in Malaya, and cutting off supplies from the rebels. And there was considerable ill treatment and even torture, though this was often investigated and attempts were made to stop it. But nevertheless, the Mau Mau revolt was a very nasty episode. And for many people, it tended to discredit the whole idea that there was a colonial future for any European state in Africa.
- 7.32** But by far, the bloodiest decolonization war was in Algeria, between 1954 and 1962, with appalling atrocities on both sides. It was complicated by Algeria's strange legal status as part of France. One French general said, "The Mediterranean runs through France as the Seine runs through Paris." Algeria was France. This had been proclaimed during the 1848 revolution, ironically, which had claimed that Algeria was a land forever French. And so it was not like, at least they didn't see it as decolonization. They saw it as a removal of part of French territory and also complicated by the presence of a European settler population.

- 7.33 And large French forces were committed to the war, and it's usually accepted that at least 400,000 Algerians died in the fighting. The war caused bitter divisions in France, especially when French conscripts were sent; and the decision to withdraw, as I said a minute ago, almost caused a civil war and did, in fact, bring about a peaceful coup d'état, which brought General de Gaulle, the wartime French leader, back into power as President in order to sort out the chaos that was caused by the Algerian war.
- 7.34 The whole question of empires and coloniality has become in recent years so ideologically charged and so central to public discourse that I don't think there's any way of not making a few brief—I hope brief—final comments. I recall one distinguished British historian of empire saying that this was our Holocaust, which I don't think is true, but it's interesting that such a thing could be said. Now, I've talked about European empires before, and I've said they were enormously complex with multiple causes, very different methods of rule, very contradictory consequences, and also empires differed from each other, and individually, they changed a great deal over time, which makes it very difficult to draw up some balance sheet of costs and benefits—though, as I may have said before, this is not something that we usually demand of other empires.
- 7.35 We don't ask whether the Ottoman Empire or the Mughal Empire or the Chinese Empire were on balance, good or bad. But I suppose the European empires are still too recent for them to be regarded as simply historical phenomena. Most empires relied on acceptance and collaboration by their peoples. Sometimes this was coerced, often not. One historian has called the British Empire in Asia and Africa, really a joint enterprise with Indians, as much of its economy was run by Indian merchants and Indian workers, as indentured workers, moved to various parts of the empire, and indeed were supported in doing so by the government of India.
- 7.36 If I could just tell you a small anecdote, I was at a conference in Paris a few years ago, and one of the participants was a very distinguished French historian of the French Empire, who had been brought up in a French colony in Africa. And he said, yes, I remember the French Empire, he said, in this town where he was brought up in Senegal, I think it was. I remember the French Empire. My father was headmaster of the local school, and the station master at the railway station was French, and the sergeant who commanded the local gendarmerie was French, and those three men were the French Empire as far as that city was concerned.
- 7.37 And I think one has to remember how small and, in many ways, weak colonial empires were. It's often said, and I guess it's true, that United Nations agencies and NGOs have far larger numbers of people involved in Africa than the European empires ever did in their heyday. So they were fairly weak and they relied on being accepted. But when they offered less, as they did after the war, and when they seemed vulnerable, or when a new indigenous elite began to demand power, and when that elite received outside support from the Russians or from the Chinese or from the Americans or indeed from

the United Nations, which was adopted, which had adopted a policy of decolonization, then there was no way that these empires could long persist or even perhaps, really, wanted to persist.

- 7.38 But there was some support, and I've heard older people in India say this, for empires, and some who even said they regretted independence, especially, of course, when independent governments proved incompetent or corrupt or oppressive. At best, empires offered law and order, economic development, modern technology, and a new vision of the future. Ironically, this is now precisely what is criticized by some exponents of decolonization. Not, by which they don't mean independence for colonies, which of course happened long ago, but the rejection in principle of Western values, which many postcolonial rulers of ex-colonies actually wanted for a time to espouse.
- 7.39 But no, that modern decolonizers see that it was Western values themselves that were wrong in principle when imposed, as they would see it, on other cultures. I've read some of what the Pitt Rivers Museum in Oxford makes of this, which I quoted because after all, it's a great cultural institution in a great world university. Let me just quote a little bit of it again. "Colonialism seeks to overwrite existing cultural systems in the belief that colonial cultures are superior." Now, you might say that was at least partly true. "The cultural systems that often get imposed are capitalism, communism, religion, scientific logic, racism, patriarchy, and gender binary."
- 7.40 Well, some of this is patently untrue. It's bizarre to suggest that patriarchy and gender binary were imposed by colonial authorities on societies like the Zulus or the Asante Kingdom or Benin, or indeed on India, which were themselves highly patriarchal and with very developed sense of a gender binary. And much of this seems, in any case, vastly overstated and vague. It assumes huge power by often short-lived empires and implies that indigenous people were and remain entirely passive and powerless. Once you've been touched by coloniality, it seems that you're incapable of ever escaping from it. But that is clearly not true.
- 7.41 If patriarchy had been imposed on African countries by colonialists, what is to stop African countries from ridding themselves of patriarchy once they're independent? The reality, surely, is that colonialism usually accepted local cultures insofar as it could, and the extent to which it overwrote them, it did so only in a pretty superficial way and at a political level; but it didn't change the societies, or the cultures of those societies, at a deeper level.
- 7.42 Nevertheless, some of the accusation is true. It must seem very offensive that European place names are applied to places in other cultures. You might well want to change the names back to the indigenous names, so that in Australia, Ayers Rock becomes Uluru. But do we also want to reject scientific logic? Have any former colonized peoples chosen to reject scientific logic? And what about other colonial impositions, such as human rights, civil liberties, the rule of law, democracy or

individual freedom? Was it tyrannical to forbid the burning of widows, forced marriage, or female genital mutilation?

- 7.43** I mentioned in an earlier lecture Zulu warriors, who complained that under the British, they had practically lost control over their girls and women. Was that a bad thing? Was it colonial oppression to stop slavery, cannibalism, the human sacrifice of slaves, and tribal warfare? In some non-European territories, the murder rate due to tribal warfare reached 500 times the murder rate in Britain. Is it not also very strange for today's enemies of coloniality often to be critics of non-European countries that refuse gay and transgender rights? Should they not regard this as coloniality today?
- 7.44** The other dominating process at this time, and one that was far more important to most Europeans in the end of Empire was, of course, the Cold War, and that's what I want to talk about now. Russia, as I said, had imposed its power over Eastern Europe, killing and imprisoning political dissidents. Yet it took a long time for the nature of communist rule to be accepted by many progressives in the West. A first turning point came in 1956 with the Hungarian uprising, which was brutally suppressed by Russian tanks.
- 7.45** But the same year, and this was even more upsetting for many on the left, the Russian leader, Nikita Khrushchev, made a secret speech to the Soviet Party conference, which was immediately leaked to the Western press, in which he attacked Stalin and his repressive policies, or at least the repressive policies that were applied to other communists. And this began a sharp decline in communist and Marxist support, with some intellectuals, though not all, taking a clearly anti-Marxist and anti-communist stand and expressing regret for their earlier support.
- 7.46** To give a couple of examples, the French historian François Furet, whom I quoted in an earlier lecture as talking about the French Revolution saying farewell to history, had been a communist, but he decided after he lost faith in communism, that he must change his whole approach to history. And one of the things he did was to try to deconstruct and debunk the myth of the French Revolution, which communists had seen as a step towards communism, and to try to recover a more liberal history of France, in which you point out that revolution was not the only way.
- 7.47** In fact, a better way was, or would have been, the adoption of a more liberal policy as during the early years of the revolution before the terror. But in contrast to people like Furet, who left the Communist Party in 1956, the equally or even more distinguished British historian Eric Hobsbawm remained very close to communism throughout his career. And his critics, at least, would say he always tended to downplay or excuse the atrocities of communism.
- 7.48** So 1956, the Hungarian uprising and Khrushchev's secret speech were the first big shocks to the Western— the left in the West, communist, socialist, and progressive, generally. It's perhaps hard to recall that many people who are not communists

regarded the Soviet Union with great respect, and Stalin was seen as a great leader of his people who had defeated fascism. There was even a rather sentimental liking for Russia because of Russia's status as a Western ally, and a tendency, in fact, to exaggerate the degree to which Russia was responsible for the defeat of Nazism. But so those were the events that almost started the landslide.

- 7.49** Literature, too, had a huge influence. And you will know some of these works; some of them are very famous. But the extent to which literature affected a whole cultural attitude, I think needs to be recognized. There was repression in the Soviet Union. There was some denialism in the West. But nevertheless, the cumulative effect of a list of important books did change many people's ideas about what communism meant. I've given a little list here, some of which, as I say, I'm sure you will know.
- 7.50** Arthur Koestler's book, *The Darkness at Noon*, that was published in London in 1940, was an attempt to explain the purges. Why would a loyal communist admit to having been a traitor, as many loyal communists did under the Stalin purges? And Koestler came up with a kind of psychological explanation. I think we know now that much more likely was the fact they were tortured into it. George Orwell, *Animal Farm*, published in 1945. George Orwell, again, *1984*, published in 1949. Still very widely read.
- 7.51** Gustaw Herling, not so well known, a Pole, who wrote a book called *A World Apart*. I actually met Herling, and I'm pretty sure he told me he'd had quite a lot of difficulty in getting the book published. He tried in France, and left-wing publishers refused to publish it because they said they didn't believe it. But what it was, was a factual account of his experience in Russian concentration camps after the Russian invasion of Poland. In fact, he and other prisoners were released once Germany invaded Russia and were allowed to go and join the British Army in Egypt. But eventually, his book was published in 1951, the first account of life inside a Russian concentration camp, which many people had not previously believed existed or denied it existed.
- 7.52** Boris Pasternak, *Dr. Zhivago*, I suppose the greatest and most famous of any of these books, was refused publication in the USSR, eventually published in Italy in 1957. Why so controversial? It is, after all, a great love story. Because it describes the Russian revolution in less than heroic and approving terms. Then finally, Alexander Solzhenitsyn, once famous across the world as a great resister to totalitarianism, who published in 1962, and it had a huge impact, a book called *One Day in the Life of Ivan Denisovich*, which was literally a blow-by-blow account of one day in the life of a prisoner in the Russian gulag, in a Russian concentration camp.
- 7.53** All these are very well worth reading if you haven't. And finally, Alexander Solzhenitsyn's other great work called *The Gulag Archipelago*, which was an attempt by him, before it was possible to do so by archival research, to write a kind of history of the whole Russian repressive system, published in 1973, and then he was exiled in 1974. It was only after the fall of the Berlin Wall that, for a brief time, historians were allowed to study the Russian archives and discover much of the truth that Solzhenitsyn

had already managed to gather on his own and from oral sources before those archives were closed down again, as they still remain.

7.54 So the prestige of communism, the power of the USSR, was being resisted. But it still seemed immense and was easily able to suppress what was increasingly a youth rebellion against the system. And the most famous example of this youth rebellion briefly coming out into the open was the so-called Prague Spring, from January to August 1968, in which the communist government in Czechoslovakia began to liberalize itself until, in August, half a million troops and more than 7,000 tanks from Russia and other communist states invaded Czechoslovakia and reestablished an authoritarian form of communist rule.

7.55 But this was largely a youth rebellion. And of course, in the West was another youth rebellion, which took other forms. But I suppose we can see common features. The two forms I would suggest are, first of all, the swinging London thing of pop music, clothes, fashion, and a sense of youth being liberated from a pretty conformist and even repressive social system, and a much more political form in May '68 in France, when there was, for a while, a student rebellion in Paris and other cities, which looked as though it might even overthrow the state, though in the end it didn't, and such things rarely, if ever, do.

7.56 There were also, in slightly later years, more, I suppose one would have to say, terroristic left-wing organizations in Germany and Italy, calling themselves Red Brigades in the case of Italy, and the Baader-Meinhof Gang, as it was called in the case of Germany, which carried out terrorist attacks, kidnappings, and assassinations in the cause of communism, largely recruited from the same kind of youthful demographic as the other forms of youth rebellion.

7.57 Now, what were the causes? I mean, this is very important, I think. What explains what we usually call the 1960s, which was really the 1950s to the 1970s? I think there are a number of reasons, and I don't think one can say which is the crucial reason. It was a combination of reasons, as it so often is. I would say, OK, various effects of the Second World War, including the rejection of authority, which is certainly very clear in some countries, of which Germany is probably the most obvious, in which young people growing up know what their parents had done or were involved in or had not resisted, and felt there was no moral authority in the generation older than themselves.

7.58 Postwar economic boom between the 1940s and the 1970s, which in France is called the 30 Glorious Years, and in Britain is often called the Golden Age, but a period of genuine economic boom of the sort we haven't seen since. This brings with it social changes, of which the most important is move from country to town. A large part of the rural population is moving to cities, and that, as in the 19th century, caused a great social and cultural change. More money, more youth employment, more independent young consumers. Wages of young people in Britain rose 83% in the 1950s. How nice

that would be today. But so here are young people with a lot more money in their pockets.

- 7.59** More education, both secondary and tertiary. More rights and opportunities for women. Some historians suggest that women were really the leaders of the youth revolt, if revolt is what it was, at least the change in youth culture. Part of this is the increasing availability of contraception. And then we have American cultural influences like jazz and rock, which are a way of breaking away from European cultural traditions. And of course, we have television and radio. And finally, I would say we have global radicalism, the Cold War itself, with revolutions in China, Cuba, Vietnam, Cambodia, the radicalization caused by the Vietnam War, and the left-wing terrorism that I mentioned in Italy and Germany. So a sense that the world was changing, a sense that you could be part of this global radical movement.
- 7.60** One historian said that the generation growing up in the 1960s was probably more unlike its parents' generation than any other generation in history, which I think is worth thinking about. I'm using England as an example, and these are some of the external examples of what was changing. Decline in religious observance was very steep after 1956. That includes things like attending church on Sunday, getting married in church, having children baptized in church. All those things suddenly start to drop. Divorce tripled in 10 years and, consequently, one-parent families greatly increased.
- 7.61** Crime also increased. In 1957, there were only 1,200 robberies in the whole of England. Seems like another age. By 1977, there were 14,000. Sexual freedom hugely expanded, both in reality and in books, films, stage performances. Famous example in England was that D. H. Lawrence's novel, *Lady Chatterley's Lover*, was prosecuted for obscenity, and it was a big cause célèbre, and eventually it was found not to be obscene. Public—sorry, not public—capital punishment, hanging, was abolished in 1969. Homosexuality was decriminalized in 1966. Theater censorship was abolished in 1968. An awful lot is happening in just a few years.
- 7.62** It is, in fact, the end of an old society which was much more conformist, much more disciplined, much more patriarchal, if you like that word. This was falling away very quickly. This is the same throughout Europe. Things that were happening elsewhere in Europe, which were not so relevant to Britain, is that the old communist left went into steady decline. It was very powerful in Italy and France, and it was replaced by various new left-wing movements. The old authoritarian right, based on religion, social conservatism, and authoritarianism, also lost power all over southern Europe. After all, Portugal, Spain, and Greece were all dictatorships until this period.
- 7.63** And of course, the most important change of all was the final defeat of Soviet communism and the collapse of its East European empire. I looked at the abolition of the death penalty to show as a sign of liberalization. It was abolished in Belgium in 1950, in the UK in 1969, in Greece in 1975, in Spain in 1978, in France in 1981, and has now more or less disappeared all across Europe. So this is the period of change.

Legislation of the contraceptive pill, UK, 1961, France, 1967, Italy, 1971, Ireland, 1980. So a single generation, really.

- 7.64 But even more important, the defeat of the Soviet Empire and its collapse. In retrospect, you might say the Soviet system seemed doomed. Hindsight is a wonderful thing, but hardly anyone thought this at the time. Not politicians, not Western intelligence services, not diplomats. They thought the Soviet system was too strong and would persist. And yet, as we know, it collapsed very quickly. And we know now that there was, under the surface, a general failure, economic, cultural, and political. And I would say these are the symptoms of it. The younger generation in Eastern Europe had long abandoned communism.
- 7.65 I remember a Russian friend of mine telling me that when she'd been at university, somebody said to her, "Why don't you join the party?" But she said, "I don't really want to." The answer was, "Yes, but it's going to be good for your career." But by that time, there was no sense that becoming a communist was a sign of some great political commitment to a future utopian world. It was just a way of getting on and protecting yourself, doing yourself a bit of good. So it was hollowed out, really, and had lost any sense of purpose.
- 7.66 The system had few defenders and had become largely a careerist bureaucratic structure of the sort that, as we now know, was producing Vladimir Putin and his various acolytes. Its economy was founded largely on rusting industries and on oil. It was not innovating, it was not producing enough, and it was marked by huge waste and inefficiency and constant shortages in the shops, as you were saying earlier.
- 7.67 When I first went, in fact, the only time I've ever been to what was then Czechoslovakia, at the tail end of communism, the only thing you could see in the shops were tins of sardines and cloves of garlic. Little pyramids of tins of sardines. And I remember we thought, "Well, we're not going to be able to get anything to eat here. We'll have to go back to Vienna to find some dinner." In the end, we managed to survive. But you realize that people were living in a state of constant penury. And whenever there was anything available, queues would immediately form because you had to queue up to get whatever it was that was going. You couldn't rely on there being adequate supplies of anything.
- 7.68 Russia's global power was costing it too much. It was having to compete with America in producing arms technology. It was subsidizing communist regimes. It was helping to support communism all around the world, and it just couldn't afford it. Its own people were losing too much. And finally, the coup de grâce is that dissident movements were growing in Eastern Europe during the 1980s, which formed an invincible combination of workers, students, the churches, and intellectuals. And these could not all be suppressed, and these began to force political change.

- 7.69 And it first of all happened in Poland, with strikes in the shipyards at Gdańsk, in fact, largely at first about the standards of living, wages and costs, but became built into a demand for political liberty, for representation, for democratic government. In 1985, Mikhail Gorbachev was appointed Soviet leader with the aim of reforming the communist system by a modest degree of liberalization and modernization. But this set off a collapse. More than a century earlier, the French political philosopher, Alexis de Tocqueville, had pointed out that the most dangerous moment for any authoritarian system is when it starts to try to reform itself.
- 7.70 And what happened in Russia was that people who had feared the results of opposing the system suddenly realized that it was not so frightening after all. And when Gorbachev declared in October 1989 that the USSR would no longer intervene militarily in other countries, as they had done in '68 in Czechoslovakia and '56 in Hungary, then the whole Soviet Empire rapidly imploded, and a great popular movement, simply to cross borders, brought down the system, and everyone realized that it could not be put back together again.
- 7.71 And the great symbolic moment came with the fall of the Berlin Wall only two weeks after Gorbachev had made his statement. And so, post-war Europe, I think one could say, came to a sudden end. But this was not the end of history. The American political scientist, Francis Fukuyama, wrote a famous essay, written in 1989 and turned into a book in 1992, called *The End of History and the Last Man*. And he concluded that the end of the Cold War meant the endpoint, and this is a quotation, "the endpoint of mankind's ideological evolution and the universalization of Western liberal democracy as the final form of human government."
- 7.72 The final form of human government. If this had happened, it would have meant, I suppose, the victory of European culture, the global victory of European culture, and finally, the victory of the Enlightenment, the sort of society that people like Adam Smith had wanted. But as we know, this is not what was going to happen. The emergence of new religious and ideological clashes of civilizations mean that Europe and its offshoots are no longer setting the course of human history, as it briefly seemed they were, and that the Enlightenment itself is increasingly challenged and disavowed, including by many European intellectuals. And I'm going to return to this in my final lecture, which will be on European integration.
- 7.73 I'm curious to what do you attribute the current popularity that Marxist thought enjoys in Western academia?
- 7.74 Well, until you were talking earlier, I hadn't really realized that it was—I mean, people sometimes talk about cultural Marxism, which is what is popularly called woke, wokeness. And there is, I know, a widespread belief that this is a form of Marxism. And I guess there are connections. If you think that Marx was correct in predicting that capitalism would finally be destroyed by its own internal contradictions, or if you think that Lenin was right, that the only thing that was keeping the capitalism going was the

exploitation of the rest of the world, then you could see some of the themes of post-colonialism, wokeness, as being linked with Marxism, which I think they are.

- 7.75** But I think there are other strands, too, which I think are quite different. First of all, I think Marxism, whether you think it was, how useful you think it is as a description of history, was at least a coherent system. I mean, it was very thoroughly worked out by Marx himself and many others, whereas much of contemporary ideologies seem to me pretty chaotic and intellectually weak.
- 7.76** But I think that there are other strands in it, of which postmodernism and the questioning of any objective reality, and the assertion that the world is—that the only reality that we can have is what we can express in words. That therefore language is the only reality and that different forms of language are different forms of exerting power, which is maybe slightly true, partly true, has very little to do with Marxism in its classical form.
- 7.77** I think originally, postmodernism was also an enemy of, or at least was highly subversive of, Marxism. Because if postmodernism is saying all these things that people are telling us are true are not true—they're just discourses, they're just forms of words, they're just collections of ideas, they're not true—then Marxism, too, is not true. It's just another ideology, another grand narrative. And indeed, I thought at the time that this was largely what postmodernism was going to be about. It was going to be demolishing things like Marxism.
- 7.78** But certainly, Marxism has, to some extent, survived and been incorporated into or has incorporated postmodernist thinking in a rather incoherent way, it seems to me. But the thing that they have in common is, I suppose, the desire to subvert the Western system and to blame all the ills of the world on capitalism, essentially that. OK, Marx didn't talk much about empire. In fact, he rather approved of it. In fact, he explicitly approved of it. He thought this was a way of spreading modernity. But it was Lenin who blamed imperial exploitation for propping up the capitalist system. We might say a bit more about that later, maybe. I think that's the best I can do. But it's a very complex question, I think.
- 7.79** It's more or less a very simple question, but I know you talked about—
- 7.80** Good.
- 7.81** I know you talked about this a while ago very briefly, but I was wondering if you could share a little bit more details about the atrocities of the Russian gulag. Maybe why was it established in the first place? How was it able to function? And what was it—what were some of the things that were happening inside it? I know you mentioned a book called *The Gulag Archipelago*. So maybe you could use some of the knowledge that you gained from that book in terms of answering this question.

- 7.82 Yeah, OK. Well, I'll do my best. It was a very large, a very, very large system. We're talking about a system of prison camps, which at its height contained many millions of people. It was partly, well, I suppose it's essentially because Bolshevism, Russian communism, was based on the idea of class war, and in Lenin's view, a ruthless class war that was aimed at the destruction of the class enemy, and therefore any social group that would be the class enemy, and you were talking about this earlier, which would not only be the aristocracy, the bourgeoisie, but also wealthier peasants, small peasant landowners even, could be regarded as the class enemy.
- 7.83 And that meant that many millions of people were regarded as enemies of the revolution, enemies of the state. And this meant mass repression. It often meant mass killing. But if not killing, it meant sending large numbers of people into exile or indeed in turning them in prison camps. The camps themselves were also used as a source of labor, of slave labor. So the most famous, I suppose, is the building of the White Sea canal, in which political prisoners were used as labor in building this canal. Very large numbers of them died because they were regarded as expendable. If they died, well, fine. After all, they're the enemies of the revolution. Therefore, death is what they deserve.
- 7.84 But they could, meanwhile, be used as a source of cheap labor. And many of the Russian camps were set up, at least in theory, as labor camps. It could be that they were doing forestry, they were building roads, they were building railways, they were building canals and so on. But the way it was done was certainly not one that was aimed at efficient use of labor. It was aimed at punishment, at the creation of terror, and eventually the death of many of the prisoners. So there were various levels of camp in which some were regarded as more punitive than others.
- 7.85 If you're being sent to a labor camp well to the north of the Arctic circle and you were being fed very little, you would have very little protective clothing, you'd be working outside in sub-zero temperatures, then you would know and your captors would know that you would not live long and you were not expected to live long. The difference between the gulag and the German system is that the gulag was not explicitly an extermination system. It did kill very many people, but it did not have the machinery of mass killing that the Nazi system had in places like Auschwitz.
- 7.86 So you could survive a Russian camp. If you were a Jew in Auschwitz, you would not survive and you were not intended to survive. You might be used as a slave laborer for a brief period, but death would be the final end. You could survive a camp. And if you were not in the most severe camp, you might survive even for years. The book I mentioned, Solzhenitsyn's book, *One Day in the Life of Ivan Denisovich*, is quite moving. He ends up by saying, he's describing his whole day in the camp, and he says, "I've had a good day. I got an extra helping of soup. I didn't get beaten up. I wasn't sent on one of the worst work assignments, so I wasn't injured. I managed to get a bunk with an

extra blanket, so I didn't freeze to death. So today was a good day." And that was what it was like.

Lecture 8: Efforts Toward Unity

At a glance — Efforts toward unity.

- 8.1** Right, we've arrived at the last lecture of what seems like a rather epic cycle. And I want to thank you, first of all, for having been such a wonderful and engaging and interested audience. Without you, I would not have been able to do this. And now we arrive at the endpoint, which is on European Unity: Community of Destiny or Grand Illusion, I'm calling it. I began my first lecture, you may remember, by reflecting briefly on what Europe was, a geographical area, a civilization, a motor of world history, or what? Some people now think we've found an answer.
- 8.2** According to a very recent European Union report entitled European Historical Consciousness, I quote, "Historically speaking, we should not consider Europe as a homogenous civilization and geopolitical space. The European Union is a community of destiny (Schicksalsgemeinschaft), and it should be understood as such and not as a community of one shared collective memory. This is how the historical journey of Europeans needs to be seen." If I understand this correctly, and I'm not sure I do, it sees Europe as leaving something behind, a dark history of totalitarianism, racism, conflict, and colonialism, and becoming something new. Europe's historical journey is still going on towards its destiny.
- 8.3** The idea of a united Europe, even of a United States of Europe, has been around for a long time. It's been called the last Enlightenment grand narrative. The Anglo-French Commercial Treaty of 1860 began what has been called the first common market. Victor Hugo, whom we were talking about earlier, in 1867, advocated European unity with Paris as its capital, of course. In the 1920s, there were many intellectual supporters of European unity. And in 1930, one of the leading prophets of European unity suggested asking Adolf Hitler and Neville Chamberlain to get together to proclaim a European Federation, which certainly shows a remarkable degree of optimism.
- 8.4** The French Foreign Minister, Aristide Briand, proposed in 1929 -1930 a European Federation based on Franco-German reconciliation. I think the idea of European unity has always been, at least for its visionaries, an escape, an escape from danger, and also an escape from history. Yet at the same time, it has, and perhaps this is a contradiction, been seen as the embodiment of a great and unique heritage of European values, which the same EU document that I mentioned earlier lists as including humanism, tolerance, democracy, and the rule of law. Those are the European values. You might say they are a lot of people's values.
- 8.5** I think we can see in the history of European integration a mixture of realism and idealism, with idealism providing the public justification for realism. The realism lay in a desire to protect some states from others and to avoid war. The photograph here is of President François Mitterrand and Chancellor Helmut Kohl standing together holding

hands at Verdun, as a symbol of Franco-German reconciliation. So that was a major desire, and certainly a major stated desire was to avoid Europe descending once again into war, especially a Franco-German war.

- 8.6** But behind the idealism was also a desire to win national advantages for each individual state, and that, I think, remains. As a leading historian of European integration put it, "To the French, it was a flag of convenience. To the Italians, it was preferable by definition to government by Rome. To the Germans, a welcome escape route. And to the Benelux nations, a better choice than being dominated by powerful neighbors." So it began very practically in 1950 as a coal and steel community, to manage economic recovery and control strategic industries. No coal, no steel, no war.
- 8.7** But there was even then a hint of greater future union, and the coal and steel community developed into the European Economic Community by the 1957 Treaty of Rome. How do we explain the progress so far? Well, I think I would say, a postwar reaction against nationalism, political extremism, and war; a need to recover from economic devastation; fear of Russia and communism; American pressure—the Americans have always been keen, and perhaps keener than anyone else, on European integration; the need for a new ideal and to leave dark history behind; and then finally, as I said, individual national motives, too.
- 8.8** But Britain and several other Western countries did not at first join. But worries about decline caused Britain to apply for admission in 1961 and actually to join in 1973. Although probably the least enthusiastic about the project of ever closer union contained in the Treaty of Rome, Britain did play a considerable role. But why did it hesitate and why did it change its mind? Many people believe that Britain, and this had been believed by many exponents of European unity in previous decades, that Britain was much too connected with the rest of the world, particularly through the Empire, to be considered a European country.
- 8.9** What changed, of course, was decolonization, and then the worry of many British politicians that Britain was falling behind economically and risked being marginalized and becoming merely a big Sweden, as one of them put it. And that's why they asked to join in 1961. The delay between '61 and '73 was caused by the French President, Charles de Gaulle, General de Gaulle, who basically said that Britain should not be allowed to join because it was not sufficiently European. It had too many connections with the rest of the world, which was, as I suggested a moment ago, a fairly widely shared view in earlier decades.
- 8.10** But although Britain was never very enthusiastic about ever -closer union, it did play quite a considerable role during its membership in the development of the community. Under Margaret Thatcher, Prime Minister, 1975 to 1990, Britain pressed to extend the free market, culminating in the single European Act of 1986, which establishes the single market. But then Thatcher turned against further integration because the EU, in her view, was going too far in pursuing interventionist policies. But then under Tony

Blair, her successor, who was Prime Minister from 1997 to 2007, Britain supported extension of the European Community to include the newly liberated states of Eastern Europe.

- 8.11 And Britain was the first, or among the first, to allow complete freedom of movement of East Europeans, which the Germans and the French did not at first permit, though the large scale of this movement did later fuel Euroskepticism in Britain. So Britain had quite an important influence on the way the European Community developed, but it was rarely able to direct European policy, not least because most of its people and many of its politicians were reluctant to press ahead with ever greater union. And so it was France and Germany that pushed Europe towards greater unification.
- 8.12 How did this happen? Well, first, it was given a boost by the fall of the Berlin Wall and the coming reunification of Germany, which seemed inevitably going to make Germany the most important, certainly economically the most important, European state. And as a condition of supporting that reunification, the French insisted that Germany should commit itself to what was officially called Economic and Monetary Union. And the clear intention was of restraining German European, sorry, German economic and financial power. Germany was going to be very powerful. Therefore, you needed to enmesh Germany in a whole European system, which would prevent Germany from using its power for potentially dangerous and selfish reasons.
- 8.13 So that was Economic and Monetary Union, essentially a French idea. And it included a single currency, the Euro, which was adopted in 1999. A number of economists warned of the dangers of this step, on the grounds that the European Community was not an ideal currency area because different parts of the community had very different levels of economic efficiency, standards of living, economic performance. And you could only bring them under a single currency if you adopted a single European fiscal and financial system.
- 8.14 In other words, if Europe was going to be more like the United States of America, with using the equivalent of the dollar, then you would have to have a system as in the United States by which richer states would be willing to subsidize the welfare costs of smaller states, so that states like California will, where necessary, transfer wealth to states like Alabama. But if that doesn't happen, the single currency would be likely to increase economic differences between different parts of the community.
- 8.15 And that indeed is precisely what has happened. A single currency has not been accompanied by a single fiscal policy. And so the Euro's had very damaging effects on some countries, notably Italy and Greece. Italy has had no economic growth since the Euro was adopted. No significant economic growth. But the main aim of the Euro was not financial or economic, but political—to limit the independence of member countries, especially Germany, and to hold the European Union together, as there is no clear route out of the Eurozone once you're in it. Significantly, several member countries, and most importantly, Britain, did not join the Euro.

- 8.16** European integration has significantly fluctuated in popularity. It reached its high point in the 1990s in the run-up to the adoption of the Euro and has tended to decline since then and especially so since the 2008 financial crisis. But even before that, both France and Holland voted no in referendums in 2005 on a proposed European Constitution to create a new European Union. But despite the failure to persuade the peoples of Europe to vote for this innovation, it was largely adopted anyway by treaty.
- 8.17** Madame Frau Merkel, the German Chancellor, said, in practice, the treaty includes everything that the Constitution would have contained, which is a sign that, whether you like the EU or not, it's a sign that those who run it do not allow public opinion to hold back the progress of the project. But although France and Holland, and indeed several other countries, have voted no in various referenda on European matters since 2005, only Britain actually voted to leave in 2016, which was undeniably a setback for the EU and arguably a setback for Britain, or so many people believe.
- 8.18** Why did this happen? How can we explain it? I think it's fairly easy to understand. First of all, a less traumatic experience of the 20th century. Britain did not experience any of the terrible trauma such as revolution, defeat in war, foreign occupation, revolution, mass violence that has been the sad lot of many continental European countries. Indeed, it was victorious in the Second World War, of course, and therefore, came out of the war with a sense of pride and of enhanced independence. Also, as General de Gaulle said, it has greater global connections and stronger ties with the Commonwealth countries, the USA, and the Anglosphere, generally.
- 8.19** And it's been reluctant to give power to unaccountable central institutions. Indeed, you might say that the British public tends to be rather suspicious of politicians in the state in any case, and even more suspicious of foreign politicians and foreign institutions. And then finally, I would say the crucial step was that it did not adopt the Euro. Had Britain been a member of the Eurozone, I don't believe it would have voted to leave in 2016, however much its people might grumble about the EU.
- 8.20** Compared with Britain, how would we sum up the other EU states? Well, of course, a 20th century much more marked by traumatic experiences, and hence the EU is seen as a way out of these, the way of beginning a more, a safer and more optimistic future. Arguably a stronger sense of European identity, fewer connections with the outside world. In some cases, weaker democratic traditions, I suppose. After all, several EU member states are quite recent democracies. And finally, membership of the Eurozone, which I think, as I say, is crucial. Once you're in, you can't really get out.
- 8.21** I'm not going to say a lot about Brexit, but it is, after all, one of the most important episodes in the history of European integration of the last few years, so I don't want to pass it over entirely. I've tried to explain why it happened, which I don't think is too difficult. Much more difficult is to say what the consequences are, because these are still being debated and indeed are still uncertain. And under a Labour government, which is quite likely in the next few months, would become more uncertain still.

- 8.22** But let's look at some of the results for Britain. First of all, serious economic damage was predicted as a consequence of Brexit, and this has certainly not happened. Political marginalization was predicted, and yet Britain has played a stronger role over Ukraine and in the Pacific and even in the Middle East. On the other hand, Britain has not taken back control of its borders, which was one of the main demands of the Leave campaign. Northern Ireland has become semi-detached from the rest of the United Kingdom. Trading benefits are still uncertain, though there are certain encouraging developments, such as being ready to sign the Trans-Pacific Partnership.
- 8.23** I think most serious of all, political fallout is continuing with government instability since the Brexit vote, of a kind that's very unusual in British history and with deep political divisions still continuing. Which I think have tended to become confused with or identified with other aspects of the culture wars. It's still uncertain whether Britain will drift back towards effective alignment with the EU, making Brexit, in effect, meaningless.
- 8.24** One political scientist has talked of the difference between being a nation-state and a member-state. In a nation-state, governments draw their legitimacy from their electors. In a member-state, they draw their legitimacy from other governments who are in the organization. It's still unclear whether Britain will succeed in changing itself from being a member-state back into a nation-state.
- 8.25** What about the consequences of Brexit for the EU? Well, the original fear that other countries might follow Britain's example has, of course, not happened. On the contrary, Britain's very public difficulties have weakened such tendencies and have tended to weaken Euroskepticism throughout the community. Interestingly, although Euroskeptic parties have expanded now in several countries—France, the Netherlands, Poland, Hungary—they don't talk about leaving the EU. They talk about changing it from within or resisting its authority, but not from actually leaving it.
- 8.26** Second point, without Britain, it's possible in theory that the EU will become more integrated. After all, Britain was the main break on integration. Without Britain, there's nothing in principle to stop integration from advancing faster, but the opposite has happened with political, social, and economic differences increasing between the northern and southern member-states and the eastern and western states.
- 8.27** In international terms, the EU has proved pretty well absent in the Ukrainian crisis and in the Middle Eastern crises. And this may partly be due to Britain's exit, as Britain is arguably the strongest military and diplomatic state in Europe—Europe's last great power, as one historian puts it, which doesn't actually say very much for the others when you think how relatively weak Britain is, too. But nevertheless, it may be that Britain's departure makes Europe less consequent as a force in the world.
- 8.28** So, questions remain for Europe, as well as for Britain. And I would say that they're these. Is Europe inevitably in economic and political decline? It appears that it is. What

can be done to reverse such a decline? Secondly, is there really a European people, or a demos, as it's often called? Can you have a democracy without a demos? And is there really a European people or lots of different European peoples? Third, is the EU doomed to fragmentation or instead to non-democratic government? One historian has said Europe's now governed not by its principles or by its people, but by its bank board. The board of the European Central Bank seems to be the main focus of power. And is Europe still composed of nation-states or only of member -states?

- 8.29** Fourth question, has today's Europe any genuinely shared values? And if so, is it capable of defending them? Fifth question, is it capable of responding to migration pressures, to economic stagnation, and to political disaffection? Who or what is capable of taking control of these problems and resolving them? And I suppose, final question, is there really a thing called Europe? Has there ever been? Historians rightly refuse to predict the future. We know that there are too many uncertainties and that even what may seem likely now is subject to unexpected events, often on the other side of the world. So I ask these questions and I won't attempt to answer them.
- 8.30** Instead of crystal-gazing, I want for the rest of this lecture to try to draw some conclusions and discuss the controversies about Europe that have become pressing in recent years. These controversies, to some degree, affect the wider world as questions about Europe often really apply to the whole of the Western world and raise the question as to whether the rest of the world should deliberately reject European ideas and models, as some people say. There is, after all, maybe an Asian model, a Chinese model, an African model, and not simply a European model to be copied and universalized.
- 8.31** So these are some of my conclusions. And I want to summarize, first of all, the story as I've tried to tell it. From my starting point in 1688, at least until 1914, and perhaps until the Second World War, Europe's history seemed to be that of modernity. Europe defined supposedly universal values, the Enlightenment ideas, ideas about economic growth, about liberal democracy, and hence, even in, as late as 1989, Fukuyama could suggest that the end of the Cold War was the end of history.
- 8.32** This European model of modernity spread partly by example, partly by compulsion. Europe's empires span the globe, and much of the globe, therefore, ended by adopting, at least for a time, European political, economic, and legal ideas. Two world wars destroyed Europe's supremacy, political and economic, and the two superpowers, the USA and the USSR, took the lead. Totalitarianism and genocide destroyed, or perhaps should have destroyed, Europe's sense of superiority. "To write poetry after Auschwitz is barbaric," as Adorno said; I quoted him before.
- 8.33** Worse still, some influential intellectuals argued, and today argue perhaps more than ever, that the horrors of totalitarianism and other horrors in the modern world were not Europe betraying its civilization, but were in fact a result of that civilization, a result of Enlightenment ideas and of European modernity—in brief, many would say, the

willingness to use ideology to impose a violent utopia. Was Stalin the heir of Robespierre and Rousseau? And was it really the Enlightenment's focus on rationalism and calculation, as some have said, that set Europe on the road to Auschwitz?

- 8.34** Today, it's more commonly colonialism that is seen as Europe's great crime, and it's colonialism which is said to tarnish all its intellectual, cultural, and scientific achievements. Hence, demands for decolonization are really a disavowal of European culture and history. In either case, it seems to me that it's the modern world that is the target of these critiques of Europe, and it's that perhaps that links it to an older tradition of Marxism. Because as the leading critic Michel Foucault has put it, I quote, "The Enlightenment has determined, at least in part, what we are, what we think, and what we do today."
- 8.35** Let me repeat that. "The Enlightenment has determined, at least in part, what we are, what we think, and what we do today." So if we don't like what is being done today, we can blame it on the Enlightenment as the root cause. I've quoted before from the statement in the Pitt Rivers Museum in Oxford, but it's so good, I want to just quote it again to remind you. "Colonialism seeks to overwrite existing cultural systems in the belief that colonial cultures are superior. The cultural systems that often get imposed are capitalism, communism, religion, scientific logic, racism, patriarchy, and gender binary."
- 8.36** That's a succinct statement of what has now become a fashionable orthodoxy, which is why I've quoted it. Now, I've said already why I think it is in places silly and in places offensive. It casts non-Europeans as either helpless victims or dupes. And as they seem to be unable to throw off the effects on them of colonialism, often a very short period, one might conclude that they're pretty useless, if one takes that view. I went to India a few years ago and saw a little notice about the pet tortoise of Lord Clive, Robert Clive, the great East India Company soldier who conquered Bengal and much of Eastern India, and he had a pet tortoise. Well, the tortoise lived until the 1950s, and it occurred to me that Clive's tortoise actually lived longer than Clive's empire.
- 8.37** So we have to realize that European empires were actually quite short, and some of them were very short indeed, only a few years, less than a single generation. So is it really true that they left an indelible print on the world, that decolonized peoples are unable to throw off without our help? Another thing that seems to me strange is that this obsession with decolonization and colonality exposes European history and culture to a hostile scrutiny that would seem absurd or offensive if applied anywhere else.
- 8.38** Imagine arguing that Asian culture should be rejected because of Japanese atrocities in the Nanking massacre in 1937, because of Chinese mass starvation under Mao in the '50s and '60s, or the horrors of the Cambodian genocide in the 1970s. What is it about Asian culture that has caused all these horrors? Should we not be thinking how Asian culture should be deconstructed and dismantled? Or Africa. Surely there's something wrong with African culture, if Africans for centuries were willing to sell other Africans

into slavery, were willing to sacrifice human beings, and still want to continue genital mutilation of young girls. Is there not something wrong with Africa and African culture?

- 8.39** Of course, we don't say those things, and to say them sounds ridiculous, but we do say them, or some people say them, about European culture and European history. I would say that that shows that the decolonization vogue is political rather than truly intellectual or historical. Moreover, it's based on blatant double standards, as I've said. Is the attempt to impose modern Western progressive ideas on parts of Africa and on Arab cultures not another form of coloniality? Yet in this case, practiced by those who criticize, in principle, the colonialist legacy.
- 8.40** Double standards are found in historical approaches. In many recent histories of empire, the same episodes are almost certain to recur. They're selected as being somehow the norm, but acts of violence are shown as being somehow representative of the whole history. But what about the opposite? What about peacekeeping? What about economic development? What about the care shown for indigenous cultures? What about education and medical advances, and indeed, the scientific logic distasteful apparently to the Pitt Rivers Museum?
- 8.41** Honest history, indeed meaningful history, must try to take in the whole of what it is studying, including the context of its times. Even if, to take the most extreme case of evil in modern history, we study the Holocaust, it would not be enough simply to say that it drew on Enlightenment ideas of the modern state, or on Romantic ideas of the nation, or Darwinian ideas of evolution. That would not be a sufficient explanation. You would also have to take account of the state of Germany into war, of a deeply rooted tradition of anti-Semitism, of the dynamics of the Nazi state and much else. And it would be similarly absurd to base Stalin's purges on Jean-Jacques Rousseau.
- 8.42** It was recently stated in a recent conference in Cambridge that, I quote, "the British Empire was far worse than the Nazis. It lasted far longer. It killed far more people. And in fact, in many ways, the Nazis were copying large elements of the British Empire." If there are any rational purposes in making such comments, as opposed to pure provocation, perhaps they are intended to create division and to make a reasonable history of empire impossible.
- 8.43** If we are to have, I should say, if we are to have again, reasonable and serious appraisals of Europe's history, including its colonial influence, we would need not only to include violence, but also peace; not just famine, but the end of famine; not just the dispossession of people, but also their protection; and to recognize that many of those ruled by Europeans accepted their rule as better than what had proceeded.
- 8.44** We've seen this in recent months with democratic campaigners in Hong Kong, waving the Union Jack. Does this sort of thing matter? I think it does. Across the English-speaking world, and continental Europe may not be far behind, we see a comprehensive attack on European and Western history as essentially destructive and

malign. And this view is increasingly found in schools, universities, museums, and other cultural institutions.

- 8.45** There are at least two damaging results. First, as the distinguished judge and historian Lord Sumption has put it recently, I quote, "It can only fragment our society, obstruct the integration of minorities, and undermine any sense of community." I think one would have to conclude that those are the intentions. The intentions are to fragment society, to obstruct the integration of minorities, and to undermine a sense of community. That is why these things are being said.
- 8.46** And the second damaging consequence, it seems to me, is that if we are to weaken and undermine European ideas and values, however imperfect and at times damaging they certainly have been, they are, after all, the best we have managed as the result of centuries of effort, and we ought to at least ask what is likely to replace them, both in our own societies and in the wider world.
- 8.47** In our own societies, it seems to me it would probably be a nihilistic vacuum in which all historical traditions and values are renounced. In the wider world, it would seem more likely to be the encouragement of ruthless conflict, criminality, and war. It's interesting that the Russian foreign ministry recently expressed its support of decolonization, which it said would be very useful diplomatically.
- 8.48** I'm going to end by quoting a journalist, which I don't think I've done very much so far, a journalist called Matthew Syed, who wrote very recently in the Sunday Times, in fact, on the 28th of January, 2024. He said, "We've spent an inordinate amount of time trashing our own nations and histories, which would have been fine if the debate had been conducted with nuance and wisdom. But the cartoon indictments of the West rarely take account of what we might call the plausible counterfactual. How would the world have looked if the Islamists, Bolsheviks, or genocide Chinese Communist Party had been in charge?" We could add, of course, what if the Nazis had won? "The West, in this context," says Syed, "can be seen as the world's greatest blessing, not its greatest curse."
- 8.49** I think I might say it's closer to being a blessing than a curse. In some ways it's been a blessing, and I don't deny that in some ways it's been a curse to some people. But I think that can be said of all civilizations and all states in history. So to finish, I would say, and this is definitely my very last words, we should not be afraid of historical truth. We should not deny the possibility of arriving at historical truths and accuracy. And this includes certainly facing up to terrible events in European history. And I've given quite a lot of harrowing details of many of them.
- 8.50** But to treat that history as wholly negative, now to be disavowed by cultural decolonization, is a gross distortion and intellectually dishonest, and no good purpose is served by it. And with that, I shall end. And thank you again. Thank you again for your

remarkable and sustained attention and engagement. If there are any questions, I'll be very happy to try to answer them.

- 8.51** Thank you for all your words and your wisdom. The questions about decolonization. I lived with a Salesian of John Bosco, who was a missionary from the Congo, and he said that it seemed like also the pervasive opinion of his countrymen, that the countries on the African continent that used to be British colonies were doing much better than all the other former colonial countries. Do you think there's some truth to that? And if so, why?
- 8.52** I suppose we'd have to go through the list of them, wouldn't we? I don't think—I think Africa has been through a pretty terrible ordeal over the last half century and more. I think you'd have to say that some parts of Africa have certainly been more successful than others in maintaining the prosperity and the flourishing of their peoples. And certainly some of these—you might think of Kenya, you might think of Nigeria, to some extent—were formerly parts of the British Empire. To some extent, you can say, well, the British did try to set up systems of government that would outlive them and which would permit African countries to prosper after independence.
- 8.53** But then some Portuguese colonies—I think that may well be true of parts of what were once Portuguese. Senegal, I think, which was French, is also like that. I think a lot depends. Here, some people put the blame on the empire builders, on what the colonies actually—I mean, Lord Salisbury said, "We're drawing lines on maps where no white man's foot has ever trod." Sometimes colonies were turned out, and Nigeria is one example, to be made of very diverse peoples, and it makes it very difficult to run a democracy where there is no single sense of solidarity. There may be religious differences, as well as cultural differences.
- 8.54** I think someone from Mali once said to me, "Well, we have 400 languages in Mali." It's very difficult to run that kind of state. You might say, well, if there had never been any attempt to create a state, what would have happened then? Well, the answer is, very probably, you would have had perhaps a higher level of conflict between these ethnic groups, as happened often before them, before colonization. But I think probably those countries which have done best are those which were not too big, which were fairly ethnically homogeneous.
- 8.55** And probably, I mean, there's a theory you may know, probably those which have not been over-endowed with natural resources. There's now, I think, a very well-established theory that says the problem with countries that have a lot of natural wealth, such as oil, is that the government doesn't need the support of its people because it gets money from selling resources to foreigners. Therefore, it has a flow of—a very large, often, flow of income, which means it can exist as a state and as a government without its people having to contribute very much. This tends to create dictatorial systems and often corrupt systems.

- 8.56** So it's probably better for you if you live in a state where there's not too much oil, not too much gold, not too many diamonds, and therefore you're going to be left alone by the rest of the world and not ruled by a bunch of crooks who are mainly in it for what they can get out of it. I think those are the countries that are most likely to be successful, though to some extent they will rely on the institutions that were created by former colonial authorities, British and other. Sorry, that's a rather messy answer.
- 8.57** Some people say that we learn history for us to be able to learn from our past experiences and make sure these same mistakes won't happen in the future. But for the past eight lectures, you've mainly talked about a lot of revolutions, conflicts, and wars. Does that indicate that human, man, don't really — sorry, butchering it a little bit, but we don't really learn from our past? Do you think that is just human nature and an inevitable concept for us to be able to evolve and progress as a human race?
- 8.58** Well, I can't remember who said the only lesson that we learned from history is that we don't learn lessons from history. And I think, I'm afraid that seems to be true. And as you say, my lectures seem to show that, as do others. I think what we can learn from history is, at least, it can help us to think about our own situation. That's one thing. We can say, and I've done this myself, "Are we facing a situation a bit like people faced in the 1930s? How did they respond? And is there a way in which we can think that we ought to respond differently?" In other words, we can't learn direct lessons and say, "The lesson is this," but it can maybe concentrate our minds on our own problems.
- 8.59** But I think, other than that, I think a great value of history is to —and I read this recently from a student who said, "It helps us to recall lost ways of thinking." We should think of the past as giving us examples of how different people at different times lived and how they thought differently and they felt differently and they believed different things. And I guess this might make us relativize our own thoughts and think, well, maybe our way of looking at things is not the only way of looking at things.
- 8.60** And maybe it would make us a bit more humble, if we were to recognize that past generations often had successes with far fewer resources than we have. Whereas I think often a tendency is to say, the past was awful and aren't we wonderful? People often say it's incredible that something rather is happening in the 21st century, as if we're the only people who were ever civilized and that somehow it was OK if it was happening 200 years or 500 years ago. It's bad because it's happening in our time. Whereas often things, people 200 years ago or 500 years ago were often succeeding in lots of things in which we are not necessarily succeeding. So I think it ought to make us rather more humble and rather more willing to examine our own record.
- 8.61** And apart from that, I think, it's a bit, it seems to me traveling in time, which is what history is, is a bit like traveling. It's a bit like traveling the globe today. It brings you into contact with other peoples and other civilizations. And in that sense, I hope it expands our own understanding of what it is to be human, in the way that visiting a great temple in India or looking at the great wall of China or visiting a small village in Africa

might show us that there are other ways of living than ours. And I think that's —we ought to do that for history, too. But learning lessons, well, I think it doesn't teach us direct lessons, but it perhaps should teach us to be cautious and to be reflective and not to be too arrogant.

- 8.62** Do you think British and American bombing efforts might have been better to focus more on German industry, rather than carpet-bombing cities, and that that might have been more ethical? I think Speer said, in *Inside the Third Reich*, which is a worthwhile and easy-read book, that more resources should have been focused on the Dambusters Raid, for instance.
- 8.63** Well, yes, Speer, I think you have to be careful of. I don't think you can trust him very far. Well, yeah, it would have been ideal. In fact, they thought, you probably know this, at the beginning, they thought they could target small targets. After a few months, they did a survey and found that—I can't remember quite the figures of it, something like this—only 10% of bombers managed to drop a bomb within 10 miles of the target. Some bombers hit the wrong country, even. If you tried to do it by daylight, you got shot down. If you tried to do it by night, you couldn't see the target. The only things that they could hit were cities, as I said earlier.
- 8.64** I mean, later on, they got much more accurate, and then they did succeed in hitting some strategic targets. When you, in particular, developed ground-reading radar, that could mean that you could see exactly where you were, you could do it much better then. They developed pathfinding techniques, which would mean other aircraft dropping flares which would illuminate or mark targets that the other bombs would then aim at. They did certainly become more accurate, but nothing like as accurate as now, when you can take out a single building.
- 8.65** So I think the main answer is that it would have been very nice if they could have done it, but they couldn't really do it. The Americans did try to do it. The American air force began by saying, we're not going to do what the British do and fly at night and drop, carpet-bomb cities. We're going to fly by daylight because we have these super fortresses with lots and lots of guns, which can defend themselves against fighters, and which will bomb key targets like—the most famous one is probably the ball bearing factory at Schweinfurt.
- 8.66** Because if you don't have any ball bearings, you don't have any machinery that can go around. Blow up the German ball bearing factory, and their whole war economy will come to an end. But the trouble was, the Germans also knew that Schweinfurt was important. And so what you got was masses and masses of anti-aircraft guns defending these targets. And you found that your bombers were all being shot down and you were losing 30% or something like that of your crews in each attack. And in any case, it turned out often that you could pretty quickly repair the damage or else you could disperse the production.

8.67 So, you hit Schweinfurt once and the Germans say, OK, we'll have to move the machinery out to a dozen different places and they can't bomb them all. So, it really was only area bombing that proved in the end effective, because that was all you could do until you got laser -guided bombs and all that.